

starting out: the english

NEIL MCDONALD



EVERYMAN CHESS

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Introducción

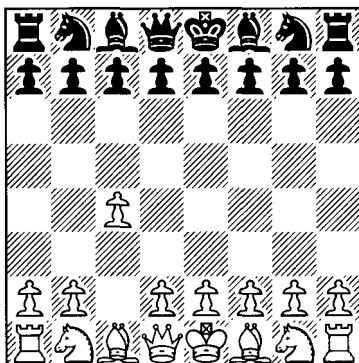


Diagrama 1
La apertura inglesa

La Apertura Inglesa es a veces descrita por sus detractores como una apertura negativa: es decir, en lugar de salir luchando con 1 e4 o 1 d4, las blancas se contentan con contener sus peones en el centro para formar una barrera inexpugnable contra la cual esperan que su oponente se destruya presionando demasiado. En otras palabras, piensan que las blancas tienen la solidez y las negras las posibilidades dinámicas.

Sin embargo, tal pensamiento equivale a malinterpretar la naturaleza del planteamiento de las blancas. No ha sacrificado la capacidad de jugar activamente fortaleciendo su centro: ¡es precisamente esta solidez la que hace posible un enfoque dinámico!

Una de las reglas de oro de la estrategia del ajedrez es que no debes iniciar un ataque en una de las alas a menos que tengas un centro seguro.

En la Apertura Inglesa, las blancas tienen la libertad de embarcarse en ataques laterales que serían demasiado arriesgados si hubieran jugado 1 e4 o 1 d4. En este libro verás muchos casos en los que las blancas pudieron iniciar un ataque emprendedor en el flanco de rey, a menudo comenzando con g2-g4. Blanco

también es capaz de lanzar un ataque audaz en el flanco de dama, moviendo todos sus peones hacia adelante; nuevamente, esto sólo es posible porque la situación en el centro es estable.

Por lo tanto, las blancas conservan un dinamismo y una flexibilidad considerables al contener sus peones centrales. Además, después de 1 d4 o 1 e4 podría haber un baño de sangre inmediato, en el que se intercambiarían todas las piezas y se produciría un empate. La Apertura Inglesa mantiene todas las piezas sobre el tablero: las negras no pueden reducir la tensión liquidando inmediatamente.

Esto significa que es una buena apertura en una situación en la que "debemos ganar". Tal vez recuerden que Kasparov eligió a los ingleses contra Karpov en la última partida de su match en Sevilla en 1987, que Kasparov tenía que ganar para empatar el match y conservar su título mundial. En esa partida, la presión a largo plazo resultó demasiado para Karpov.

Este libro busca explicar todas las ideas básicas detrás de la Apertura Inglesa tanto para blancas como para negras. Se examina cada sistema de defensa y de ataque y, cuando es necesario, se analizan las variaciones tácticas. He tratado de mantener este análisis al mínimo, pero a veces los principios generales tienen que dar paso a un examen detallado de lo que ha funcionado y lo que no en el pasado.

¡Te deseo la mejor de las suertes, ya sea probando la Apertura Inglesa con blancas o ganándola con negras!

Neil McDonald,
Gravesend, mayo
de 2003.

Orden de movimiento en inglés.

La inglesa es una apertura muy flexible. Por lo tanto, especialmente cuando se juega con negras, hay que ser consciente de las posibilidades de transposición a otras aperturas.



ADVERTENCIA: Como negras, ten cuidado de no caer en un 1 d4.
¡Apertura de la que no sabes nada!

Los jugadores blancos que normalmente juegan 1 d4 a veces lanzan una partida de 1 c4 y a menudo están felices de volver a transponer las líneas principales a 1 d4. Por ejemplo si respondes 1 c4 con L.c6 tienes que estar preparado para 2 d4, cuando 2... d5 (¿qué más?) es eslavo. O en el caso de 1 c4 e6, entonces 2 d4 limita sus opciones a un Gambito de Dama después de 2... d5, un Holandés después de 2... f5 o un Nimzo/India de Dama después de 2... Cf6 3 Cc3 Ab4 o 3 Cf3 b6. ¡Espero que juegues una de esas aperturas!

He aquí un truco útil con las blancas si estás contento enfrentándote a la India de Rey pero no a Griinfeld. Deberías jugarlo así: 1 c4 Cf6 2 Cc3 g6 3 e4! (Diagrama 2)

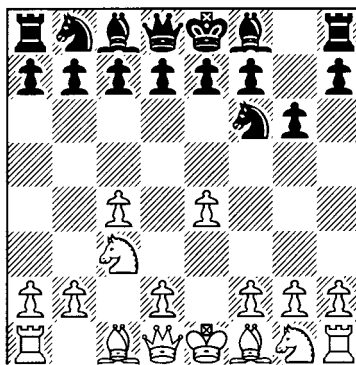


Diagrama 2

Truco anti-Grunfeld



Ahora después de 3...d6 4 d4 tenemos la línea principal del juego indio del Rey. Si el negro quería una posición tipo Griinfeld después de 1 c4 Nf6 2 Nc3 tuvo que jugar 2

TIP: Jugando 1 ... e5 o 1 ... c5 previene que Blanco cambie directamente a Apertura 1 d4

Si juegas L.e5 entonces el juego permanece como un inglés, aunque dependiendo de cómo responda Black, tendrá el sabor de un indio del Rey, Nimzo-India o Griinfeld. Lo mismo se puede decir sobre L.c5 - la única transposición notable aquí es a líneas de Hiedehog que más típicamente surgen de la línea principal siciliana. Estas líneas tienden a ser batallas posicional en las que el blanco intenta explotar su ventaja espacial: son completamente diferentes del dragón, por ejemplo, donde necesitas saber mucha teoría.

Como se verá, a la mejor opción de White para responder al primer movimiento de Black es elegir 2 Nc3, 2 Nf3 o incluso 2 g3. En general, 2 Nc3 es el movimiento más flexible ya que el caballo de reina está casi siempre mejor colocado en c3 donde aumenta la presión de White sobre la d5. A diferencia de esto, dependiendo de las circunstancias, a White le puede gustar jugar Nf3 o tal vez e2-e3 y luego desarrollar el caballo del rey a e2. Del mismo modo, el obispo en f1 podría ir a e2 o g2.

Las idiosincrasias del orden de movimiento en el inglés pueden ser confusas, lo que es una razón más por la cual debes comprender las ideas detrás de los movimien

Capítulo Uno

Inglés simétrico 1: Fiancetado del Rey de Black

No tex Introducción

Error El Negro Ocupa el Espacio en el Cent

No tex Negro defiende el cuadrado dS

Error Copias Negras con S ... Nf6

White Avoids Nf3



Introduction

The Symmetrical Variation begins 1 c4 c5. Black prevents White from playing 2 d4 and so ensures that the game stays in English Opening territory.

In this Chapter we look at lines where Black fianchettoes on g7. In Chapter Two Black avoids ...Bg7 in favour of immediate action in the centre and in Chapter Three we analyse the so called Hedgehog, which is characterised by Black setting up a mini centre with pawns on d6 and e6.



NOTE: The analysis in this chapter is mainly built around the position reached after 1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nc6 3 g3 g6 4 Bg2 Bg7 5 Nc3. Lines in which White prefers to delay Nf3 or play Nge2 are considered at the end of the chapter. Any early decision to break the symmetry by White or Black, such as 1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nc6 3 d4, is considered in the next chapter.

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3

White's choice of second move in the English can be of critical importance. It is worth remembering that lots of games begin with the Réti move order 1 Nf3, which means White has already committed his knight. The reason for 1 Nf3 is that White wants to rule out the Four Knights Variation beginning 1 c4 e5. On the other hand, playing 1 Nf3 takes away some flexibility from White's build-up.

For most of this chapter we assume play has began 1 c4 c5 2 Nf3, but in the final part we look at other methods for White. Elsewhere in the book 2 Nc3 is sometimes preferred, for example versus the King's Indian set-up and the Four Knights. And 2 g3!? also has its merits and is the move order suggested versus 1...c6 – see Chapter Eight.

2...Nc6

Black consistently strengthens his hold on the important d4-square.

3 g3

Meanwhile White aims his pieces at the d5-square.

3...g6

There is an endless number of different move orders in the English. If, for example, Black wants to launch a quick assault with ...d7-d5 he could play 3...Nf6 4 Nc3 d5 5 cxd5 Nxd5 here, which should soon transpose to the 5...Nf6 6 0-0 d5 line discussed later in this chapter.

4 Bg2 Bg7 5 Nc3 (Diagram 1)

Black can carry on copying White with 5...Nf6 or he can break the symmetry with either 5...e6 or 5...e5. We'll look at all three approaches in reverse order in this chapter.

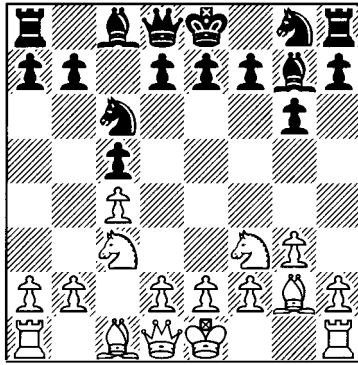


Diagram 1
Decision time

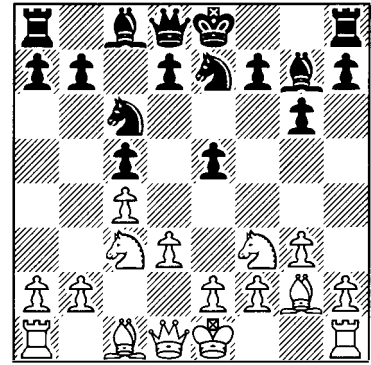


Diagram 2
The fight for the d5-square

Black Seizes Space in the Centre

5...e5!?

The first thing we notice about this move is that it leaves a hole in Black's pawn structure on d5.



NOTE: In chess terminology, a hole is a square of strategical importance in a player's pawn structure that can no longer be defended by a pawn.

Here Black has a hole on d5 as he can no longer bolster the square with ...c7-c6 or ...e7-e6. As this hole is right in the centre of the board and on the diagonal of the bishop on g2, it seems a serious concession. It would be a dream outpost for a white knight, while a bishop can exert pressure from a distance – for instance the bishop can target b7 whether it is sitting on g2 or d5, whereas a knight acts at shorter range and so is particularly effective on a centre square where it is free from attack by enemy pawns.

So why does Black create a weakness on d5? Despite the hole on d5 Black judges that his centre has more stability after 5...e5. He strengthens his grip on the d4-square and prevents White from counter-attacking with d2-d4, a move which might occur even as a sacrifice after the alternative 5...e6. And, if allowed, Black will advance ...d6-d5 to conquer space in the centre and remove the hole.

Regarding the weakness on d5 itself, here I recall a paradoxical remark by Aaron Nimzowitsch, one of the great chess thinkers of the 20th century. In his book *My System* he talks about the concept of overprotection – that is, you guard a key centre square with far more pieces than necessary and, in doing so, 'by accident' the pieces find themselves well placed when the moment arrives later in the game to decide on a plan. Nimzowitsch extended this idea by asserting that

having a weakness in your central pawn structure makes it easier to find the best squares for your pieces – you can't do better than bolster up a weak centre square. Here Black has given himself a hole on d5, so that suggests he should play ...d7-d6 and then ...Be6 – the bishop finds its best square for all sorts of plans, and all in the name of defending d5!



TIP: If Black achieves ...d6-d5 safely he will free his game.

6 d3

A strong case can be made for the immediate 6 a3!? here. Then experience has shown that 6...d6 7 0-0 Nge7 8 b4! cxb4 9 axb4 Nxb4 10 Ba3 gives White a dangerous initiative for the pawn. He has Benko-like pressure against Black's queenside with potential pawn targets on a7, b7 and d6. Therefore Black should probably play 6...a5, to prevent the expansion b2-b4. So in one sense it could be argued that White has gained a move, as in the main line he provokes ...a7-a5 with a2-a3 and Rb1, whereas here it has only taken a2-a3. However, it isn't clear what White's plan should be if he doesn't stick the rook on b1. On this useful square it might support a future b2-b4 with the help of a knight after the manoeuvre Ne1 and Nc2.

Finally, mention should be made of a wild possibility for White after 6...a5, namely 7 d4!? – an 'impossible' move as d4 is covered twice, but 7...cxd4 8 Nb5 d6 9 e3 is the idea, clearing the way for an attack on d6. Black's best response is the cold blooded 9...Be6 10 exd4 Bxc4, which seems to destroy most of White's initiative.

6...Nge7! (Diagram 2)

After the natural 6...Nf6 White gets the chance to pin the knight with 7 Bg5. He is then happy to play Bxf6, even though he is giving up a bishop for a knight, as it allows him to win control of the d5-square, for example 7...d6 8 0-0 h6 (or else the pin is awkward) 9 Bxf6 Bxf6 10 Nd2 and White, who has lovely control of the light squares in the centre, is ready to play 11 Nd5. You can see that the bishop on f6 is a poorer piece than the white knights as it cannot fight for control of d5 and is blocked in by the e5-pawn. If pawns could move backwards Black would love to play 10...e6 here, when the d5-square is defended and the diagonal is opened for his bishop!



WARNING: pawns can never move backwards, so beware of thoughtless pawn moves!

7 Rb1 0-0 8 a3 a5!

Black gives himself a second hole on b5 but there is no way for White to exploit it. It is much more important that he prevents White undermining the c5-square with b2-b4.



TIP: A hole or any other structural fault is only a weakness if it can be attacked.

9 Bg5!

White still hopes that he can exchange bishop for knight with Bxe7.

9...f6!

Again Black is prepared to accept a loosening of his pawn structure in order to preserve his hold on the square that really matters – d5.

White's main idea is frustrated but he can retreat the bishop, happy that he has forced ...f7-f6, which isn't a move Black would have willingly played were it not for a higher positional motive.

10 Be3! (Diagram 3)

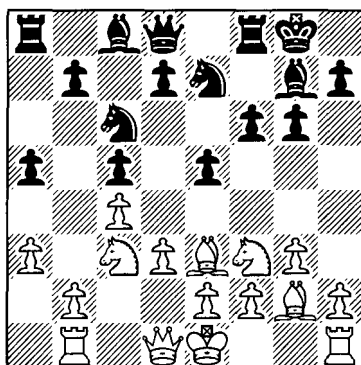


Diagram 3

The bishop prevents ...d7-d5

Who says that a dark-squared bishop can't fight for a light square? Here the bishop prevents ...d6-d5 because of the attack on c5. After 10 Bd2 d6 11 0-0 Be6 12 Ne1 d5 13 cxd5 Nxd5 Black would have achieved his aim.

Theoretical?

Not really; the lines after 5...e5 are straightforward to play as both colours, with clear strategical ideas. You don't need to know many variations.

Let's look at a couple of games. In the first White wins in fine positional style, while in the second he meets much tougher resistance.

Game 1

□ Andersson ■ Seirawan

Linares 1983

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nc6 3 g3 g6 4 Bg2 Bg7 5 Nc3 e5

I have repeatedly 'tidied up' the move order of the illustrative games in this book so that they all begin 1 c4. The actual move order in the game was 1 Nf3 c5 2 c4 Nc6 3 g3 g6 4 Bg2 Bg7 5 Nc3 e5. But watch out if you try this as Black as 2 e4! would mean you are holding the wrong book. Of course Seirawan was aware that Ulf Andersson, one of

the finest exponents of flank openings, would never play a risky move like 2 e4.

6 0-0 d6

Here too the players diverge slightly from the theoretical line given above with these sixth moves. However, the nature of the position doesn't change and the ideas remain the same.

7 a3 Nge7 8 Rb1 a5 9 d3 0-0 10 Bg5 f6 11 Be3 Be6 12 Ne1

White's plan is to play Nc2 to support the b2-b4 advance.

12...Qd7?!

In the next game 12...b6!? is examined. The plan adopted by Seirawan here allows White the better chances. Indeed Andersson's phenomenal play makes it almost look like a forced win for White!

13 Nc2 (Diagram 4)

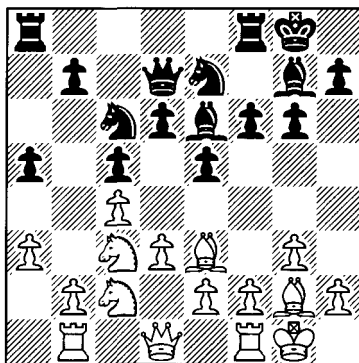


Diagram 4
White prepares b2-b4

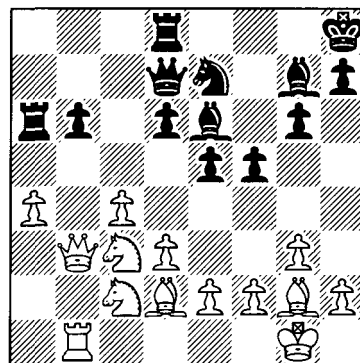


Diagram 5
The knight returns to c2

13...a4

This is the idea: White cannot allow the queenside to be fixed, so he has to accept an isolated pawn on a3. However, it will turn out that this pawn will have a glorious career. In contrast the black pawn on b7 proves far more of a target.

14 b3 axb3 15 Rxb3 Rfb8 16 Qb1 Ra6

White would prefer his rook on b2 rather than b3, as it would be out of the range of ...Nd4 from Black, or the bishop on e6 if Black advanced ...d6-d5. Here's how Andersson arranges this:

17 Rb6! Qc7 18 Rb2

Now the black queen has been cajoled into leaving d7, where she would support a ...d6-d5 advance. White is happy to have swapped the move Rb2 for ...Qc7.

18...b6?

A natural move, but with hindsight it appears to be a mistake. The pawn proves more of a target on b6 than it would be if it remained on b7. The pawn also has a role on b7 in defending the knight on c6, which solidifies Black's centre. Perhaps he should wait with 18...Qd7.

19 Bd2!

An excellent little move that clears the way for Ne3.

19...Qd8 20 a4!

Not, of course, 20 Ne3? Rxa3. The pawn isn't moved to a4 just to make Ne3 possible: it is to be used as a battering ram against b6.

20...f5

Perhaps in his earlier calculations Seirawan had planned 20...d5, the typical freeing move. However, after the multiple exchange 21 cxd5 Nxd5 22 Nxd5 Bxd5 23 Bxd5+ Qxd5 White has 24 a5! Nxa5 25 Bxa5 Rxa5 26 Rxb6 with an excellent position: his pawns are more compact, his king is safer and his knight is better than the entombed bishop on g7.



WARNING: A natural move can be a bad move in a specific position. In the introduction above I've been extolling the virtues of the ...d6-d5 advance, but here it would be a rotten move. There are no hard and fast rules in chess: only ideas that may or may not work.

21 Ne3 Nb4

Blocking the b-file and guarding d5 again. Has Black an excellent game after all? The following sacrifice clarifies matters.

22 Rxb4! cxb4 23 Qxb4

White has a safe king and an impregnable pawn structure. Rooks thrive on open lines, but there aren't any available to the black rooks. Meanwhile the white pieces can besiege the b6-pawn both frontally and from the centre with Nd5 and Be3 etc.

The only possible counterplay for Black is along the f-file. The drawback to this is that as soon as Black plays ...f5-f4 White can reply Ne4, attacking the d6-pawn. Besides, the black rooks are a long way from supporting a kingside attack.

23...Qd7 24 Rb1 Rd8 25 Qb3!

Another wonderfully inconspicuous move that has a profound idea behind it. It seems that White is merely increasing his grip on d5, but in fact he is clearing the way for a strong manoeuvre.

25...Kh8 26 Nc2! (Diagram 5) 26...h6 27 Nb4

This is the point: the knight dislodges the rook from its defensive duty on a6.

27...Ra5 28 h4!

White is in no hurry to force the win of the b6-pawn. First of all he takes time out to restrain the black kingside pawns. The only move he will permit is ...f5-f4 as this gives him the e4-square.

Starting Out: The English

28...f4 29 Kh2!

Not letting Black gain any freedom with 29...Bh3.

29...Kh7 30 Nbd5

Only now does Andersson go after the b6-pawn. You can only admire his patience.

30...Nxd5 31 cxd5 Bf5 32 Qxb6 Rc5 33 a5 Rdc8 34 Rb3 fxg3+ 35 fxg3 e4

A desperate move as the a-pawn was going to march through.

36 Nxe4 Rc2 37 Qe3 Qa4 38 Rb7

Killing off the flurry of counterplay with the threat of 39 Qxh6+.

38...R8c7 39 Rxc7 Rxc7 40 Nxd6 Rc2 41 Nxf5 1-0

White has four pawns for the exchange. White wins easily after, for instance, 41...gxf5 42 d6.

Game 2

□ O.Bjarnason ■ De Firmian

Reykjavik 2000

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nc6 3 g3 g6 4 Bg2 Bg7 5 Nc3 e5

Here the move order was actually 1 Nf3 c5 2 g3 Nc6 3 Bg2 g6 4 c4 Bg7 5 Nc3 e5

6 d3 Nge7 7 Rb1 0-0 8 a3 a5 9 Bg5 f6 10 Be3 d6 11 0-0 Be6 12 Ne1 b6!? (Diagram 6)

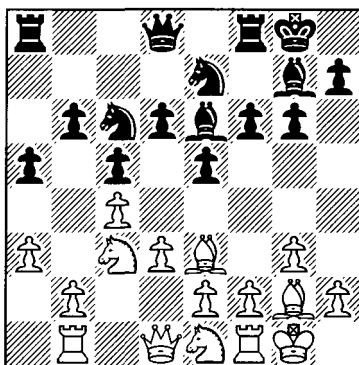


Diagram 6

Black prepares ...d6-d5

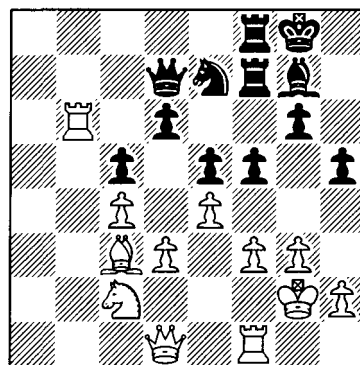


Diagram 7

Black attacks

This defends c5 again and so reintroduces the positional idea of ...d6-d5. White feels obliged to prevent this.

13 Nd5 Rc8

Tactics! White threatened 14 Nxe7+, winning the exchange.

14 Nc2 Nd4!

Preparing a sequence of exchanges that liberates Black's position.

15 Bxd4 Bxd5!

Better than 15...cxd4 16 Nxe7+Qxe7 17 b4.

16 Bxd5+

After 16 cxd5 cxd4 the pawn on d5 is cut off from its comrades.

16...Nxd5 17 Bc3 Ne7

A horrible positional mistake would be 17...Nxc3 18 bxc3, when the rook on b1 suddenly has the open b-file and White has the positional threat of 18 Ne3 and Nd5. Note if Black did blunder like this his best defensive move would be 18...Bh6!, to answer 18 Ne3?! with 18...Bxe3.

18 e4

To stop ...d6-d5. The exchange of light squared bishops has taken all the pressure off Black's centre. Therefore Black can begin to play aggressively on the kingside.

18...f5 19 f3 Qd7 20 b4 axb4 21 axb4 Rf7 22 bxc5 bxc5 23 Kg2 Rcf8 24 Rb6?

White refuses to admit he has lost the initiative and carries on playing actively on the queenside. Instead a defensive move like 24 Qe2, or 24 Ne3 followed by 25 Nd5 would hold the balance. After all, Black's minor pieces aren't anything special.



WARNING: A sure way to lose is to carry on attacking when you should be thinking about defending!

24...h5! (Diagram 7)

A typical move in such situations. Black utilises his h-pawn as a battering ram.

25 Qb1?

The logical continuation of his plan to break through on the queenside. Nevertheless it leaves the f3-square weak. It wasn't too late to play 25 Ne3 or 25 Qe2.

25...fxe4 26 dxe4 h4

Now 27...h3+ is a big threat, winning the f3-pawn. White thinks he has found the answer, but it allows a winning tactic. Clearly he underestimated the danger right until the moment he had to resign.

27 g4? Rxf3! 0-1

Black wins easily after 28 Rxf3 Qxg4+.

Black Defends the d5-square

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nc6 3 g3 g6 4 Bg2 Bg7 5 Nc3 e6 (Diagram 8)

Black defends the d5-square and plans smooth development with ...Nge7, ...0-0 and then ...d7-d5. Once Black has played these moves he will have a very solid position. Therefore White has experimented with a bold sacrifice to exploit the temporal disadvantage of 5...e6:

that is, Black has weakened the d6-square and failed to develop the king's knight.

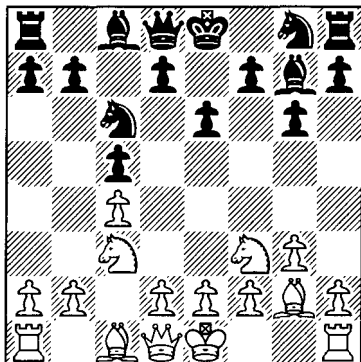


Diagram 8

Black prepares ...Nge7

Theoretical?

You need to look at the sharp response 6 d4: knowledge of concrete theory is necessary here. But assuming you learn this line there isn't much to fear as Black.

Game 3

□ T.Markowski ■ B.Macieja

Warsaw 1998

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nc6 3 g3 g6 4 Bg2 Bg7 5 Nc3 e6 6 d4!? (Diagram 9)

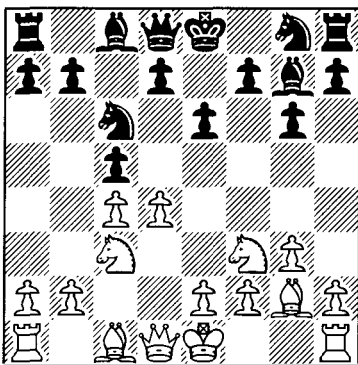


Diagram 9

White sacrifices a pawn

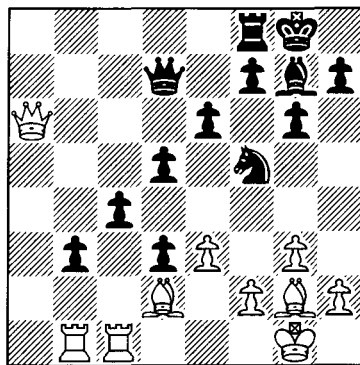


Diagram 10

Pawn Power!

White can't expect much (if any) advantage after the solid 6 0-0 Nge7

7 d3 0-0 8 Bg5 h6! (not allowing the exchange of bishops after Qc1 and Bh6, when Black's dark squares might become weak) 9 Bd2 d5 and Black has nothing to fear.

In contrast the gambit in the game is very tricky.

6...Nxd4 7 Nxd4 cxd4 8 Nb5 Qb6

Defending d4 and d6 but leaving the queen on a potentially exposed square – see the next note.

9 Qa4

The immediate 9 e3 gives White nothing after 9...Ne7 10 Nxd4 0-0 11 0-0 d5 12 cxd5 Nxd5.

9...a6

Straightforward development with 9...Ne7? falls for 10 Bf4 e5 11 c5! Qd8 (or 11...Qxc5 12 Rc1 and the check on c7 will be fatal) 12 Nd6+ Kf8 13 Qc4 and Black has no good way to defend f7.

10 e3 d3

Black keeps the position blocked. Completely wrong would be 10...dxe3? 11 Bxe3 Qd8 12 Nd6+.

11 0-0 Ne7 12 Rd1

White hopes to regain the pawn with 13 Rxd3 with a good position due to his pressure on the d-file and the passive black bishop on c8. But now it is Black's turn to sacrifice...

12...axb5! 13 Qxa8 bxc4

The doomed pawn on d3 has suddenly become a protected passed pawn. Black has great compensation for the exchange.

14 Rb1 0-0 15 Bd2 d5 16 Rdc1 Qc7 17 Qa3 Qd7?

Black was afraid of 18 Qxd3, but a better answer to this threat was 17...Nc6, when Macieja gives a lot of analysis in Informator 74 to show that Black has a clear advantage after 18 b3 b5 19 Qc5 Bd7 20 e4 Rb8! etc.

18 b3 b5 19 Qc5 Nf5 20 a4 Ba6 21 Qb6?

Now it is White's turn to go wrong. He had to break up the pawns with 21 axb5.

21...bxa4!!

A brilliant positional sacrifice. The mass of passed pawns will be worth more than a rook!

22 Qxa6 axb3 (Diagram 10) 23 Qa5 Rb8 24 Bc3 Qb5!

TIP: Queens are tricky pieces, so when you have a winning long term advantage the exchange of queens is often the best way to kill off any counterplay.

25 Qxb5 Rxb5 26 Bxg7 Kxg7 27 Bf1

White's only hope now is to sacrifice his king's bishop on d3 to break up the pawns. If Black had played accurately he could have prevented



this defence.

27...Nd6 28 f3 Rb4?

Black doesn't quite realise how strong his passed pawns are. Here he missed the brilliant 28...d2 29 Rd1 c3! 30 Bxb5 Nxb5 when the rook and three connected passed pawns overwhelm the rooks (for example 31 Rxb3 c2 32 Rbb1 Nc3!).

29 Rb2 Nb5

Here 29...e5 would have made things harder for White.

30 Bxd3! cxd3 31 Rd1 Na3 32 Rxd3 Nc4 33 Rdxb3 Rxb3 34 Rxb3 Nd2 35 Rb4 Nxf3+ 36 Kf2 Ne5 37 Ke2

The result of all the excitement is an endgame with very slight winning chances for Black, but it finished as a draw after 64 moves. A highly eventful game.

Black Copies with 5...Nf6

Theoretical?

Yes. Bobby Fischer has played this variation as both colours, while Garry Kasparov has adopted it several times as Black. Need I say more about the depth of the research that has gone into this variation?

In order to keep things clearer we shall assume that the opening sequence is the 'copying' 1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nc6 3 g3 g6 4 Bg2 Bg7 5 Nc3 Nf6 (Diagram 11)

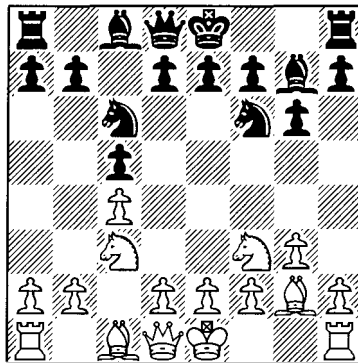


Diagram 11
A copy cat position

However, in reality, as soon as Black plays 1...c5, both players begin wondering about the best moment to break the symmetry. They might copy each other's moves for some time but sooner or later someone will make a bid to gain space in the centre. Thus as early as move

three White might try 1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nc6 3 d4, or Black might opt for 1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 Nc3 d5. Such early divergences are considered in Chapter Two. However, in most cases, despite the early differences in move order, one of the following two scenarios will be reached after nine moves.

Starting from the diagram above:

Scenario 1

6 d4 cxd4 7 Nxd4 0-0 8 0-0 Nxd4 9 Qxd4 d6 (Diagram 12)

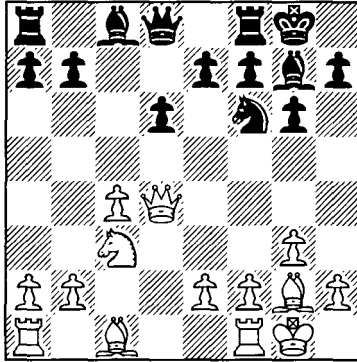


Diagram 12
Scenario 1

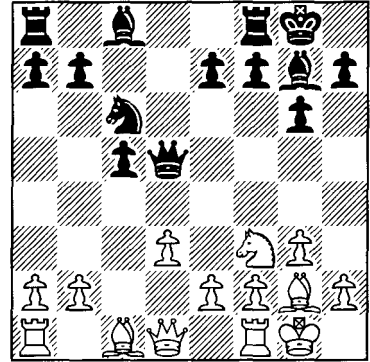


Diagram 13
Scenario 2

Scenario 2

6 0-0 d5 7 cxd5 Nxd5 8 Nxd5 Qxd5 9 d3 0-0 (Diagram 13)

In both scenarios we see a queen sitting in the centre, controlling a number of squares but in danger of a discovered attack from the enemy king's bishop, which is, of course, delighted to have such a big piece in its sights, and is also looking beyond the queen to an attack on other pieces along the diagonal. White's extra tempo in Scenario 2 makes the pressure from the bishop more potent.

The pawn on c4 in Scenario 1 confers a space advantage on White, but is slightly vulnerable; the same could be said about the pawn on c5 in Scenario 2, except that it is even more of a potential target as White has the advantage of an extra move to begin an attack on it. Nevertheless, if nothing nasty befalls the c4 (or c5) pawn and the queen manages to evacuate the danger diagonal without conceding a weakness in the pawn structure, then the player who has advanced d2-d4 or ...d7-d5 can look forward to a game in which all his pieces are actively placed and he has a space advantage.

TIP: If you like a space advantage as White, advance d2-d4. If you prefer to attack a centre from the wings, wait for Black to play ...d7-d5.



Now we'll look at developments from the two Scenarios.

Scenario One: Black Sacrifices the b7-pawn

The diagram position below is reached after 1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 Nc3 Nc6 4 g3 g6 5 Bg2 Bg7 6 d4 cxd4 7 Nxd4 0-0 8 0-0 (Diagram 14)

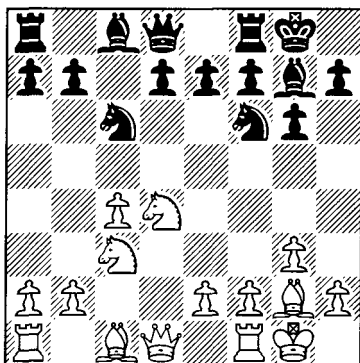


Diagram 14

Black offers a pawn

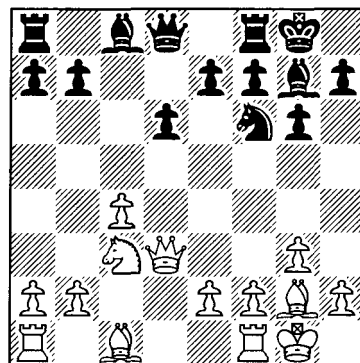


Diagram 15

White's queen is busy

Now usual is 8...Nxd4, as given in the Scenario One sequence, below, but Black has occasionally given up a pawn to take over the initiative on the queenside and facilitate his development by opening lines: 8...d6!? 9 Nxc6 bxc6 10 Bxc6 Rb8. In return for the pawn he has the open b-file for his rook, whose pressure on b2 prevents the immediate development of White's queen's bishop. Furthermore, the c4-pawn can be subjected to a rapid attack with ...Be6 or ...Qc7 – in the last case Black exploits the loosely placed bishop on c6. Topalov has successfully defended Black's position against no lesser players than Karpov and Kramnik. For example 11 Qa4 Bb7 12 Bxb7 Rxb7 13 Rb1 Qc8 14 Bd2 Qh3! (the threat of 15...Ng4 forces White to weaken his centre) 15 f3 Nh5 16 Rf2 Qe6 17 Kg2 Rc8 18 b3 Bd4 19 e3 Bxc3 20 Bxc3 Qxe3 and Black had regained the pawn with unclear play in Karpov-Topalov, 6th Amber rapid, Monte Carlo 1997.

Returning again to the Scenario One line, from the initial diagram, play might continue 8...Nxd4 9 Qxd4 d6 10 Qd3 (Diagram 15)

The white queen has prudently retreated out of the range of the bishop. She chooses a square where she keeps c4 defended and in doing so helps to fight for the b5-square.

The question arises whether Black can gain counterplay with the plan of ...a7-a6, ...Rb8 and ...b7-b5, or will he just be creating a weak pawn on b5 and opening up lines for the white pieces?

In the illustrative game below it is Kasparov playing Black, therefore it isn't very surprising that Black's queenside push triumphs in dy-

namic style! But a lesser player often finds that the isolated pawn he creates just proves sickly, and a target for the white pieces.

In fact Black often agrees to be rid of the weak b-pawn in return for activity. For example if he lets White play Bxb7 he will have the open b-file and a lead in development. Let's see Kasparov in action:

10...a6 11 Bf4 (Diagram 16)

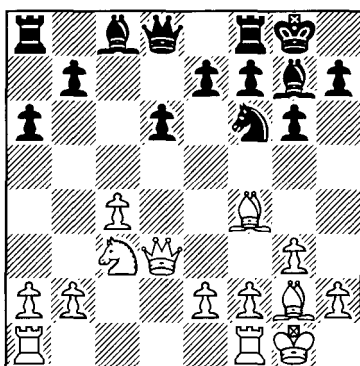


Diagram 16

Kasparov generates counterplay

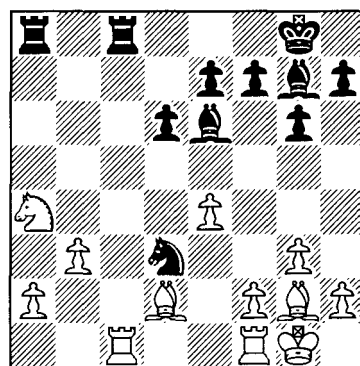


Diagram 17

A balanced position

Black can continue harassing the white queen with **11...Bf5**. It may appear that Black is losing time with this move as the apparently strong reply **12 e4** attacks the bishop. However, after **12...Be6** White finds that he can no longer play Bxb7, as pushing the e-pawn has blocked in the bishop! Now **13 Rac1 Nd7!** unleashes the dark-squared bishop and threatens **14...Ne5** with a double attack on c4, which would force White to make an unfavourable exchange of bishop for knight on e5. **14 b3 Ne5 15 Qd2 b5!** (Black's thematic freeing move) **16 cxb5 axb5 17 Nxb5 Qa5 18 Nc3 Rfc8 19 Na4 Qxd2 20 Bxd2 Nd3 (Diagram 17)**

White has a huge static advantage (connected passed pawns!) but Black has intense dynamic pressure – the beautiful knight on d3 means that Black will win control of the c-file, whether or not White exchanges on c8, when ...Rc2 will be a threat. The static and dynamic advantages balance each other, making it a very unclear position in Spassky-Kasparov, Belfort 1988.

We see Kasparov in action again in the illustrative game.

Game 4

□ Hjartarson ■ Kasparov

Tilburg 1989

1 c4 c5

The transpositional possibilities are enormous. This game actually began as a g3 Kings Indian: **1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nf3 Bg7 4 g3 c5 5 Bg2**

cx d4 6 Nxd4 0-0 7 Nc3 Nc6 8 0-0

2 Nf3 Nf6 3 Nc3 Nc6 4 g3 g6

Leaving it to White to set the pace in the centre.

5 Bg2 Bg7 6 d4 cxd4 7 Nxd4 0-0 8 0-0 Nxd4

Instead 8...Ng4!? 9 e3 Nxd4 10 exd4 Nh6 intends ...Nf5 to pressurise d4. Here White has a very good move, but it is difficult to see as normally we don't like to give up a bishop for a knight on the edge of the board: 11 Bxh6! Bxh6 12 c5! and thanks to his grip on the centre White stands better.

If Black had been allowed to play ...Nf5 then the knight could only have been ejected by the horribly weakening g3-g4. So it would in effect have been on an unassailable square in the centre.



TIP: Knights love centre squares, where they can't be dislodged by pawns.

A better approach for Black is 9...d6, offering a pawn. If White accepts with 10 Nxc6 bxc6 11 Bxc6 Rb8 then play is very similar to the 8...d6 line discussed under the sacrifices section above, but with the moves e2-e3 and ...Ng4 thrown in – a difference that surely favours Black. Instead White can avoid all this and keep a slight edge with 10 b3. Then Black can revert to the ...b7-b5 plan, e.g. 10...a6 11 Bb2 Nxd4 12 exd4 Rb8 etc. But it is fair to ask: what is the knight doing on g4?

9 Qxd4 d6 10 Qd3 a6 11 h3

We have already discussed 11 Bf4. Here is a trap Black has to avoid: 11 Be3 Ng4 12 Bd4 Ne5 13 Qd1. Then Black should continue with 13...Rb8, as taking on c4 would lose a piece to an exchange on g7 then Qd4+ and f2-f4 if necessary – 13...Nxc4?? 14 Bxg7 Kxg7 15 Qd4+ Ne5 16 f4.



TIP: You can't hope to play good positional chess unless you see tactics.

Another possibility is 11 Bd2 Rb8 when Black is ready for ...b7-b5. If White now continues quietly with 12 Rac1 Black gets to play his freeing move: 12...b5! 13 cxb5 axb5 14 Nxb5 Bf5 15 e4 Nxe4! 16 Bxe4 Bxe4 17 Qxe4 Rxb5 with a position that is difficult to assess because White has queenside passed pawns but Black has a nice centre. White can prevent this simplification with 12 c5!?, offering the c-pawn. The idea is that after 12...dxc5 13 Qxd8 Rxd8 14 Bf4 Ra8 15 Na4! there is the double threat of 16 Nxc5 and 16 Nb6 Ra7 17 Bb8. White regains his pawn with some initiative. If instead Black just ignores the move, with 12...Be6?, for example, then he is left with an isolated pawn after 13 cxd6 exd6. The best response is 12...Bf5!, Black again taking the pressure off b7 by making White play 13 e4, when 13...Be6 14 cxd6 Nd8! avoids being left with an isolated pawn. White could play 15 Bf4 Nxd6 16 Bxd6 Qxd6 17 Qxd6 exd6 but the price would be his lovely dark-squared bishop – it isn't worth it. Instead there is 15 Nd5 Nxd6 16 Bf4 Bxd5 17 Qxd5 Bxb2 18 Rad1 Qc8! and Black returns the pawn,

avoiding the pin on the d-file and earning equal chances, Tal-Neurov, Moscow 1990.

Hjartarson's move in the game is also quite crafty. White waits for Black to play the natural 11...Rb8, when he can hit him with a familiar pawn sacrifice in the shape of 12 c5!, when 12...dxc5 13 Qxd8 Rxd8 14 Bf4 Ra8 15 Rfd1! leaves Black in dire trouble. He can't develop his bishop on c8 without b7 dropping, but if he doesn't develop the bishop then he loses control of the d-file. The extra pawn is meaningless as White can regain it at any point with Na4 and Rac1 if necessary.

This analysis and the following notes are based on Kasparov's analysis in Informator 48.

11...Nd7!

Kasparov knows an immense amount of theory, but this hasn't dulled his tactical awareness or his ability to adjust his plans as necessary. Many players (even Grandmasters) on facing 11 h3 would think 'this is a slow, irrelevant move that doesn't do anything to stop my plan of queenside expansion – 11...Rb8 must be the right move'. Not, however, Kasparov. He is one of the greatest opening experts of all time because he combines knowledge with flexibility and originality to a perfect degree. The text clears the long diagonal for the king's bishop and rules out c4-c5.

12 b3

Here's how Kasparov intended to neutralise White's queenside pressure after 12 Bd2: 12...Ne5 13 Qe4 Bd7!, offering the b-pawn, when 14 Qxb7 Rb8 15 Qxa6 Rxb2 gives Black huge play for the pawn, while if White refuses the offer then Black will play 14...Bc6 and exchange off the light-squared bishops.



TIP: Always be on the lookout (as Black) for ways to sacrifice the b7-pawn.

12...Rb8

But now it's right to return to the plan of preparing ...b7-b5.

13 Be3 b5!? (Diagram 18)

Offering the exchange.

14 cxb5?!

After 14 Ba7 b4 15 Bxb8? Nc5! 16 Qe3 Bxc3 Black has compensation for the exchange, but 15 Nd5! would have kept some advantage for White (Kasparov).

14...axb5 15 Rac1

It is too late for 15 Ba7 in view of 15...Qa5! 16 Bxb8? (16 Bd4) 16...Bxc3 17 Rac1 b4 and White is in big trouble as his bishop is entombed on b8.

15...b4 16 Na4 Qa5 17 Qd2

In this game, White's position gradually goes downhill. Here was the moment to bail out with the move 17 Qd5!, offering to trade queens.

This would prevent Black from building up an attack on the white king.

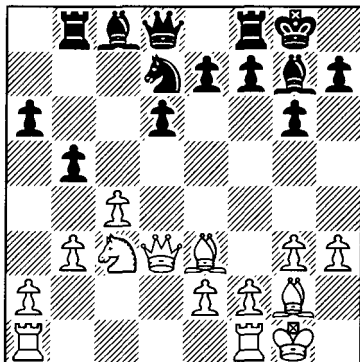


Diagram 18
Black invites 14 Ba7

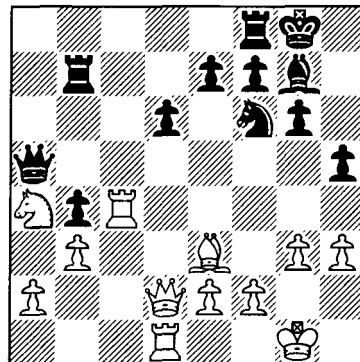


Diagram 19
A useful kingside thrust

17...Bb7

The exchange of light-squared bishops is disagreeable for White, who must have been regretting weakening his king's position with 11 h3.

18 Bxb7 Rxb7 19 Rfd1 Nf6 20 Rc4 h5! (Diagram 19) 21 Qc2 Rfb8 22 f3 Qe5 23 Bf2 Qe6 24 g4

More solid was 24 Kg2.

24...hgx4 25 hxg4 Rb5 26 Rc1 Bh6 27 Rc8+

Now the rook abandons the defence of g4, after which a sacrifice from Kasparov becomes inevitable.

27...Kg7 28 Rxb8 Rxb8 29 Rd1 Nxg4! 30 Bd4+

In the event of 30 fxg4 Qxg4+ 31 Kf1 Qh3+ 32 Kg1 Rb5 White's king is defenceless.

30...Nf6 31 Kg2 Rb5 0-1

Scenario Two: White Offers the b2-pawn

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 Nc3 Nc6 4 g3 d5 5 cxd5 Nxd5 6 Bg2 g6 7 0-0 Bg7 8 Nxd5 Qxd5 9 d3 0-0 10 Be3! (Diagram 20)

An excellent offer of a pawn. Now after 10...Bxb2 11 Rb1 Bg7 12 Nd4 Qd6 (12...Qxa2 13 Nxc6 bxc6 14 Bxc6 sees White win the exchange) 13 Nxc6 bxc6 14 Qc2 Black is temporarily a pawn up but both doubled c-pawns are likely to drop.

A natural response would be 10...Qd6, getting the queen out of the way of the discovered attack, but if Black can safely develop a piece he should do it! Let's see what happened in the following world class game.

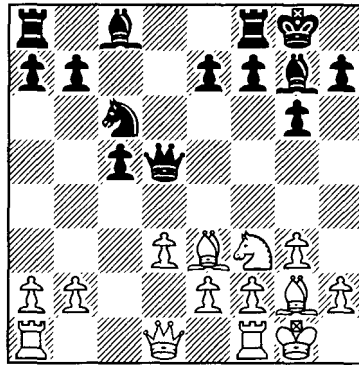


Diagram 20
White offers the b-pawn

Game 5

□ Karpov ■ Ribli

IBM Amsterdam 1980

1 c4

Karpov was gunning for revenge in this game as Ribli had beaten him in their first game of this double-round tournament. Against a solid, defensive player like Ribli it seems Karpov had decided that he had to look for a modest positional advantage and keep plugging away.

1...c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 Nc3 Nc6 4 g3 d5 5 cxd5 Nxd5 6 Bg2 g6 7 0-0 Bg7 8 Nxd5 Qxd5 9 d3 0-0 10 Be3 Bd7! (Diagram 21)

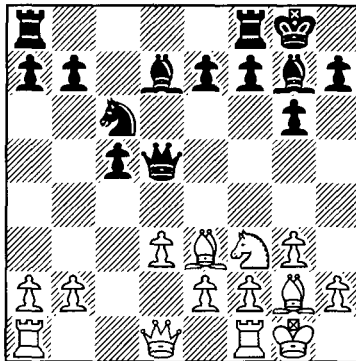


Diagram 21
Black supports c6

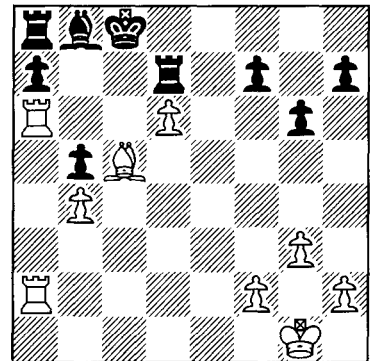


Diagram 22
Decisive bind

The key move. Black allows White a discovered attack on his queen but strengthens the knight on c6, thus avoiding doubled pawns.

Meanwhile, in reply to 11 Nd2, intending 12 Ne4, then h5 is a safe square for the queen, while 11 Ng5 Qe5, attacking b2, is good for Black.

11 Nd4 Qd6 12 Nxc6 Bxc6 13 Bxc6 Qxc6 14 Rc1

It seems that White has the advantage after all in view of 14...b6 15 b4 or 14...Bxb2 15 Rxc5, keeping the initiative (15...Qe6 16 Qa4 etc.).

14...Qe6!

So Black goes after the a2-pawn.

15 Rxc5 Qxa2 16 Rb5!

Karpov finds the only way to keep up the pressure. If Black managed to escape the bind then he could fight for the advantage due to his queenside pawn majority.

16...b6 17 Qa1! Qxa1?

Agreeing to enter a poor endgame. Here is a dynamic defence of Black's position: 17...Qe6! 18 Qa4 Rfc8 19 Rb4 Qd5 (the queen heads for h5 to terrorise the e2-pawn) 20 Ra1 Qh5 21 Qd1 Qd5 22 Raa4 b5! and Black gives up a pawn to activate his position and gain counter-play on the c-file. C.Hansen-Sutovsky, Esbjerg 2001 continued 23 Rxa7 Rxa7 24 Bxa7 Bh6! (threatening 25...Rc1+) 25 Be3! Bxe3 26 fxe3 Rc5 27 Qf1 Qc6 28 Qf3 Rc1+ 29 Kg2 Qc2 30 Rf4 Re1 31 Kf2 Qd1 32 Qa8+ Kg7 33 Rxf7+! (forcing a draw by repetition) 33...Kxf7 34 Qd5+ Kf6 35 Qd4+ Kf7 36 Qd5+ Kf6 37 Qd4+ e5 38 Qd6+ Kf7 39 Qd7+ Kf6 40 Qd6+ Kf7 41 Qd7+ Kf6 ½-½.

18 Rxa1 Rfb8 19 Ra6!

Fixing the queenside pawns. Black's problem is that the rook on a8 is passive. As Karpov remarks, if it were on the second rank Black would be okay.

19...Kf8 20 Rb4 Be5 21 Rba4 b5?

An instructive mistake. Black had to ensure the disappearance of all the queenside pawns with 21...Bxb2 22 Bxb6 Rb7 23 Bxa7 Rc8 when, in his book *Chess at the Top*, Karpov says the endgame with five pawns versus four pawns would be very hard to win.



TIP: Games are often won by creating an outside passed pawn.

When you are a pawn down, try to exchange off all the pawns on the opposite side of the board to the kings.

22 Ra2! Rb7 23 b3 Bb8 24 Bc5

Black has been completely outplayed. Now Karpov intensifies the pressure by creating a passed pawn in the centre.

24...Ke8 25 d4 Kd7 26 e4 e6 27 b4 Kc8 28 d5 exd5 29 exd5 Rd7 30 d6 (Diagram 22)

Now Black's queen's rook and bishop are completely entombed.

30...Rd8 31 Kg2 Kd7 32 Re2 Kc8 33 Re7 Rd7 34 Ra2!

A decisive change of front. Black loses a piece after 34...Bxd6 35 Rxd7

Kxd7 36 Rd2.

34...a5 35 Rc2 1-0

A masterpiece won against one of the most difficult players to beat.

Finally, we shall look at lines in which White delays or avoids Nf3.

White Avoids Nf3

After 1 c4 c5 2 Nc3 Nc6 3 g3 g6 4 Bg2 Bg7 White has several interesting alternatives to 5 Nf3.

Theoretical?

These lines offer a good way to avoid the complexities of the variations above.

Immediate Queenside Action

5 a3!? (Diagram 23)

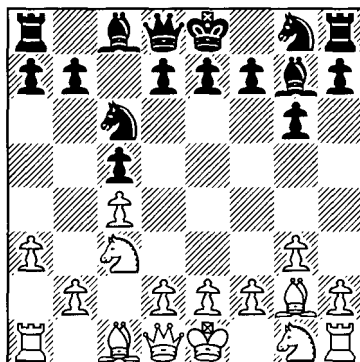


Diagram 23

White prepares b2-b4

White delays the development of his kingside in favour of immediate action on the queenside. Black must now decide how he is going to counter the positional threat of 6 Rb1 and 7 b4, when White gains space and undermines the centre. The most solid method is probably 5...d6 6 Rb1 a5, putting a stop to b2-b4 for the foreseeable future. Nevertheless, White can be pleased to have provoked the creation of a weakness on b5. You can see how in the illustrative game White manages to exploit this hole, in a similar position with 5...Nh6 rather than 5...d6.

It is also worth noting in this move order that 5...e5?! can be answered strongly with the pawn sacrifice 6 b4!, when 6...cxb4 7 axb4 Nxb4 8 Ba3 offers White excellent play. Black has a ragged centre

and his queenside can be attacked down the open files by the white rooks and queen, which would be ably abetted by the bishop on g2.

In the Style of the Botvinnik System

With **5 e4** White chooses to deploy his pawns and pieces in the style of the Botvinnik System – see Chapter Seven. A possible line is **5...Nf6 6 Nge2 0-0 7 0-0 d6 8 d3** when Black does best to prepare his own expansion on the queenside with **8...a6**, intending **...Rb8** etc. Then White has to spend a move on **9 h3** before he can put his bishop on e3 as **9 Be3 Ng4** is annoying. If instead **8...Ne8**, then **9 Be3** threatens to gain space with **10 d4**, and **9...Nd4 10 Rb1 a5 11 Bxd4 cxd4 12 Nb5** looks pleasant for White, who has the b5-square again.

Expansion in the Centre with Nge2 and d2-d4

The natural sequence is **5 e3 e6 6 Nge2 Nge7**. Then **7 0-0 0-0 8 d4 cxd4 9 Nxd4 d5!** should equalise for Black. Instead White can try to keep some life in the position with **7 Nf4** to prevent the freeing **...d7-d5**, but Black can then expand on the queenside with **7...a6 8 Rb1 b5!**, when **9 cxb5 axb5 10 Nxd6 0-0!** offers good compensation for the pawn in Benko-like pressure on the queenside and a strong centre after **...d7-d5**.

Game 6

□ **Miles** ■ **W.Arencibia**

Cienfuegos 1996

1 c4 c5 2 Nc3 Nc6 3 g3 g6 4 Bg2 Bg7 5 a3 Nh6

An ambitious move. Black prepares to bring his knight to f5 to gain control of the d4-square. At the same time he keeps the diagonal of the bishop on g7 open in an attempt to deter b2-b4. Nevertheless, all his hopes are reduced to ashes by the excellent play of Tony Miles. The solid approach was **5...Nf6** or **5...d6**.

6 Rb1 a5

He does well to stop **7 b4**, but this leaves a hole on b5.

7 e3 Nf5 8 Nge2 d6 9 b3

White prepares Bb2 and then the exchange of Black's important bishop on g7. Black's minor pieces look actively placed but they aren't supported by any pawn advances. Consequently no constructive plan is available.

9...0-0 10 Bb2 Bd7 11 0-0 Rb8 12 Nb5! (Diagram 24)

After this move even the ghost of a breakout with **...b7-b5** vanishes. The text also clears the way for the bishop exchange, when Black has no good way to stop a future d2-d4. This shows that Black's plan beginning with **5...Nh6** has been a failure.

12...Bxb2 13 Rxb2 Ne5 14 Nec3 Bxb5 15 Nxb5 a4

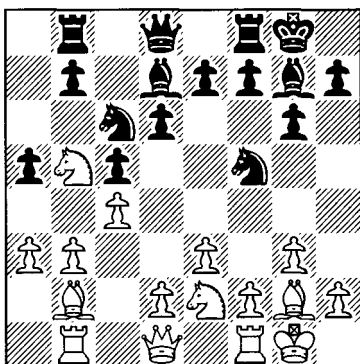


Diagram 24
White stands better

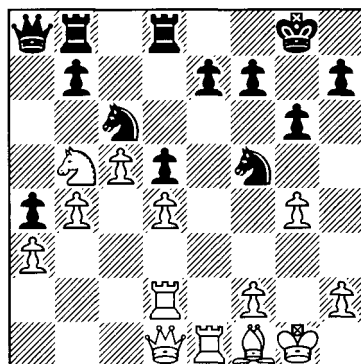


Diagram 25
White switches flanks

A bid for counterplay that shows Black is busted as White now plays the two pawn advances that this entire strategy was designed to prevent!

16 d4 Nc6 17 b4 cxd4 18 exd4 Qb6 19 Rd2 Rfd8 20 Re1 d5 21 c5!

A decisive strengthening of the white pawns on the queenside. In reply to 21...Qxb5 White traps the queen with 22 Bf1.

21...Qa6 22 Bf1 Qa8 23 Nc7 Qa7 24 Nb5 Qa8 25 g4! (Diagram 25)

Many players in this situation would be thinking about preparing a breakthrough on the queenside where the impressive white pawns can be supported by the pieces. But why allow the black queen to have a say in the outcome of the game? She is a powerful piece who is best left alone in her tomb on a8. Instead it makes sense for White to attack on the kingside.



NOTE: If there is a choice you should always start an attack as far away as possible from the main body of enemy pieces.

25...Ng7 26 Nc7 Qa7 27 Nb5 Qa8 28 Rd3

The white pieces all head towards the enemy king.

28...Ne6 29 Rxe6! fxe6 30 Nc7 Qa7 31 Nxe6 Re8 32 Rh3 Nd8 33 Qe1 b5 34 Qe5 Nxe6 35 Qxe6+ Kg7 36 Bd3 1-0

It's queen, rook and bishop against a king. Black resigned as there is no good defence against 37 Rxh7+! Kxh7 38 Qxg6+ and mate on h7.

Chapter Two

Symmetrical English 2: Early Action in the Centre

Introduction

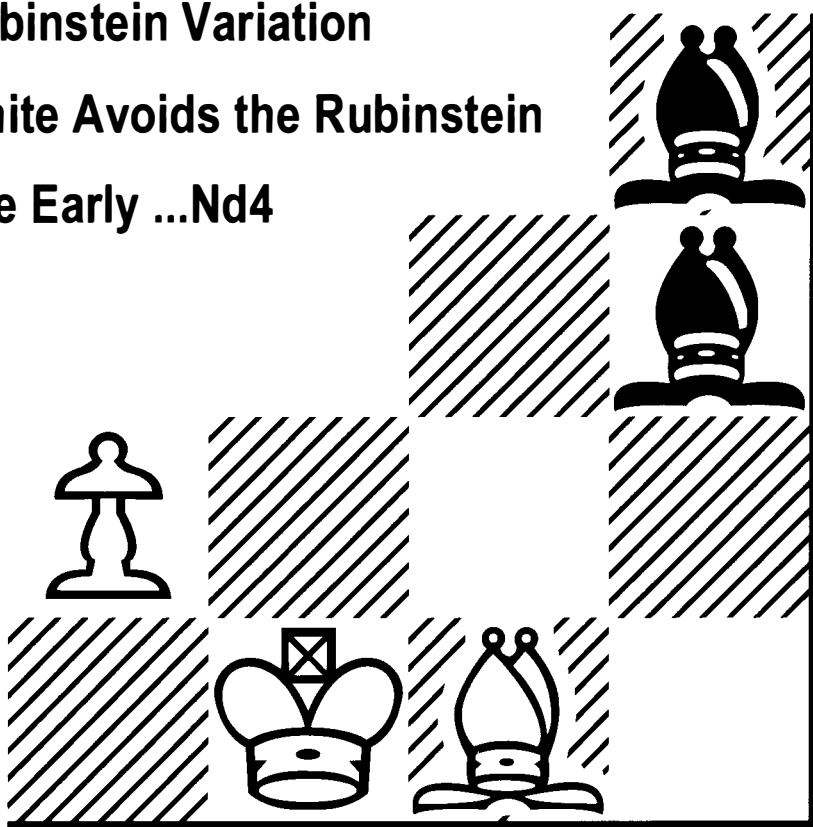
1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 d4 cxd4 4 Nxd4 e5!?

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 d4 cxd4 4 Nxd4 e6

Rubinstein Variation

White Avoids the Rubinstein

The Early ...Nd4



Introduction

In this chapter we look at lines in which either White or Black breaks the symmetry at an early stage – move three or four – in order to begin immediate operations in the centre. The only exception is that after 1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 d4 cxd4 4 Nxd4 we don't look at a black fianchetto on g7. This is because after 4...g6 5 Nc3 Bg7 6 e4 we would end up in the Sicilian Maroczy Bind which, while playable for Black, is out of the range of this book. Instead we look at ways to retain an English flavour with 4...e6 or even 4...e5. The rest of the chapter is concerned with lines in which Black is the first to break the symmetry. The most important of these is Rubinstein's Variation, 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 g3 d5 4 cxd5 Nxd5 5 Bg2 Nc7.

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 d4 cxd4 4 Nxd4 e5!?

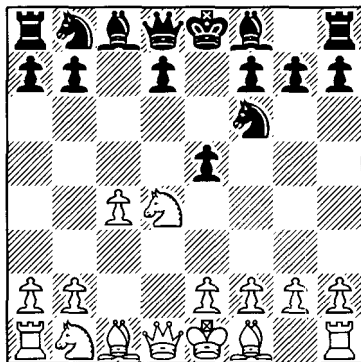


Diagram 1

Black plays to win – or lose!

Black makes a bold pawn stab at the white knight to gain time for development, but it isn't without risk. It was used by the young Kasparov in the illustrative game – evidently at that time he was more willing to take risks than after he became World Champion.

5 Nb5

The knight has been dislodged from the centre but it spies a great square on d6. We have already mentioned the subject of holes in Chapter One, but it is such an important theme in a positional opening like the English that it is worth continuing the discussion here. A hole on a centre square is often a serious structural weakness and should be avoided unless there is clear compensation, such as material or an active development of your pieces. In this case White intends to exploit the hole with 6 Nd6+ Bxd6 7 Qxd6 when he has the two bishops and control of the dark squares.

After 5...d6 6 Bg5! Nc6 7 Bxf6 gxf6 8 N1c3 another hole has appeared in Black's position, this time on d5. A white knight can use such a square to dominate the board.

The worst type of holes are those that occur in front of one of the defender's own pawns, as the pawn gets in the way of bolstering the weak square with a rook or queen. On the other hand, a hole usually vanishes if this pawn can be advanced. With these considerations in mind Black should play:

5...d5! 6 cxd5 Bc5

Black couldn't recapture on d5 because after 6...Nxd5?? 7 Qxd5 Qxd5 8 Nc7+ he emerges a piece down. So he carries on with his plan of developing as rapidly as possible.

7 N5c3

The knight has been denied its moment of pleasure on d6, and this retreat denies the other knight its natural square. White might consider 7 d6, aiming for 8 Nc7 winning the rook in the corner, and if 7...Bb6 he can play still play Nc7 when appropriate, returning the extra pawn after Bxc7 etc. but acquiring the two bishops.

7...0-0 8 e3

Blunting the attack on f2. Instead 8 e4? Ng4 would be extremely unpleasant for White – how does he defend the f2-square? The assumption in all this is that White will castle kingside. Black is deploying his pieces in the expectation of being able to launch an attack against a king sitting on g1. But in fact White had available a more dynamic approach. For example 8 h3 (preventing ...Ng4 and therefore threatening 9 e4) 8...e4 9 g4!? looks bizarre but White intends to play Bg2 combined with g4-g5, chasing away the knight to win the e4-pawn. Black can try 9...e3 to mess things up further, but it isn't convincing.

8...e4!

Black ensures that White will never be able to support the d5-pawn with a future e3-e4. Black also takes away the d3-square from the white bishop and, looking further ahead, both e4 and f3 from a white knight. A hard battle is ahead. Let's see how it might work out in practice.

Game 7

□ Mikhailchishin ■ Kasparov

Frunze 1981

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 c5 3 Nf3 cxd4 4 Nxd4 e5 5 Nb5 d5 6 cxd5 Bc5 7 N5c3 0-0 8 e3 e4 (Diagram 2)

We are sometimes stuck with misleading names for our openings. As you can see the game actually began with a Benoni move order in which White avoided 3 d5. For this reason the variation is sometimes called the Benoni-English, despite the fact that the pawn structure has absolutely no resemblance to the Benoni.

9 Be2 Qe7 10 Nd2

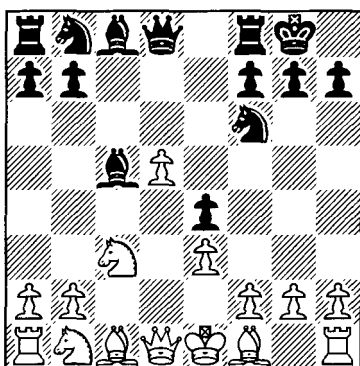


Diagram 2
Black has more space

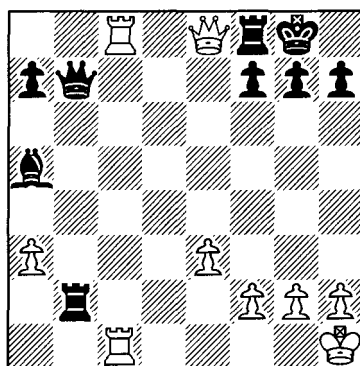


Diagram 3
Who is winning?

A solid move. Instead 10 g4!? also had merit, with the aim of undermining the defence of e4 with g4-g5.

10...Rd8 11 a3

White returns the pawn but, on the other hand, he achieves full development and can try to exploit the slight weakness of the e4-pawn.

11...Nxd5 12 Nxd5 Rxd5 13 Qc2 Bf5 14 b4 Bb6 15 Bb2 Nc6 16 0-0 Qg5 17 Kh1 Rd6!?

After 17...Re8 18 Nc4 White has a slight but annoying positional advantage, so Kasparov stakes everything on the complications that follow this sacrifice. White must accept or else the attack with ...Rh6 or ...Rg6 will become overwhelming.

18 Nxe4 Bxe4 19 Qxe4 Rd2 20 b5?

White gets excited about the prospect of creating a passed pawn on the seventh rank, but this plan fails to Kasparov's tactical resourcefulness. In fact White missed the chance to consolidate an advantage with the unexpected 20 Ba6!, when 20...Rxb2? 21 Bxb7 is bad and 20...bxa6 21 Qxc6 Rad8 22 Bd4 leaves Black active but still a pawn down.

20...Rxe2! 21 bxc6 Rxb2 22 cxb7 Rf8 23 Rac1 Ba5!

White may have missed the strength of this defence in his earlier calculations.

24 Rc8 Qb5 25 Rfc1 Qxb7 26 Qe8!? (Diagram 3)

Looks decisive, but...

26...Qxc8!

White's back rank proves weaker than Black's.

27 Qxc8 Bd2!

The point. Kasparov must have seen this quiet move at least seven

moves ago. No wonder he became World Champion!

28 h3

White has no way to avoid an endgame of queen versus two rooks in which the f2-pawn also drops.

28...h6 29 Qc4 Bxc1 30 Qxc1 Rxf2 31 Qc7 a6 32 Qa7 Rf6 33 a4 Rd8 34 a5 Rd1+ 35 Kh2 Rd2 36 Qb8+ Kh7 37 Qb4 Rff2 0-1

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 d4 cxd4 4 Nxd4 e6

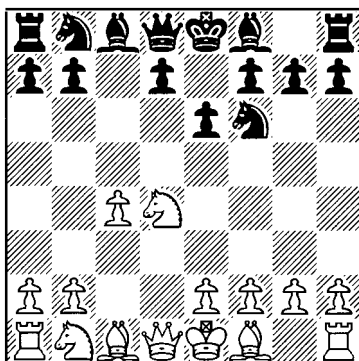


Diagram 4
A popular variation

Black prepares to develop his bishop and, if appropriate, advance ...d7-d5. This is a very popular variation for Black so we should look at it in detail, with the help of practical examples. After 5 Nc3 Black can prepare ...Qc7 with 5...a6 or counterattack after 5...Nc6 6 g3 with either 6...Bc5 or 6...Qb6, in both cases aiming to drive the white knight from the centre. Alternatively White could answer 5...Nc6 with 6 a3 to prevent a pin with ...Bb4.

Theoretical?

Very much so. You will need to know some concrete lines as both White and Black.

Game 8

□ **Adianto** ■ **Espinosa**

Istanbul 2000

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 d4 cxd4 4 Nxd4 e6 5 Nc3 a6

Black defends the b5-square so that he can play ...Qc7 without being bothered by Ndb5.

6 g3 Qc7 (Diagram 5) 7 Bg2!?

White gambits the c-pawn in return for a lead in development. In-

stead the defensive 7 Qd3 let Black equalise easily in Kasparov-Kramnik, London Match 2000, after 7...Nc6 8 Nxc6 dxc6 9 Bg2 e5 10 0-0 Be6 11 Na4, when a draw was agreed. That insipid draw makes quite a contrast with the fire of Kasparov's attacking play versus Mikhalchishin!

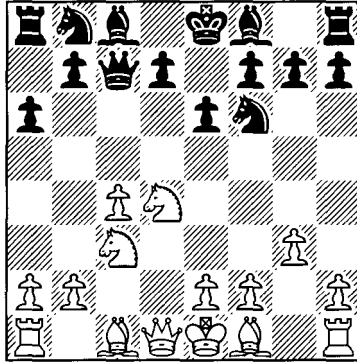


Diagram 5
Black hits c4

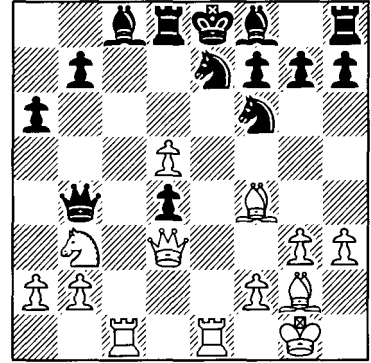


Diagram 6
Black is under pressure



NOTE: In Sicilian type positions with a small black centre consisting of pawns on d7 and e6 the best square for the black queen is almost always c7. Here she can exert influence both on the c-file and on the b8-h2 diagonal. That is why in the Sicilian Kan Black is often willing to commit the queen to c7 even before he develops any of his other pieces (1 e4 c5 2 Nf3 e6 3 d4 cxd4 4 Nxd4 a6 5 Bd3 Qc7).

7...Qxc4 8 Bf4 Nc6 9 Nb3

White gets the knight out of the way of a fork with ...e7-e6. Now there is no immediate danger to the black queen but her position is certainly uncomfortable as White has the idea of 10 Rc1 followed by 11 Nd5. Perhaps Black should have anticipated this with 9...Qb4.

9...d5?

The black d7-e6-f7 pawn centre is known from decades of master experience in the Sicilian Defence to be extremely resilient. It can survive all sorts of pressure. Therefore, having lost time by grabbing a pawn, the last thing Black should be doing is dismantling it. This move also presents White with a 'hook' on d5 which he can use to force open the centre.



WARNING: When you are behind in development, you should try to keep the position closed.

10 0-0 Qb4 11 e4!

After this White will have two big targets: the black queen and the black king!

11...d4

Black tries to keep the d-file blocked since 11...dxe4 12 Re1 regains the pawn on e4 with a strong initiative.

12 Nd5!!

A sparkling move. White gives up a piece to open lines and disrupt Black's development, preventing the king escaping from the centre.

12...exd5 13 exd5 Ne7 14 Re1

With the horrible threat of 15 d6. A long time ago I played against Karpov in a simultaneous display when he was world champion and I was a young amateur. I made a speculative sacrificial move, hoping to confuse him as I had heard that was the right thing to do in a simul. Karpov's reaction to this surprise was to pause and take a step backwards from the board. Then, after a short pause for thought, he found the complete answer to my foolhardy enterprise. In an exciting position such as this it can be worth taking a metaphorical 'step backwards' from the feverish calculation of variations and instead consider general principles. For example it is worth comparing the rook on a1 with the rook on h8, both of which are currently not involved in the struggle. The rook on h8 can never be brought into the game; meanwhile the white rook on a1 can be easily deployed to the open c-file. Thus in reality White has a large advantage in firepower despite the fact that, technically speaking, he is a piece down. Such a simple observation can tell you more about the value of a sacrifice than half an hour looking at variations.



TIP: If your opponent can't develop his pieces, there is no need to hurry – even if you have sacrificed a piece.

14...Bg4 15 Qd3 Rd8 16 h3 Bc8 17 Rac1 (Diagram 6)

Black's king's rook and bishop remain entombed and there is the threat of 18 d6 Rxd6 19 Rxc8+. The hanging bishop on c8 means that Black is also ruined after 17...Nxd5 18 Bxd5.

17...g5 18 Bd2 Qd6 19 Qxd4

Now there is no defence to 20 Bb4.

19...Nfxd5 20 Qxh8 h6 21 Bxd5!

White should only play such a move if it leads to a forced win.

21...Qxd5

Given even the slightest breathing space Black would play ...Bxh3, threatening mate on g2. But White has calculated he can do everything with check.

22 Rxe7+! Kxe7 23 Bb4+ 1-0

Game 9

□ Karpov ■ Topalov

Linares 1994

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 d4 cxd4 4 Nxd4 e6 5 Nc3 Nc6 6 g3 Bc5

Before putting his bishop on e7 Black takes time out to dislodge the knight from the d4-square. Nevertheless, I think 6...Qb6 was the better way to challenge the knight – see the next game.

7 Nb3 Be7 8 Bg2 0-0 9 0-0 d6 (Diagram 7)

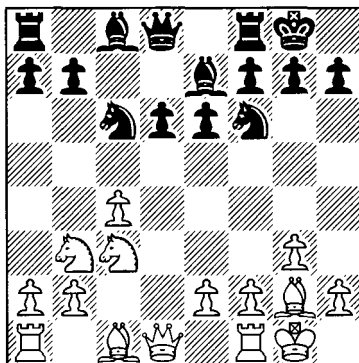


Diagram 7
Black's small centre

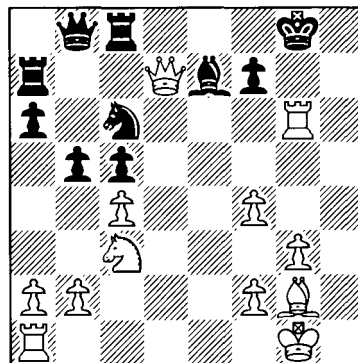


Diagram 8
Black's defences crumble

Black sets up the familiar small centre. An interesting alternative was 9...b6, planning ...Ba6 to develop the queen's bishop and attack c4.

10 Bf4!

This puts annoying pressure on d6 and seems to suggest that 9...b6 should have been preferred, not providing White with a target on d6.

10...Nh5

If Topalov thought that this would force the bishop to move away then a surprise awaited him.

11 e3!

An extremely instructive positional move. Black must now take on f4 – otherwise his last move was a waste of time.

11...Nxf4 12 exf4

Why did Karpov allow the removal of his dark-squared bishop for a knight, doubling his pawns in the process? It all comes down to the e6-pawn. If this pawn can somehow be made to advance to e5 White could then play Nd5 with a wonderful outpost in the centre. Such a knight would be worth more than either of Black's bishops. Now we see that after 12 exf4 White can attack e6 with Re1 and the advance f4-f5. White would even be willing to push his pawn as a sacrifice in some cases. If necessary, after Re1 and f4-f5 White could capture f5xe6 and, after ...f7xe6, further add to the pressure on e6 with Bh3! etc. If White is allowed to carry out this plan it will be inevitable that Black will have to play ...e6-e5 at some point, when his light squares

become weak and the dreaded Nd5 comes. Thus the change in the pawn structure has favoured White – the maligned doubled pawn is the key mover in White's strategy. The only way for Black to stop f4-f5 is with ...g7-g6, when the build-up g3-g4? to enforce this advance would loosen White's own kingside. Topalov trusts in ...g7-g6 in the game but Karpov has an alternative and deadly plan ready.

Finally, it is crucial in all this that Black has no counterplay. What is he supposed to do? He can hardly contemplate ...d6-d5, whilst the bishop on g2 is exerting so much pressure that it is difficult to arrange the ...b7-b5 break. In the game Topalov prepares ...b7-b5 in a laborious way, but it arrives too late to be more than a side-show.

12...Bd7 13 Qd2 Qb8 14 Rfe1

Now White is ready for 15 f5, when 15...exf5 16 Bxc6 would win a piece.

14...g6

The move Black had relied upon, but after...

15 h4!

White developed a decisive attack with remarkable speed.

15...a6 16 h5 b5 17 hxg6 hxg6 18 Nc5!

No doubt Black had foreseen this move but thought he could escape by using tactics.

18...dxc5 19 Qxd7 Rc8

It seems that Black will survive because 20 Bxc6 Ra7 forces the queen back along the d-file and regains the piece. However, the reply shatters this defensive device.

20 Rxe6!

The purpose of this move is to combine the winning of the e6-square for the queen with the destruction of Black's kingside pawn structure.

20...Ra7 21 Rxc6+! (Diagram 8) 21...fxg6

21...Kf8 22 Qh3 fxg6 23 Qh8+ Kf7 24 Bd5 mate.

22 Qe6+ Kg7 23 Bxc6

Black's defensive tactic has failed and he is left with a wrecked kingside.

23...Rd8 24 cxb5 Bf6 25 Ne4 Bd4 26 bxa6 Qb6 27 Rd1 Qxa6 28 Rxd4!

A fine concluding combination, during which Black loses virtually all his pieces.

28...Rxd4 29 Qf6+ Kg8 30 Qxc6+ Kf8 31 Qe8+ Kg7 32 Qe5+ Kg8 33 Nf6+ Kf7 34 Be8+ Kf8 35 Qxc5+ Qd6 36 Qxa7 Qxf6

It would have been the height of injustice if, after all White's brilliant play, Black had escaped with 36...Rd1+ 37 Kg2 Rg1+ 38 Kxc6?? Qd1+ 39 Kg2 Qh1+, forcing stalemate. But instead 38 Kh3! wins – 38...Rh1+ 39 Kg4 and the white king will escape.

37 Bh5 Rd2 38 b3 Rb2 39 Kg2 1-0

Game 10

□ Marin ■ Z.Almasi

Bled 2002

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 d4 cxd4 4 Nxd4 e6 5 Nc3 Nc6 6 g3

Here's a line that needs some care: 6 Ndb5 d5! (Black has to stop 7 Nd6+) 7 Bf4 e5 (and now the attack on c7 has to be blocked) 8 cxd5!? exf4 9 dxc6 bxc6 10 Qxd8+ Kxd8 11 Rd1+ Bd7 12 Nd6 Rb8 and White's sharp attack has led to an unclear endgame.

6...Qb6

Black has the same aim as in the previous game of forcing the knight on d4 to an inferior square, but this seems to be the superior way of doing it. Although the whole line is extremely complicated, the queen appears to be an asset on b6 rather than a target.

7 Nb3

7 Ndb5!? is a sharp alternative.

7...Ne5!? (Diagram 9)

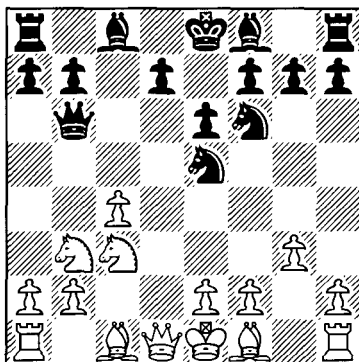


Diagram 9
An awkward threat

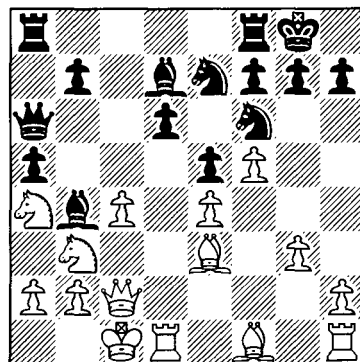


Diagram 10
Is c4-c5 dangerous?

This is Black's key move in this variation. It looks strange to move the knight again when he could be developing another piece, but it proves very annoying for White, who was hoping to develop in peace with Bg2 and 0-0 but now finds himself obliged to play some loosening moves in order to defend the c4-pawn. Of course, these so called 'loosening' moves may turn out to be strong as long as White survives the disruption with his position intact.

8 e4

Not the thematic move when you are planning Bg2, but how else can White prevent the capture on c4?

8...Bb4

And now White has to deal with the threat of 9...Nxe4. So against the 'accusation' that 7...Ne5 has lost time, it could be pointed out that this strong developing move comes with a threat.

9 Qe2 d6

Instead Black could give White doubled pawns with 9...Bxc3+ 10 bxc3 d6. However, White's dark-squared bishop would then be a strong piece. Therefore Black prefers to keep up the pressure.

10 Bd2

White prepares to castle queenside.

10...0-0 11 0-0-0 a5!

Now it is a question of whether White's pressure on the centre outweighs Black's attacking chances against his king. Personally speaking, I would much prefer to be on the black side here and the result of the game confirms this opinion. If nothing else, it is easier to play attacking moves than find subtle positional moves, especially when your king is in the firing line.

12 f4 Nc6 13 Be3 Qa6 14 Na4

White blocks the advance of the rook's pawn and plans to embarrass the black queen, who is very short of squares thanks to the prospect of Qc2 followed by a discovered attack by the bishop with c4-c5. If now 14...Nxe4 the centre becomes open to White's advantage after 15 a3 Bc5 16 Naxc5 Nxc5 17 Nxc5 dxc5 18 Bxc5.

14...e5!

A thematic move that increases Black's grip on the central dark squares. As will be seen the d4-square becomes a serious hole in White's position. Furthermore, it allows Black to play ..Bd7 next without worrying about the response e4-e5. There is also the immediate threat of 15...Bg4.



TIP: If you can combine a logical move with a threat then it is normally a sign that it is a good idea.

15 f5

Perhaps White should bail out with 16 c5 Qxe2 17 Bxe2 with murky complications – even if he loses a pawn his piece pressure in the centre is very strong.



TIP: The best way to meet an attack on the king is by exchanging queens.

15...Bd7

At last the bishop is developed, and here there lurks a threat to the knight on a4.

16 Qc2

White continues his plan but it backfires due to Black's dynamic play.

16...Ne7! (Diagram 10) 17 Nb6

Or 17 c5 b5!? 18 cxb6? Qb7! with the dual threats of 19...Bxa4 and

19...Rac8.

17...a4! 18 Nxa8 Rxa8

Not 18...axb3 19 Qxb3 and the bishop on b4 hangs. Black is happy to sacrifice the exchange to get a blistering attack.

19 Nd2 a3 20 b3 Rc8 21 Bg5 b5 22 Bxf6 gxf6 23 Kb1 Qb7 24 Bd3 Nc6!

Now White finds he can't adequately guard both the c4-square and the d4-square. Letting Black play 25...Nd4 would be terrible, but as played his king's defences crumble.

25 Nf3 Na5 26 Ka1 bxc4 27 bxc4 Ba4!

The point is 28 Qxa4 Bc3 mate.

28 Qc1 d5! 0-1

White resigned as 29 exd5 e4! 30 Bxe4 Rxc4 is gruesome.

Game 11

☐ J.Horvath ☒ Kosten

Reims 2002

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 d4 cxd4 4 Nxd4 e6 5 Nc3 Nc6 6 a3

White decides it is worth investing a tempo to rule out ...Bb4.

6...Nxd4 7 Qxd4 b6 8 e4

To become a good chess player you have to learn all the principles of positional play. Then, having learnt them all thoroughly, you have to train yourself to be extremely sceptical about their value during an individual game. Principles are at best approximations to the truth – sometimes they can be entirely wrong. This is just as well for if it were not the case it wouldn't be possible to win a game against a player who knew all the principles as he could draw on his knowledge to make one decent move after another. Here, for example, White plays an entirely natural sixth move, preventing ...Bb4, so what could be more consistent than gaining space with 8 e4? In fact there was a better plan, but it depends on a subtle appreciation of the position. It is no wonder it was discovered by Victor Korchnoi, one of the most creative chess minds of all time. He found 8 Qf4!, placing the queen on an active and safe square before playing e2-e4. Then 8...Bb7 9 e4 (only now!) 9...d6 10 Bd3 Be7 11 Qg3! 0-0 12 Bh6 Ne8 13 Bd2 Rc8 14 0-0 gave White a slight but pleasant space advantage in Korchnoi-Sax, Wijk aan Zee 1991.

We often read in books that 'gaining space with e2-e4 is a good idea', but never that 'Qf4 and Qg3 is a good manoeuvre' – so learn to look at the position in front of you.



WARNING: Never blindly trust a half-remembered idea lurking in your brain.

8...Bc5 9 Qd1 (Diagram 11)

Alas, the queen has been barred from the kingside by her own pawn.

She is much less effective on d1.

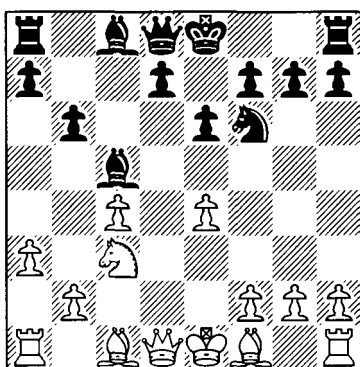


Diagram 11
The queen returns to base

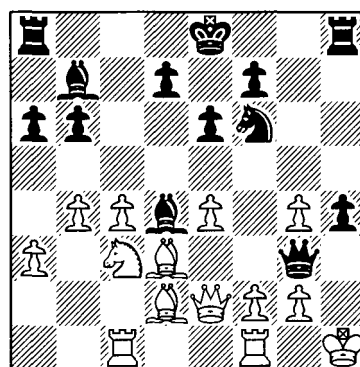


Diagram 12
Black's Brilliancy

9...Qc7!

The familiar square for the queen in this type of centre – yes, this is a principle that was worth remembering!

10 Bd3 Bb7 11 Qe2

Black has active piece deployment but he is still suffering from a space disadvantage. Now he has to decide what to do about the threat of 12 e5, driving his knight back to g8.

11...h5

A good decision. Black prepares to answer 12 e5 with 12...Ng4 when it is a case of the hunter being hunted. And after...

12 h3 h4!

...the knight has the h5-square.

13 b4?

Another stereotyped decision. On his excellent Flank Openings website at Chesspublishing.com the winner of this game gives the correct line for White in 13 Nb5! Qb8 14 e5 Nh5 15 b4 Be7 16 0-0 a6 17 Nc3 and concludes that White might still have a slight edge.

13...Qe5!

Evidently White had thought he was driving the bishop back to e7, as 13...Bd4? 14 Nb5 Qe5 15 f4 wins. If he had looked more closely at the tactical lines he would have seen that Black can play this strong preparatory move that wins time for 14...Bd4. It would have been unavailable after the immediate 13 Nb5 as 13...Qe5 doesn't attack a rook on a1 and so would just lose time after 14 f4 etc.

TIP: Make sure you play your moves in the best order.

14 Bd2 Bd4 15 Rc1 a6 16 0-0?



This castles into the attack. Tony Kosten gives 16 f4! Qh5 17 e5 Bxc3 18 Bxc3 Qxe2+ 19 Bxe2 Nh5 20 Bxh5 Rxh5 as an equal endgame, though I wouldn't particularly like to defend it as White as there is a target on g2 that can be attacked again after ...g7-g5, breaking up the white kingside. Nevertheless the discomfort here is nothing compared to what White suffers in the actual game.



TIP: Endings with rooks and opposite coloured bishops are often drawish; pure opposite bishop endgames can sometimes be drawn when a player is two or more pawns down. Consequently if you are struggling in the middlegame, head for such an endgame.

16...g5!



TIP: If everything is quiet and fixed in the centre, a player is justified in launching an all out attack on one of the wings.

17 Kh1 g4 18 hxg4 Qg3!! (Diagram 12)

A beautiful move which helped this game win a Brilliancy Prize.

19 Be3

Forced in view of 19 fxg3 hxg3, mating, while otherwise 19...Nxg4 would lead to mate on h2.

19...Nxg4!

There is just no stopping the attack.

20 fxg3 hxg3+ 21 Kg1 Nxe3 22 Rf2

Otherwise the knight moves from e3 with a killer discovered check.

22...Nf5! 23 exf5 gxf2+ 24 Qxf2

A sad necessity as 24 Kf1 Rh1 is mate.

24...Bxf2+ 25 Kxf2 Ke7

It's a pity White didn't resign here when the game just qualifies as a miniature. Instead he lingered on for another 21 or so moves:

26 Ne4 exf5 27 Ng3 f4 28 Re1+ Kf6 29 Ne4+ Bxe4 30 Rxe4 Rh4 31 Rd4 Ke7 32 Be4 Rg8 33 Bb7 a5 34 c5 bxc5 35 Re4+ Kd6 36 bxa5 Kc7 37 a6 Kb6 38 Re7 Rd8 39 Rxf7 c4 40 a4 c3 41 Rf5 f3 42 Rb5+ Ka7 43 gxf3 Rc4 44 Rb1 d5 45 Ke3 d4+ 46 Kd3 c2 and White resigned after a couple of moves that are garbled on my database...0-1

Rubinstein Variation

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 Nc3 d5 4 cxd5 Nxd5 5 g3 Nc6 6 Bg2 Nc7 (Diagram 13)

The Rubinstein Variation is characterised by the knight retreat to c7. Instead Black would love to be able to leave the knight on its good centre square and play 6...e5? but, alas, it fails to the tactic 7 Nxe5!, when 7...Nxc3 8 Nxc6 Nxd1 9 Nxd8 will leave White with an extra pawn.

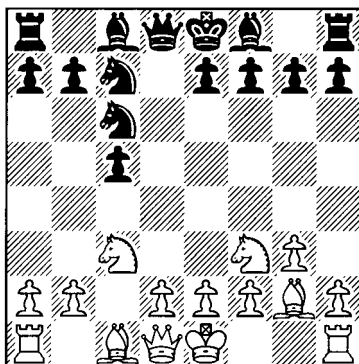


Diagram 13
The knight is happy on c7

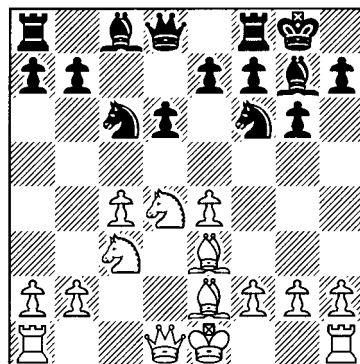


Diagram 14
Sicilian Maroczy Bind

Theoretical?

It's a good idea to know something about the pawn sacrifice discussed below, but this isn't overly theoretical.

Strategies

Don't be deceived into thinking that the black knight belongs on b6 in this type of centre, despite the fact that it retreats there in the Reversed Dragon and Pseudo-Grünfeld. If Black has a choice he will always prefer to have it on c7. Most importantly, compared to a knight on b6, on c7 the knight doesn't obstruct ...b7-b6, which consolidates the c5-pawn. And from c7 it can be manoeuvred to e6 where it bolsters the c5-pawn and the d4-square, and may even go to d4 itself. The d4-square isn't technically an outpost square as the knight could be evicted with e2-e3, but White would certainly think carefully before playing this move as it leaves the d3-pawn backward and on an open file.

7 d3 e5 8 0-0 Be7 9 Nd2!

The best move. White uncovers the diagonal of his king's bishop with the immediate positional threat of taking on c6. Meanwhile the knight heads for the c4-square to put pressure on e5 and at the same time clears the way for f2-f4, striking once more at the black centre.

9...Bd7

Experience suggests that White has the significantly better chances if he gets to double the black pawns, after 9...0-0 10 Bxc6, for example. This scenario is discussed in the note to move 12, below.

Black has set up a Maroczy Bind with colours reversed. It is interesting to compare this position with one that arises in the Sicilian Accelerated Dragon after 1 e4 c5 2 Nf3 Nc6 3 d4 cxd4 4 Nxd4 g6 5 c4 Bg7 6

Be3 Nf6 7 Nc3 0-0 8 Be2 d6 (Diagram 14)

We can clearly see that Black's deployment in the Rubinstein has had to be much more modest due to the fact that he is a tempo down. In the Sicilian line White has played Be3 and kept the knight on d4; in the Rubinstein line Black has (for tactical reasons) had to play ...Nc7 and then develop more passively with ...Bd7 to protect his pawn structure. In the Sicilian line White would have to abandon his hold on d4 with the faintly absurd sequence 9 Nc2 Nd7 10 Bd2 to create a mirror image of the Rubinstein game. Nevertheless, the Rubinstein Variation sets up an impressive black pawn structure – the pawns on c5 and e5 create a pincer against the d4-square. It isn't in many openings that Black gets a space advantage right from the start. It is all very well to say that Black's pieces are on inferior squares compared to the Sicilian Maroczy, but what can White actually do about it? White can't easily free himself with the natural d3-d4 break, and so has to arrange the f2-f4 pawn stab at e5, which involves a definite weakening of his own centre. In fact it is possible that an inexperienced player won't even realise he should be trying for f2-f4. He could well wander around planlessly with his pieces while Black builds up in the centre and finally hits him on the head.

10 Nc4 0-0!?

The alternative is 10...f6, defending the e5-pawn, when Lautier-Leko, Batumi 1999 continued 11 f4 b5 (practically forced to drive back the knight, as 11...exf4 12 Bxf4 introduces the possibility of 13 Nd6+) 12 Ne3 Rc8!? (evacuating the rook from the danger diagonal) 13 a4 b4 14 Nb5 exf4 15 Nc4!? Nxb5 16 axb5 Nd4 with complex play. Both pawn structures look loose.

11 Bxc6 Bxc6 12 Nxe5 Be8 (Diagram 15)

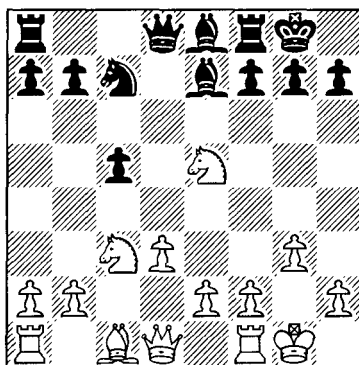


Diagram 15
Black sacrifices a pawn

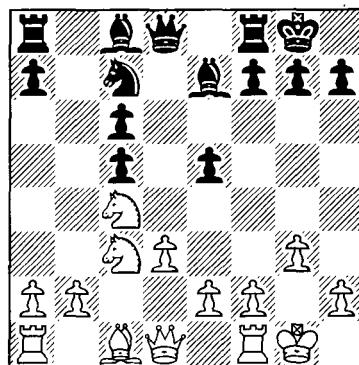


Diagram 16
A position Black should avoid

Back at move nine Black wasn't interested in accepting doubled pawns on the queenside in return for White's light-squared bishop,

but here he is willing to give up the e5-pawn to gain the bishop! How can this change of mind be explained? It is a question of open lines and the control of key squares. At move nine, consider the plausible continuation 9...0-0 10 Bxc6 bxc6 11 Nc4 (**Diagram 16**) (11 Qa4 might also be good) with the following position:

Here the white knight has a beautiful outpost on c4, from where it can never be dislodged by a pawn. Nor can Black play ...Bc6 to seize the diagonal – there is a black pawn blocking this square. Thus the semi-blocked nature of the position makes it difficult for Black to exploit the bishop pair or strike a serious blow against the white king.

Now look again at the diagram (in the Kasparov game) after 12...Be8. The white knight is floating on e5 and will have to retreat once attacked by ...Bf6. Here there is no sanctuary on c4, as it can be dislodged by ...b7-b5. So the knight is much less happy here. Secondly, the black bishop has retreated to e8, but once the knight is ejected from e5 it can go to c6 when it enjoys a strong diagonal (there is no pawn blocking this square). And thirdly, after 13...Bf6 next move and the retreat of the white knight, the dark-squared bishop can go to d4 (there is no black pawn on e5 hindering its activity). Finally a black rook can exploit the open e-file by attacking e2 with ...Rfe8. This latent threat is likely to persuade White to weaken his pawns with e2-e3, as occurs in the game. Thus we see that the balance of piece activity is much more favourable to Black after the pawn sacrifice than in the doubled pawn line.

Nevertheless, to paraphrase George Orwell: it should be remembered that all pawns are equal but some pawns are more equal than others. Black is making a serious sacrifice by giving up his important e-pawn.

Game 12

□ **Piket** ■ **Kasparov**

KasparovChess GP Internet 2000

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 Nc3 d5 4 cxd5 Nxd5 5 g3 Nc6 6 Bg2 Nc7 7 d3 e5 8 0-0 Be7 9 Nd2 Bd7 10 Nc4 0-0!? 11 Bxc6 Bxc6 12 Nxe5 Be8 13 Qb3 Bf6 14 Ng4 Bd4

Black hopes to prove the knight is badly placed on g4, but after f2-f3 and Nf2 it turns out to be well placed, defending the d3-pawn. Perhaps 14...Bc6 15 Nxf6+ Qxf6 should have been preferred.

15 e3!

White wisely erects barriers in the centre. A typical Kasparov king-side attack follows after 15 Qxb7 f5! etc.

15...Bxc3 16 Qxc3 b6 17 f3! Bb5 18 Nf2 (Diagram 17) 18...Qd7 19 e4

It isn't very pleasant to have to give away the d4-square, but White needed to develop his queen's bishop and Black could anyway have practically forced this move with ...Rfe8, intending ...Nd5 etc.

19...Ne6 20 Be3 a5 21 Rad1 Rad8 22 Rd2 Qc6

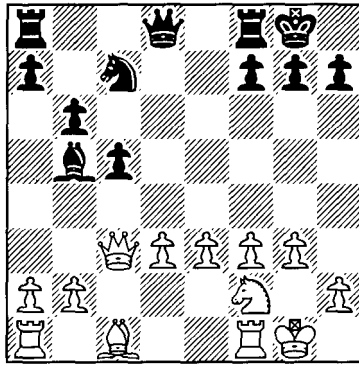


Diagram 17
The knight returns

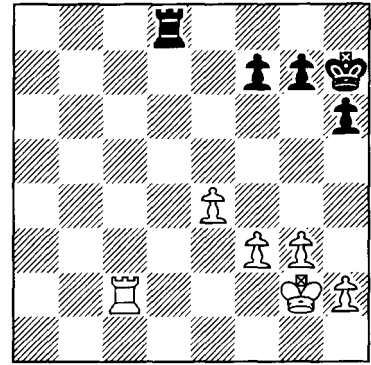


Diagram 18
A book draw

Black has a lot of piece play but there is no way to destroy White's central fortress. A state of dynamic equilibrium has arisen which is only broken because Black seems to lose patience.

23 Rc1 Qb7 24 a3 Nd4 25 Kg2 Rc8?

This looks like a significant error as it gives White the chance to open lines in a favourable way with the b2-b4 break. Instead 25...a4 fixes the queenside and threatens 26...Nb3. If then 27 Bxd4 Rxd4 28 b4 axb3 29 Qxb3 Ba4!? Black seems to be okay, his queenside pawns being much more secure than in the game.

26 Rb1!

Avoiding the trick 26 Bxd4? cxd4 when the rook on c1 will drop. But now the capture on d4 really is threatened, which means that Black has no time to play 26...a4 to lessen the effect of b2-b4.

26...Rfd8 27 Bxd4! Rxd4 28 b4!

This thematic advance ruins Black's queenside.

28...axb4 29 axb4 Qd7 30 bxc5 bxc5 31 Rbb2 h6 32 Ra2 Kh7 33 Ra5 Rd8 34 Qxc5 Bxd3 35 Rxd3?



TIP: It is well known that when there are pawns on only one side of the board the knight's ability to control squares of both colour makes it more valuable than a bishop, whose long range powers become less relevant. Therefore White should have kept the minor pieces on the board and played for the attack (with 35 Ra7!, for example).

35...Rxd3 36 Nxd3 Qxd3 37 Ra2 Qb3 38 Qc2 Qxc2+ 39 Rxc2 (Diagram 18)

The endgame is now a book draw, although not without some discomfort for the defender. Kasparov puts his pawns on the correct squares to make it difficult for White to create a passed pawn.

39...h5! 40 f4 g6 41 e5 Rd3?

The rook should have stayed on its second rank with 41...Rd7!, for after White's rook infiltrates Black's defence crumbles.

42 Kh3 Re3 43 Kh4 Kg7 44 Kg5 Re1 45 Rc7 Re2 46 Re7 Ra2 47 f5 gxf5 48 e6 h4 49 Rxf7+ Kg8 50 Kf6 1-0

The passed pawn is unstoppable. To be fair to Kasparov it should be remembered that this was a rapidplay game (one hour each). I think he would have held the draw at a classical time control.

White Avoids the Rubinstein Variation

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 Nc3 d5 4 cxd5 Nxd5 5 e4

Another possibility is 5 d4, when 5...Nxc3 6 bxc3 would transpose to the Grünfeld. The attempt to keep the game in English territory with 5...cxd4 6 Qxd4 Nxc3 7 Qxc3 seems to me to be a little dangerous for Black, who is behind in development and will therefore suffer when White is first to exploit the open lines in the centre.

Black could play very sharply (after 5 e4) with 5...Nb4!? (**Diagram 19**)

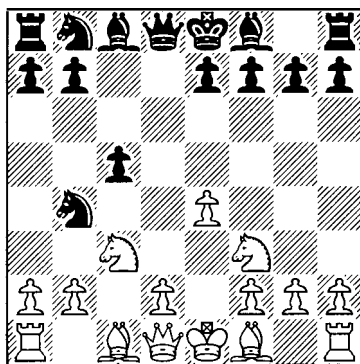


Diagram 19

The weirdest line in the English

The beginning of a somewhat bizarre manoeuvre. White cannot play 6 d4? as 6...cxd4 7 Nxd4? Qxd4! falls for a knight fork on c2. This is already the third time Black has moved the knight in the first five moves, and if 6 Bc4 he intends to move it another three times: 6...Nd3+ 7 Ke2 Nf4+ 8 Kf1 Ne6. The knight has achieved a lot, preventing White from castling and arriving on a nice centre square from where the key d4-point can be further monitored. Still, you can't expect to move a knight six times in eight moves without incurring some danger and, here, the sharp variation 9 b4!? axb4 10 Nd5!?, when White has cleared the way for d2-d4, gives White a significant initiative for the pawn.

White has another way of causing Black problems after 5...Nb4,

namely 6 Bb5+ N8c6 7 d4! (anyway!) 7...cxd4 8 a3! dxc3 9 Qxd8+ Kxd8 10 axb4 cxb2 11 Bxb2 Bd7 12 Bxc6 Bxc6. After this mass of exchanges White is still a pawn down, but with 13 Ne5! Ke8 14 Nxc6 bxc6 15 Ke2, clearing the way for his king's rook to enter the fray, his lead in development will ensure he regains one of the pawns while maintaining the pressure – after all, it isn't easy for Black to bring his king's rook into the game.

Game 13

□ Krasenkow ■ Protaziuk

Suwalki 1999

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 Nc3 d5 4 cxd5 Nxd5 5 e4 Nxc3 6 dxc3!?

We would be in the Grünfeld after 6 bxc3. With the text White secures a slight edge in the endgame.

6...Qxd1+ 7 Kxd1 Nc6 8 Kc2 e6 9 Bf4 f6?

Black is provoked into setting up a rigid structure of pawns in the centre that leaves his light squares looking sickly. He should play 9...Be7 here, though White then has a very pleasant edge.

10 Nd2 e5 11 Be3 Be6 12 Bc4!

White trades off Black's active bishop and leaves him with the inferior one. The bishop exchange also means that the important centre squares c4 and d5 are left without their natural guardian.

12...Kf7?

Black had to fight for the c4-square with 12...Bxc4 13 Nxc4 b5! etc.

13 a4! (Diagram 20)

This is a key positional move, after which Black is condemned to a miserable defence. White rules out ...b7-b5 and so secures the c4-square as a wonderful outpost for his knight.

13...Be7 14 Bxe6+ Kxe6 15 Nc4 b6 16 Rhd1 Rhd8 17 Rxd8 Rxd8 18 g4!

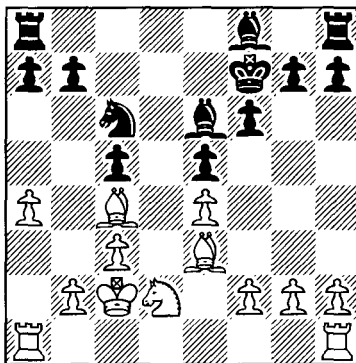


Diagram 20

White rules the light squares

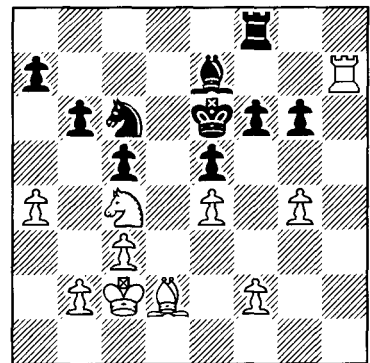


Diagram 21

White prepares Ne3

White's winning plan is to cause a disturbance on the kingside which will tie down the black king and rook. Then at the moment when the black defenders are at their most distracted he will suddenly open a second front and begin to infiltrate with his king along the weak light squares in the centre.

18...g6 19 Rg1 Rh8 20 Kd3 Kf7 21 h4 Ke6 22 h5 Rd8+ 23 Kc2 Rg8 24 hxg6 hxg6 25 Rh1 Nd8 26 Na3 Nc6 27 Rh7 Rc8 28 Nc4 Rf8 29 Bd2 (Diagram 21) 29...f5 30 Rh6 fxe4 31 Rxe6+ Rf6 32 Rxf6+ Kxf6 33 Kd3 Kg6 34 Ne3!

The knight suddenly retreats and wins the game. If Black defends the g4-pawn with 34...Kh5 then he is in effect a king down in the end-game; the black monarch can only watch the decisive invasion on the light squares after 35 Kc4 etc.

34...Bg5 35 Nxg4 Bxd2 36 Kxd2 Kg5 37 f3 Kf4 38 Ke2 a6 39 Nf6 b5 40 Nd5+ Kg5 41 Nc7 bxa4 42 Ne6+ 1-0

The Early ...Nd4

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nc6 3 Nc3 Nd4 (Diagram 22)

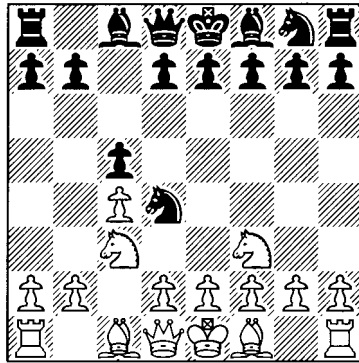


Diagram 22

Black seizes the centre

A radical way to stop 4 d4. Black breaks an elementary rule by moving a piece twice in the opening, but he would claim that after 4 e3 (the obvious response) 4...Nxf3+ 5 Qxf3 the exchange of a pair of minor pieces has helped him in a general way – he has less space so the fewer pieces he has to accommodate within his pawn structure the better. Additionally, 4 e3 isn't exactly tearing at Black's throat, so the loss of time isn't that important. In the interesting illustrative game White managed to find a way to justify his queen being on f3, but since then improvements have been found for Black. Therefore, thus far there is no refutation of 3...Nd4.

Game 14

□ Krasenkow ■ Macieja

Plock 2000

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nc6 3 Nc3 Nd4 4 e3 Nxf3+ 5 Qxf3 g6 6 b3

The logical development for the queen's bishop.

6...Bg7 7 Bb2 d6 8 g4!? (Diagram 23)

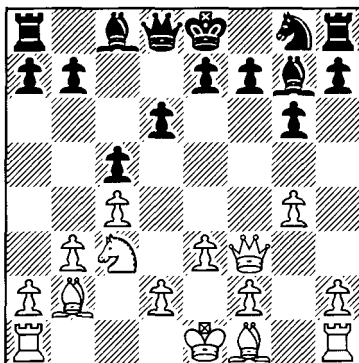


Diagram 23
Active prophylaxis

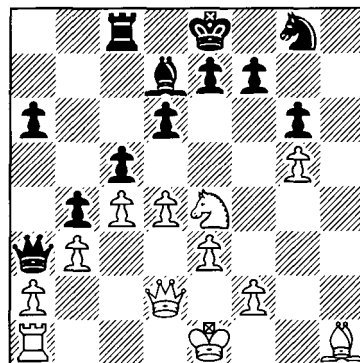


Diagram 24
White changes gear

The Polish GM comes up with an interesting plan of restraint.

8...Rb8?

It is no surprise that Black underestimated the danger from the little pawn on g4. Instead he should have got the knight out before the white pawn gets to g5: 8...Nf6! 9 g5 Nd7 10 h4 Ne5 is unclear.

9 Bg2 Bd7 10 Qe2 a6 11 g5!

In the ancient game of Arabic chess there was an opening variation called *gechi gazighi*, or the goat peg. According to a Turkish manuscript of 1501, 'It was so called because he who plays it wins with his pawns. They are like a peg in his opponent's clothes, and his opponent is like a man with his hands bound' (quoted from *Learn from the Grandmasters* by Raymond Keene). Here the g5-pawn is a peg in Macieja's clothes. It prevents the knight on g8 from developing to either f6 or h6. The alternative way out is via e7, but this will involve a serious weakening of his dark squares in the centre and kingside with either ...e7-e6 or ...e7-e5 (not something Black wants to do with the white bishop lurking on b2 and the knight on c3 ready to spring to e4 once the pin on b2 is broken).

11...b5 12 d3 Qa5 13 Rc1

Black's queenside play looks impressive, but just how is he going to bring the knight on g8 into the game?

13...h6! 14 h4 Rh7

Starting Out: The English

The point of this odd looking move is to defend the bishop and so threaten 15...b4 16 Nd5 Qxa2.

15 Ba1 hxc5 16 hxc5 Rxc1+ 17 Bxc1 b4 18 Ne4 Qa3 19 Qd2 Bxa1 20 Rxa1 Rc8

Black has been striving hard with considerable bluster on the queenside, but this last move is rather forlorn. He has run out of ideas and is still stuck with the wretched knight on g8. Krasenkow decides it is time to start his own attack, putting his opponent out of his misery.

21 d4! (Diagram 24) 21...Bc6 22 dxc5 Bxe4 23 Bxe4 Rxc5 24 f4 a5 25 Qd4 Kf8 26 Kf2 a4 27 Kf3 Ra5 28 Rh1!

White's position is now so strong that he can afford to jettison the queenside. The Goat Peg has done its deed!

28...axb3 29 Rh7 Qc1 30 Qb6

This threatens both the rook and mate on the back rank. Once Black runs out of checks the battle will be over.

30...Qf1+ 31 Kg3 Qg1+ 32 Kh3 Qf1+ 33 Bg2 Ra8

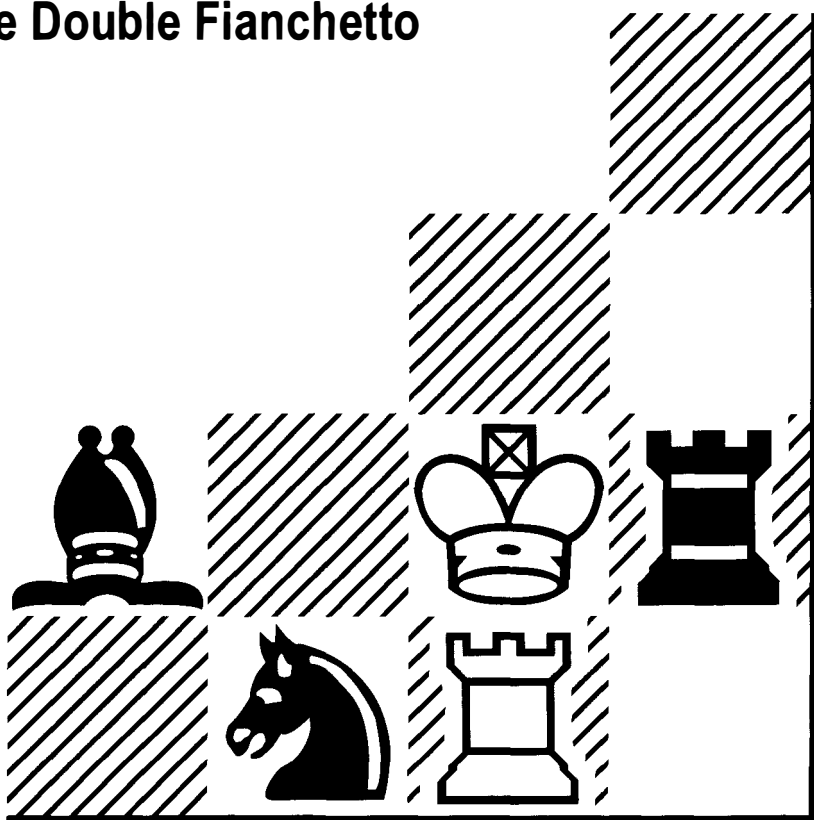
The last try, hoping for 34 Bxf1? bxa2 when Black will have a new queen. White replies by driving the rook away from a8.

34 Qb7! 1-0

Chapter Three

Symmetrical English 3: The Hedgehog

- Introduction
- Black's Vulnerable d6-pawn
- The Modern Method for White: 7 Re1
- The Double Fianchetto



Introduction

The Hedgehog is a famous system of defence that is defined by two interconnected plans. First (**Diagram 1**), Black plays ...c7-c5 and then ...b7-b6 followed by ...Bb7 to contest the control of the long diagonal of the bishop on g2.

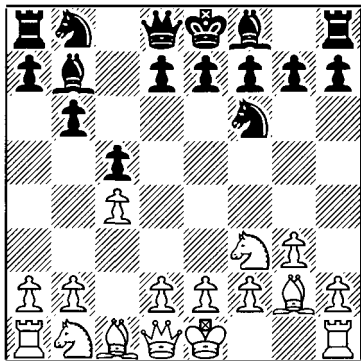


Diagram 1
Black opposes bishops

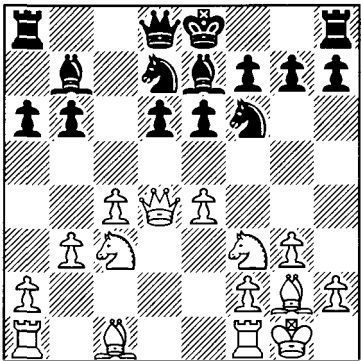


Diagram 2
A typical Hedgehog scenario

Secondly (**Diagram 2**), Black sets up a mini centre with pawns on e6 and d6, and also plays ...a7-a6, and is then ready to break if possible with ...b6-b5 or ...d6-d5. If White plays f2-f4, then ...e6-e5 is often the best response.

Theoretical?



Not particularly. But may I have a skull and cross bones, Mr. Printer!
WARNING: The difficulty of this variation doesn't depend so much on the need to know opening theory as on the extreme complexity of the manoeuvring battle that arises. You will need a lot of patience to play this well.

Strategies

The Hedgehog isn't unique to the English as it is commonly reached via Sicilian lines such as the Kan. Therefore it is no surprise that the correct strategy for both players has a Sicilian flavour to it. Thus the quiet situation in the centre, where he has a marked space advantage and the greater mobility, suggests that White should go for an all-out kingside attack. This is fine as long as at the same time he manages to keep the black centre restrained and also to prevent a ...b6-b5 break, which is by no means easy. After all, that is a lot of things for the poor human brain to think about during a game – the queenside,

centre and kingside – so it is no wonder that the best players in the world occasionally lose control when White in these positions. Indeed GM Suba, a great fan of the Hedgehog for Black, has gone as far to say that, since White has achieved his ‘ideal’ set-up right from the opening (space and mobility), his position can only go downhill, as there is no way to improve on the ideal! Meanwhile Black can keep striving for improvement with a pawn break. Normally the Hedgehog witnesses long, drawn out manoeuvring, with neither player daring to commit himself to a definite plan.

Black's Vulnerable d6-pawn

Consider the position after the typical build-up 1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 g3 b6 4 Bg2 Bb7 5 0-0 e6 6 Nc3 Be7 7 d4 cxd4 8 Qxd4 d6 9 b3 (Diagram 3)

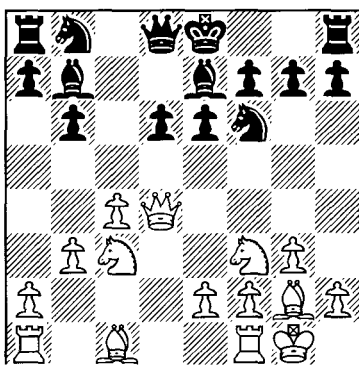


Diagram 3
The d6-pawn is a target

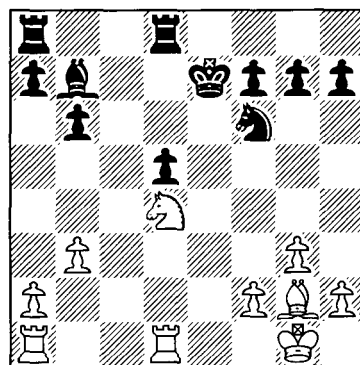


Diagram 4
White's knight is ideal

Black's 1...c5 and 5...e6 have both been very useful. The first loosened White's grip on the centre by exchanging itself for the proud white d4-pawn, while the second protected the d5-square and introduced the latent dynamic threat of a ...d6-d5 break. However, these moves have deprived the pawn on d6 of its two natural supporters.

Indeed, the pawn is rather uncomfortable as it stands on an open file, which means it can be attacked frontally by Rd1, as well as by the queen on d4. To make matters worse it can also be attacked by a knight (Nb5) or a bishop (Ba3). In order to lessen the potential pressure, at some point soon Black needs to play both ...a7-a6, to prevent Nb5, and ...Nbd7 so that, if necessary, an attack with Ba3 can be blocked by ...Nc5. But which move should he play first?

In fact Black has to be very careful with his move order. Experience shows that he should play **9...Nbd7!** first rather than 9...a6 so that he can answer 10 Ba3 with 10...Nc5, obstructing the bishop. In Ivan-

chuk-Nisipeanu, Las Vegas 1999, after 9...Nbd7 White tried to exploit the delay of ...a7-a6 with **10 Nb5**, when there followed **10...Nc5 11 Rd1 d5 12 cxd5 exd5**. The pressure on d6 has persuaded Black to acquiesce and accept an isolated pawn, but he remains very solidly entrenched in the centre. Here 13 Bb2 would be the way to keep a slight edge for White. Instead Ivanchuk tried **13 Ba3?! and there followed 13...Qd7! 14 Nc3 Ne6** (a double attack on the queen and bishop!) **15 Ne5 Nxd4 16 Nxd7 Kxd7 17 Bxe7 Nxe2+!** (a desperado move – the knight is going to be lost anyway, so why not sell it as dearly as possible?) **18 Nxe2 Kxe7 19 Nd4 Rhd8 (Diagram 4)**

White's compensation for the pawn wasn't entirely convincing, though a draw was agreed a couple of moves later. You will see in the diagram that White has his knight on an ideal square. Knights hate being attacked by pawns and operate at short range, so it stands to reason that they are best placed on the square in front of an isolated enemy pawn in the centre.

In the first illustrative game Black played the imprecise 9...a6 but wasn't punished. In fact this should have been a glorious win for the Hedgehog against a world champion. If nothing else, it is proof of Capablanca's adage that the good player is always lucky!

Game 15

□ **Karpov** ■ **Csom**

Bad Lauterberg 1977

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 g3 b6 4 Bg2 Bb7 5 0-0 e6 6 Nc3 Be7 7 d4 cxd4 8 Qxd4 d6 9 b3 a6?!

A significant inaccuracy that Karpov pounces on straightaway.

10 Ba3!

Exactly. White attacks the d6-pawn before Black has any chance to shield it with ...Nc5.

10...0-0 11 Rfd1 Ne8

A much less efficient way of defending d6 than by ...Nc5, though it provoked an unexpected reaction.

12 Bb2?

Why did Karpov lose his nerve? It isn't difficult to see that the consistent 12 Ne4! is very strong. Then after 12...d5 13 Bxe7 Qxe7 14 cxd5 Bxd5 15 Nc3 both the bishop on d5 and the b6-pawn are hanging, while after 12...Bxe4 13 Qxe4 White has exchanged his knight for the black bishop – a very good deal. An attempt to break out tactically fails: 13...d5? 14 Bxe7 Qxe7 15 cxd5 Nf6 16 d6! and White is winning.

12...Nd7 13 e4 Nc5 14 Qe3 Qb8! (Diagram 5)

Black removes his queen from the d-file before White can exploit the pin by playing 15 e5, which would have broken the hedgehog set-up. The text is more accurate than 14...Qc7 as in the future the queen on b8 might support a ...b6-b5 advance, once the bishop on b7 is moved out of the way. Furthermore, a queen on c7 sometimes gets hit by a

sudden Nd5 or Nb5. And finally, Csom is planning to activate his rook on the second rank, and doesn't want the queen in the way.

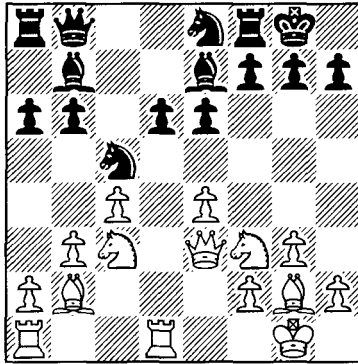


Diagram 5

A good outpost for the queen

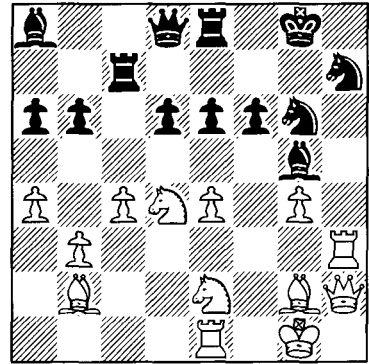


Diagram 6

Excellent defence

15 Nd4 Nf6 16 h3

Karpov feels that he has restrained Black sufficiently and now begins the prescribed kingside pawn advance. Of course, it is okay to move the pawns in front of your king if you can keep your opponent's pieces bottled up, but if you lose control it can lead to disaster. As this game shows, even a great player like Karpov can't always keep control!

16...Rc8

Black shows he is unruffled by White's kingside build-up by moving his rook way.

17 g4 h6!

Csom has devised a deep method of defence that requires he clear the h7-square for his knight.

18 f4 Nh7 19 Qf2 Ra7 20 Rd2 Ba8 21 Re1 Bf6

This would be a mistake were it not for the fine idea Csom has in mind.

22 h4

It looks as if White is going to achieve 23 g5 with gain of time, when his attack is making sure progress.

22...g5!!

Brilliant positional play. There is a rule that says you shouldn't move pawns when facing a headlong attack by enemy pawns. This is because such moves create 'hooks' on which the attack can be latched. However, that rule mainly applies to situations in which players have castled on opposite wings. Here the white king also becomes a target as the pawn structure dissolves. Csom's move destroys the flexibility of White's pawns and seriously undermines his control of the impor-

tant dark square on e5.

23 hxc5 hxc5 24 fxg5

White wants to open lines for the attack, but in fact it is the black pieces that will benefit most. White had to keep the position closed with 24 f5!, even though this meant the surrender of the e5-square.

24...Bxc5 25 Rdd1

Now Black is in command of an excellent array of dark squares, namely e5, f6 and g5. He begins by rerouting his queen's knight to e5.

25...Nd7! 26 Rd3 Ne5 27 Rh3 Re8!

A mysterious rook move, but the idea is simple once you have seen it. Black defends e6 so that he can clear the second rank with ...f7-f6 without allowing Nxe6.

28 Nce2 Rc7!

The threat of 29...b5 forces White to weaken himself even more. If instead 28...b5? immediately the rook would be hanging on a7 after White took twice on b5.

29 a4 Qd8 30 Qg3 Ng6 31 Qh2 f6! (Diagram 6)

The complete answer to the attack down the h file. Black's deep defensive play has outwitted an opponent who is himself possibly the greatest strategist of all time. White is reduced to thrashing around, looking for a tactical blow whilst his centre is collapsing.

32 Rd1 Rg7 33 Nf3 Bxe4

Black is happy that the centre is opening as his own pieces are much better co-ordinated than White's, most of which are stuck offside after the unsuccessful kingside attack.

34 Rxd6 Qc7 35 Ba3 Be3+ 36 Kf1 Bc5 37 Bxc5 Qxc5 38 Rd4 Bxf3 39 Rxf3 Ne5

The g4-pawn now drops, leaving White's king terribly vulnerable. Karpov now makes a desperate attempt to confuse his opponent in a tactical melee.

40 Rh3 Nxc4 41 Qd6 Qf5+ 42 Rf3 Qb1+ 43 Rd1 Qe4 44 Rg3 Ne3+ 45 Kg1 Nxc2 46 Rxc7+ Kxc7 47 Ng3 Qa8 48 Qc7+ Kh8 49 Rd7 Nf8??

Right at the last moment Csom collapses. Surely his brilliant positional play deserved a better fate? Any great player is a tremendous fighter and here Karpov is rewarded for his fierce resistance. Instead 49...Ng5! would leave Black a piece up with very little still to do, for example 50 Nh5 (with the threat 51 Rh7+! Nxc7 52 Qg7 mate) 50...Rg8 51 Nxf6 Nf4! and White can't mate with 52 Rh7+ as after 52...Nxc7 he is in check. Therefore his own king will be mated in a couple of moves.

50 Nf5! 1-0

The threat is 51 Rh7+ Nxc7 52 Qg7 mate, while 50...exf5 51 Qh2+ Kg8 52 Qg3+ Kh8 53 Qg7 and 50...Nxd7 51 Qh2+ Kg8 52 Qg3+ Kf7 53

Qg7 are both mate. These variations wouldn't have worked after 49...Ng5 as 52 Qg3+ isn't check. According to *Anatoly Karpov's Games as World Champion 1975-77* 'Csom resigned after sitting for 15 minutes at the board with a very red face'.

This game reminds us that we always have to be looking out for tactics. Here is another example of a 'bolt from the blue' in a hedgehog type centre:

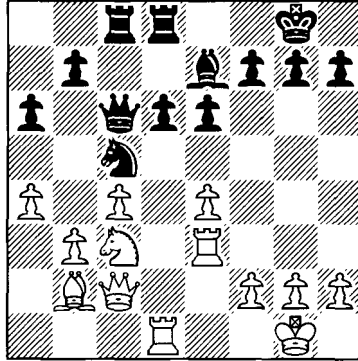


Diagram 7
A solid Hedgehog?

This position was reached in Tkachiev-Watson, London 1993. Black has a solid hedgehog centre and apparently well placed pieces. The only annoying thing for him is that he can't break out with either ...b7-b5 or ...d6-d5. White has these squares nicely covered. Still, there doesn't seem to be any danger, and Black played the natural **19...Bf6**, putting his bishop on the long diagonal. Alas, this very natural move turned out to be a disaster after **20 Nd5!! exd5**. There is no good way to decline the offer as 20...Bxb2 21 Ne7+ wins the queen. There followed **21 exd5 Qd7 22 Bxf6 gxf6 23 Rg3+ Kh8** (23...Kf8 24 Qxh7 and the combination with Re1 will lead to a quick finish) **24 Qxh7+!! Kxh7 25 Rd4 1-0**. Black resigned as there is no way to prevent mate with Rh4. A very pretty combination. Contrary to what I said above, all the black pieces turned out to be on the wrong squares!

Game 16

□ **Garcia Padron** ■ **M.Suba**

Las Palmas 1979

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 g3 b6 4 Bg2 Bb7 5 0-0 e6 6 Nc3 Be7

Writing in his excellent book *Dynamic Chess Strategy*, Suba describes 6...a6 as 'most elastic' here. However, White can then avoid the Hedgehog with 7 b3 Be7 8 Bb2 0-0 9 e3!? with the aim of proving that 6...a6 is an irrelevant move.

7 d4 cxd4 8 Qxd4 d6 9 e4

A more direct approach than 9 b3. Note, however, that White could have played the 'modern' 7 Re1 d6 8 e4 a6 9 d4 cxd4 10 Nxd4 as in the Psakhis game below, when he reaches a similar position to the game but with a knight on d4 rather than the queen. That is probably a better way for White to play.

9...a6

As White hasn't played 9 b3 there is as yet no threat of Ba3. Hence this nudge of the pawn, which prevents Nb5, is okay here.

10 b3 Nbd7 11 Bb2 0-0 12 Rac1 Qb8

Suba suggested the better deployment was 12...Qc7 followed by ...Rac8 and ...Qb8, when Black can keep the other rook for action in the centre – particularly for the purpose of harassing the white queen with possible discovered attacks after the centre has been opened.

13 Nd2 Rc8 14 h3 Bf8

There begins a long manoeuvring phase, with White unable to find any forceful plan. He simply moves his pieces around. No real damage is done to his position as Black also manoeuvres quietly. Nevertheless Black's manoeuvres seem slightly more purposeful as he gets his bishop to a nice square on g7.

15 Rfd1

Black has moved all his heavy pieces away from the kingside so it would be logical for White to begin an attack there. But how? Certainly not by playing a routine centralising move such as this, which takes the rook away from the 'attacking' f1-square! The immediate 15 f4? allows 15...d5!, a thematic response which is tremendous here as 16 cxd5?? Bc5 drops the queen. Another pawn thrust is 15 g4, but 15...g6 is safe enough as 16 g5 e5 (even stronger might be 16...Nh5) 17 Qe3 Nh5 leaves the black knight pointing at the f4-square. So perhaps 15 Kh1 was the best idea, getting the king out of the potential pin, when 15...Bc6 16 f4 begins an attack.

15...Bc6 16 Qe3 Ra7 17 Nf3 Ba8 18 Nd4 Re8 19 Qd2 g6 20 Kh2 Bg7 21 Nde2? (Diagram 8)

After a series of insipid but undamaging moves White finally cracks and plays a move which is insipid and bad! Under no circumstances should he have let Black advance the b-pawn. He had to carry on marking time, for example with 21 Re1. Of course it is psychologically very difficult to continue to do nothing.

21...b5!

After waiting patiently throughout the tiresome manoeuvring phase, Suba pounces on White's mistake.

22 cxb5 axb5

By liquidating the c4-pawn Black has lessened his opponent's grip on d5, which clears the way for a second, even more powerful pawn break with ...d6-d5. This second pawn break will be abetted by ...b5-b4, which drives the knight from c3 and so weakens White's control of

d5 and e4. As a final bonus, the rook on a7 suddenly finds itself in possession of an open file, aiming at the a2-pawn.

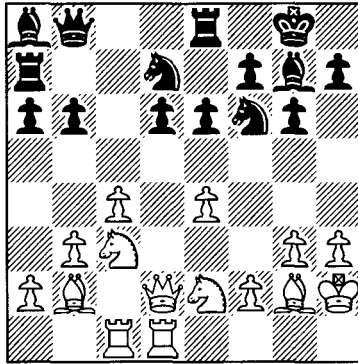


Diagram 8
White finally cracks...

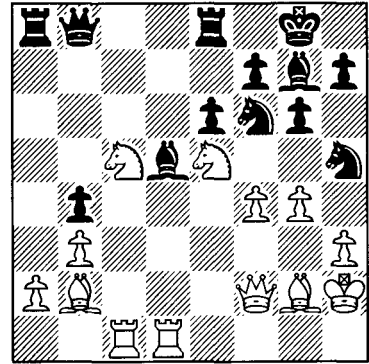


Diagram 9
Who is winning?

23 f3

This is an ugly move as it weakens the dark squares and makes the bishop on g2 look feeble. However, he had to deal with the threat of 23...b4, winning the e4-pawn.



TIP: It is a sure sign that something has gone wrong for White in a Kings Indian type set-up if he has to play both f2-f3 and h2-h3.

23...b4 24 Na4 d5

Suba remarks with silent glee that White's whole strategy has been geared to preventing ...b7-b5 and ...d6-d5, yet he has still been unable to prevent either of these advances. It just shows what a difficult opening the Hedgehog is.

25 exd5 Bxd5 26 Nd4 Ra6 27 Qf2 Nh5

This looks strong as there is the threat of 28...Nxg3! 29 Qxg3 Be5, but after the game Suba says he should have played 27...e5 followed by 28...e4.



TIP: Don't play for traps – unless they are brilliant, such as the one Suba sets in this game!

28 f4 Ndf6 29 Nc6 Qb7 30 Ne5 Raa8 31 Nc5 Qb8 32 g4? (Diagram 9)

White falls for the trap. It looks like he has found a winning combination...

32...Nxf4! 33 Qxf4 Rxa2 34 Rc2

Only now does White realise that the forced mate he had prepared is a mirage:

34 Ncd7 Nxd7 35 Qxf7+ Kh8, planning 36 Nxg6+ hxg6 37 Qxg7 mate

doesn't work because the knight on e5 is pinned by the queen! The rest is a carve up.

34...Rxb2! 35 Rxb2 Nxb4+ 36 Qxb4

Fleetingly things look very healthy for White, a rook and a knight up, but now comes retribution on the dark squares.

36...Qxe5+ 37 Kh1 Qxb2 38 Bxd5 exd5 39 Qd7 Re2 40 Qd8+ Bf8 41 Qb8 Qc2 0-1

Game 17

□ Karpov ■ Gheorghiu

Moscow 1977

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 g3 b6 4 Bg2 Bb7 5 0-0 e6 6 Nc3 Be7 7 d4 cxd4 8 Qxd4 d6 9 b3 0-0 10 Rd1

This game was played in Karpov's first competition after his hair-raising experience with Csom in the illustrative game above. It soon becomes evident that he is looking for a quieter life.

10...Nbd7 11 Bb2 a6 12 Qe3 (Diagram 10)

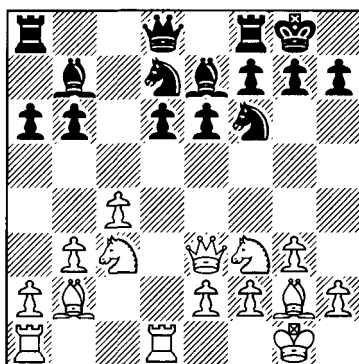


Diagram 10
White prepares Nd4

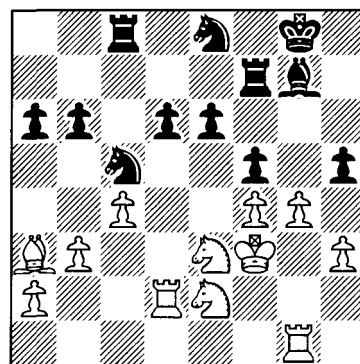


Diagram 11
Time to attack!

White makes no attempt to seize space with 12 e4. Instead he clears the way for 13 Nd4 to trade off both the light-squared bishops and the queens. This approach looks harmless; indeed it is almost as if White is doing his opponent's work for him as the exchange of bishops is one of Black's aims in this line. But it should be remembered that Karpov hardly ever played for a draw with White while he was world champion. As usual, his quiet play in the opening is the prelude to an awesome positional attack.

12...Qb8?

Black is in too much of a hurry to exchange queens.



NOTE: In the Hedgehog, the exchange of queens usually favours White. This is because a lot of the dynamism vanishes and so White

can try to exploit his space advantage without risking falling victim to a counterblow, especially against his king.

An active approach for Black was 12...Qc7 13 Nd4 Bxg2 14 Kxg2 Ne5!, while if Black wants to exchange queens he should at least wait until circumstances are more favourable. In the following extract you will see that, compared to the Karpov game:

1. White's king is on a worse square – g1 rather than g2 – when the queen's are exchanged.
 2. More importantly, Black prevented White gaining space with e2-e4.
 Here it is: 12...Re8 13 Nd4 Bxg2 14 Kxg2 Bf8 15 Rac1 Qc7 16 h3 Rac8 17 Ba3 Qb8 18 Kg1 Qa8 19 Qf3 Qxf3 20 Nxf3 Nc5 21 Bb2 Nfe4! 22 Nd4 Nxc3 23 Bxc3 Red8 was a quick draw in Ribli-Gligoric, Vrbas 1977.

13 Nd4 Bxg2 14 Kxg2 Qb7+ 15 Qf3 Qxf3+ 16 Nxf3 Rfc8 17 Nd4!

The knight returns to d4 immediately in order to intensify the restraint of ...b6-b5 and clear the way for the space gaining f2-f4.

17...Rab8 18 Rac1 h6 19 e4

Black is reduced to paralysis and the text ensures he will never be able to break out with ...d6-d5.

19...Ne8 20 f4 Bf6 21 Kf3!

White would never have been able to employ his king so actively if there were still queens on the board. Here the monarch performs an excellent role by defending e4, thus freeing the knight on c3 to manoeuvre.



TIP: The king is a strong piece: Use it!

21...Rb7 22 Ba3

White is in no hurry to force the issue with a kingside pawn advance. First, every piece is brought to its optimum square. By attacking d6 the bishop compels Black into playing ...Nc5, when the knight is less able to oppose the looming kingside advance.

22...Rbc7 23 Nce2 Nc5

This would become necessary sooner or later as White intends Nc2 with a double attack on d6.

24 Rd2 g6 25 Nc2!

The knight heads for e3 where it supports a pawn attack without blocking the d-file. Therefore the knight on e8 remains tied down to preventing Rxd6 and consequently cannot oppose the kingside advance.

25...Bg7 26 Ne3 f5

A desperate move. Black cannot bear to wait any longer while White builds up with moves like g3-g4, h2-h4, h4-h5 and Ng3.

27 exf5 gxf5 28 h3 h5 29 Rg1 Rf7 30 g4 (Diagram 11)

At last the attack comes. Thanks to his much superior piece deployment White's king can watch calmly whereas his counterpart is in great danger.

30...hxf4+ 31 hxf4 fxf4+ 32 Rxf4 Kf8 33 Ng3 a5 34 Rg6 Ke7 35 f5!

The black king hasn't managed to escape. The threat is 36 Bxc5, when e6 drops.

35...Rf6

Things also fall apart after the alternative 35...exf5 36 Nd5+ and 37 Nxb6.

36 Rxf6 Nxf6 37 Re2 Rf8

The only chance was the move 37...e5, though 38 Bxc5 bxc5 39 Ne4 leaves Black with a horrible bishop and gaping holes on the light squares.

38 Bxc5 bxc5 39 fxe6 Kxe6 40 Nef5+ 1-0

After 40...Kf7 41 Re7+ White wins the bishop. A wonderful demonstration of positional play by Karpov.

The Modern Method for White: 7 Re1!?

An interesting idea for White is **1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 g3 b6 4 Bg2 Bb7 5 0-0 e6 6 Nc3 Be7 7 Re1!?**

I have used the term 'modern' for convenience as 7 Re1 is a fairly new idea, rather than to suggest that it has superseded the 'classical' 7 d4. In fact both are played regularly these days. The idea behind 7 Re1 is simple. In the classical line after 7 d4 cxd4 White has to decide how to recapture. In fact he doesn't have much choice as allowing the exchange of bishops after 8 Nxd4 Bxg2 9 Kxg2 means that he has weakened his kingside with g2-g3 for no good reason. Consequently it has to be the recapture with the queen, but the queen is no better on d4 than d1 and may even be a target. One day a chess player must have sat down and daydreamed about being able to play Nxd4 without allowing the bishop exchange. The result of this daydream was **7 Re1!?** (Diagram 12)

White aims to answer 7...d6 with 8 e4, closing the diagonal between the bishops, when after 8...a6 9 d4 cxd4 10 Nxd4 White has achieved the best of both worlds: a knight on d4 and a bishop still on g2!

That's the sales pitch for 7 Re1. The drawback – in every new chess move there is a drawback! – is that moving the rook to e1 may prove to have wasted time when it comes to starting a kingside attack. The rook might be better on f1 to support an f2-f4 advance. Or an attacking scheme with f2-f4 followed by Rf3 and Rh3 might have been on the cards. Nevertheless, at the moment the preference at the highest level seems to be for 7 Re1 rather than 7 d4. Let's see the new move in action:

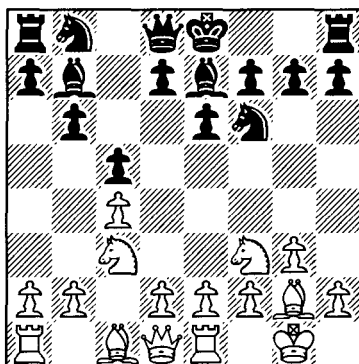


Diagram 12
White prepares 8 e4

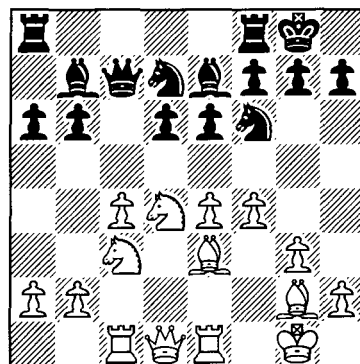


Diagram 13
Decision time

(7 Re1) 7...d6 8 e4 a6 9 d4 cxd4 10 Nxd4 Qc7

Black defends b7 as there was a threat of 11 e5!, discovering an attack on the bishop. Here we see that Black did well to play 8...a6 rather than 8...0-0, as otherwise White would be able to play the awkward 11 Ndb5 now.

11 Be3 0-0

Not 11...Qxc4 12 e5! etc.

12 Rc1 Nbd7

And now the punishment for 12...Qxc4 is the decisive 13 Nd5, so Black completes development.

13 f4 (Diagram 13)

Black must now decide how to deploy his rooks. Perhaps the most solid move is 13...Rfe8 so that 14 f5 can be answered by 14...Bf8. Here's how Black once got obliterated after 13...Rfd8:

Game 18

□ **Psakhis** ■ **Hovmoller**
Copenhagen 2000

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 g3 b6 4 Bg2 Bb7 5 0-0 e6 6 Nc3 Be7 7 Re1 d6

Instead it was possible to obstruct e2-e4 for a couple of moves with 7...Ne4. The exchange of knights should help Black.



TIP: If you have less space, exchanging off a piece will ease the congestion. After 8 Nxe4 Bxe4 9 d3 Bb7 10 e4 0-0 11 d4 cxd4 12 Nxd4 d6 13 b3 a6 14 Be3 Nd7 15 f4 Re8 16 Bf2 Qc7 Black had a solid position in Vallejo Pons-Adams, Linares 2002, though White still managed to build up an attack based on pushing the g-pawn.

8 e4 a6 9 d4 cxd4 10 Nxd4 Qc7 11 Be3 0-0 12 Rc1 Nbd7 13 f4 Rfd8 14 f5!?

White has to think long and hard before he plays a committal move like this as it leaves a big hole on e5, which would be the perfect square for a black knight. However, in this instance Black cannot exploit the hole as he needs to defend e6 with his knight by 13...Nf8 rather than put it on e5. White's alternative plan would involve g3-g4 and g4-g5 with a gradual encroachment on the kingside. However, the text looked very good after Black's reply.

14...e5?

A horrible move which just gives away the d5-square. Another bad idea is 14...exf5 15 Nxf5, when the knight on f5 and the ability to play Nd5 outweigh the e5-square.

As stated above the defensive 14...Nf8 was necessary, with a hard battle in prospect.

15 Nd5!

Black always has to watch out for a knight eruption on d5 in this type of position when he has a queen on the c-file and White a rook on c1. Sometimes White can even play it as a genuine sacrifice when Black still has a pawn on e6 as the resulting pressure after ...e6xd5 and the recapture c4xd5 can be worth a piece. Of course to play such a sacrifice depends on having very fine judgement, a quality that a player needs to develop as he becomes more experienced. In contrast, Psakhis is risking nothing here as there is no sacrifice, only a manoeuvre to open the c-file to his advantage.

15...Bxd5

The only way to try to fight it out was 15...Nxd5 16 cxd5 Nc5, when at least the bishop remains on b7 to contest the c6-square.

16 cxd5 Qb7 17 Nc6 (Diagram 14)

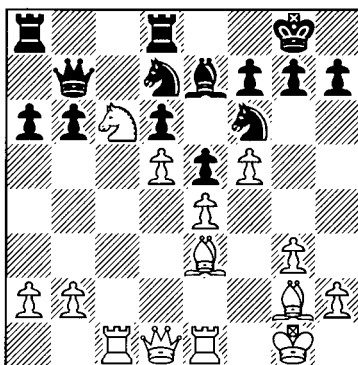


Diagram 14
Superknight!

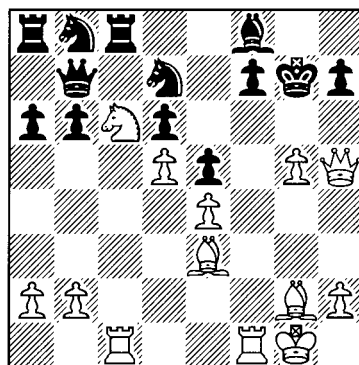


Diagram 15
The queen decides

17...Re8

A dream square – protected, central and free from a pawn attack. Now Psakhis presses home the attack before Black can eliminate the knight and free himself from its gigantic shadow.

18 g4! Nb8 19 g5 Nfd7 20 f6!

Preventing Black from closing lines with 20...f6. Here we see White's kingside pawn storm in its most deadly form. Because the black pieces are in disarray the white king is in absolutely no danger, despite all the lines opening around him. In contrast, the black king is about to be pulverised by the white pieces.

20...Bf8

In the event of 20...gxf6 White can play all the same attacking moves as in the game – Qh5, Rf1, Bh3 etc.

21 Rf1!

I don't suppose Psakhis minded much here that he had 'wasted' a tempo by playing 7 Re1 and then returning the rook to f1.

21...Rc8 22 fxg7 Kxg7 23 Qh5 (Diagram 15) 23...Nc5 24 Bh3 Re8 25 Bf5 1-0

Black never found time for ...Nxc6. It is instructive that the knight on c6 didn't take part in the direct attack but its malevolent influence caused so much chaos in Black's camp that the other white pieces were able to storm the king.

The Double Fianchetto

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 g3 b6 4 Bg2 Bb7 5 0-0 g6 6 Nc3 Bg7 (Diagram 16)

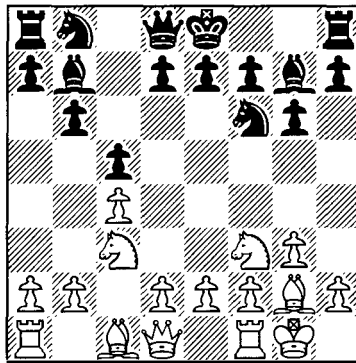


Diagram 16

Hypermodern bishops

Black plays in the true spirit of hypermodern chess, holding back the centre pawns and aiming to exert pressure on White's centre from the wings. In fact instead of creating a 'small centre' in Hedgehog style

with pawns on d6 and e6, Black has created no centre at all! The good thing about this is that there are no structural weaknesses for White to exploit – no holes on d6 or e6, for example. The bad thing is that Black hasn't yet contested White's space advantage. Sooner or later he will have to do so or else his lack of territory will lead to trouble.

This brings us to the subject of flexibility. We have seen that the pawn layout in the Hedgehog proper gave Black flexibility as he could strike out in any number of ways with his pawns. In the Double Fianchetto he has even more options when it comes to choosing a type of pawn centre. However, there is a drawback: setting up a d6-e6 pawn centre with the bishop on g7 leaves the d6-pawn more vulnerable than if Black plays the traditional Hedgehog ...Be7. Therefore most players prefer to put the bishop on e7 and only later transfer it to g7 once the defence of the d6-pawn has been secured. It is partly a question of fashion, as the Double Fianchetto has in the past featured in games of Karpov, Kasparov and other top players.

Game 19

□ **Karpov** ■ **Timman**

Amsterdam 1981

1 c4 c5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 g3 b6 4 Bg2 Bb7 5 0-0 g6 6 Nc3 Bg7 7 d4 Ne4

It looks inviting to play 7...cxd4 8 Nxd4 Bxg2 9 Kxg2, this exchange of bishops usually being a good thing for Black in the Hedgehog. Nevertheless, there is still some hidden poison in the line 9...Qc8 10 b3 Qb7+ 11 f3. Then 11...d5 is directed against e2-e4, with which White would earn a pleasant edge due to his Maroczy Bind grip on the centre. If Black had employed the set-up with d6/e6 and ...Be7 he could happily allow the Maroczy as he would be well placed to meet this with the gradual preparation of the ...d6-d5 break, but this is not the case with the bishop on g7. After (11...d5) 12 cxd5 Nxd5 13 Nxd5 Qxd5 14 Be3 Nc6 15 Nxc6 Qxc6 16 Rc1 Qe6 17 Qd3 0-0 18 Rfd1, despite the exchanges and almost symmetrical structure, White has a slight edge due to the fact that his rooks have been the first to reach the centre files. Therefore I would recommend that Black avoid this line.

8 Nxe4 Bxe4 9 d5

Karpov is never a player to refuse a space advantage.

9...0-0 10 Bh3!

Now White avoids the exchange of bishops and threatens 11 Nd2 or 11 Ng5, when the bishop on e4 is in danger of losing its life. Therefore Black has to give up the bishop for knight. Instead 10 Ne1?! allowed Black to seize the initiative in Vaganian-Timman, Niksic 1978 with the thematic pawn sacrifice 10...Bxg2 11 Kxg2 b5! 12 cxb5 Qb6 13 Qa4 Qb7 14 Qc4 d6 15 a4 a6, when Black had a good version of the Benko Gambit. Here we see the flexibility of Black's setup in its best light.

10...Bxf3 11 exf3

As in the Karpov-Topalov game (Chapter Two) the former World Champion will use the open e-file and the doubled f-pawn to his advantage.

11...e5

Timman plans to develop with ...d7-d6, ...Nd7 and ...f7-f5 with a good position.

12 f4! (Diagram 17)

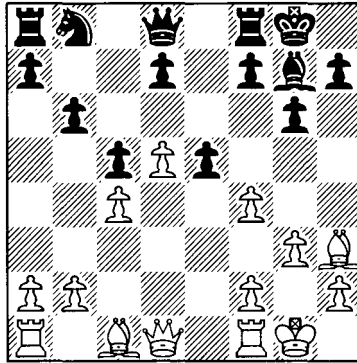


Diagram 17
White opens lines

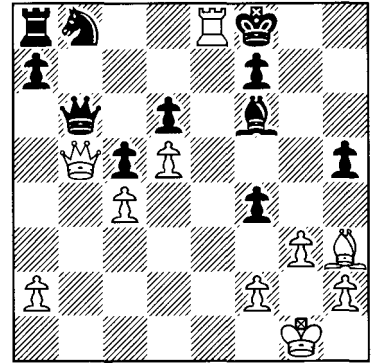


Diagram 18
White infiltrates

This pawn sacrifice is the only way to disturb Black. Karpov opens the e-file for his rooks and a diagonal for the queen's bishop.

12...exf4 13 Bxf4 Bxb2 14 Rb1 Bf6 15 Qa4!

A fine move. Black is prevented from developing his knight with ...d7-d6 and ...Nd7 almost before he thought of it! Nor can the knight go to a6. Therefore Black's queenside remains tied up. Nevertheless, White has no more pawn advances so all his pressure depends on piece play. Nor are there any obvious weaknesses in Black's pawn structure – it is difficult to attack d6. So we shouldn't exaggerate White's advantage.

15...d6 16 Rb3 h5!

An excellent defensive move. Black's pawns come to the rescue of his pieces.

17 Re1 g5

The point. If the bishop retreats Black can develop after 18...g4 and 19...Nd7, when he suddenly has winning chances. Therefore Karpov sacrifices the bishop to keep up his attack.

18 Rbe3! gxf4 19 Re8 b5!

Now a pawn thrust on the queenside clears space for the black queen.

20 Qxb5 Qb6 21 Rxf8+ Kxf8 22 Re8+ (Diagram 18) 22...Kg7 23 gxf4 Qxb5 24 cxb5

Starting Out: The English

The queens have been exchanged and Black is still a piece up, but how can he ever free his queen's rook? It looks as though he can only wait while Karpov brings up his king. However, Timman finds a way to bring the bishop to the aid of the beleaguered queenside.

24...Bc3! 25 Bf1 Ba5 26 Rc8 Kf6 27 Kg2 Ke7 28 Kf3 Bd8 29 a4 a6 30 bxa6 Kd7 31 Bh3+ Ke7 32 Bf1 Kd7 $\frac{1}{2}$ - $\frac{1}{2}$

This forced repetition is a worthy end to a well balanced fight.

Chapter Four

The Nimzo-English

- Introduction
- Main Line with 4 Qc2 or 4 Qb3
- The Startling 4 g4!?
- The Mikenas Attack



Introduction

In this chapter we look at lines in which Black adopts a Nimzo-Indian style treatment.

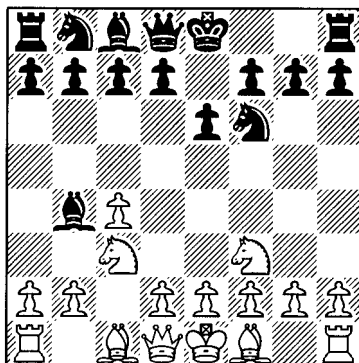


Diagram 1
Nimzo-Indian without d2-d4

A Warning about Move Order

It is important to consider the move order here. In practice the diagram position most commonly arises from the Réti move order 1 Nf3 Nf6 2 c4 e6 3 Nc3 Bb4, while another way to reach it is via 1 c4 Nf6 2 Nf3 e6 3 Nc3 Bb4. In both cases Black has achieved his set-up, but if White opens 1 c4 Nf6 2 Nc3 then he has the chance to cut across Black's plan with 2...e6 3 e4!?, the sharp Mikenas Attack. This can cause Black considerable problems. If you don't want to face this as Black you might do well to learn a different line against 2 Nc3 and save the Nimzo-English for games in which White plays Nf3 on move one or two.

Main Line with 4 Qc2 or 4 Qb3

Theoretical?

The Nimzo-English main line is positional in nature – it is more important to understand the ideas than to know lots of variations.

Strategies

Black's basic idea in answering 1 c4 Nf6 2 Nf3 e6 3 Nc3 with 3...Bb4 is to get the dark-squared bishop out of the pawn structure rather than leaving it shut behind its own pawns after ...c7-c5 or ...d7-d6. If

this means that in some lines he has to play ...Bxc3, giving up his bishop for a knight without inflicting any structural damage on White, then that is the price Black is willing to pay in order to achieve a smooth deployment of his other pieces and pawns.

We see Black's plan clearly in the two games by Michael Adams that are given here. Although he has a wide repertoire, Adams has never much liked fianchettoing his bishop on g7. Therefore if he wants to close the centre but doesn't want to fianchetto on g7 he needs to first bring his bishop out. He gets the bishop to an active square with 3...Bb4 and then puts his centre pawns on c5, d6 and e5. If he had built this centre before developing the bishop, or had put it on e7, then it would have been a passive piece, less valuable than the knight on c3 which, after 3...Bb4, he can exchange when convenient. This knight, which controls the hole on d5 created by Black's central pawn cluster c5/d6/e5, is well worth eliminating.

White, for his part, is delighted to have the two bishops and will do his best to open lines for them. Of course it is possible to take this strategy too far, as Van Wely finds in the first illustrative game. But if White succeeds in breaking down Black's centre on favourable terms then his bishop pair can become lethal. In that case Black would start wishing after all that he had kept his dark-squared bishop – even if it spent most of the time on a passive square – so that it could fight for control of the dark squares.

We see the complete triumph of White's strategy in the Anand game.

Game 20

□ **Van Wely** ■ **Adams**

Wijk aan Zee 2000

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nf3 e6 3 Nc3 Bb4 4 Qc2

By preventing the doubling of his pawns White prepares to acquire the bishop pair cleanly.

4...0-0 5 a3 Bxc3

Forced as 5...Be7 represents a loss of time and 5...Ba5?? loses the bishop!

6 Qxc3 b6

It looks as if Black is preparing ...Bb7, although, funnily enough, the bishop never gets to this square.

7 b4 a5!

Nevertheless, this pawn stab justifies the decision to play 6...b6. After the exchanges on b4 and a1 that follow it could be claimed that the board shrinks by a file as there is nothing left on the a-file. This is good news when your opponent has two long range bishops as it means your knights are less likely to be outsprinted in an endgame.

8 Bb2 d6 9 g3 axb4 10 axb4 Rxa1+ 11 Bxa1 c5 12 Bg2 e5 (Diagram 2)

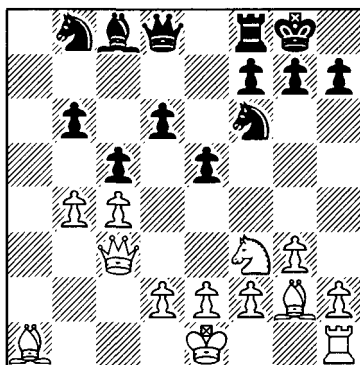


Diagram 2
Black's wall of pawns

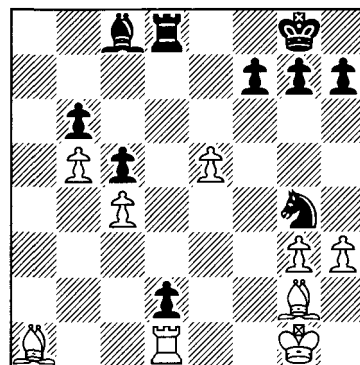


Diagram 3
The d2-pawn dominates

Black sets up the c5/d6/e5 pawn triad discussed in the introduction to the chapter. He can do it with a clear conscience now that he doesn't have a dark-squared bishop to be hampered by this plan. In contrast, White's bishop on a1 finds itself staring at a wall on e5. The outcome of the game depends on whether White manages to break down the black pawns and free this bishop. Note in all this that White's bishop on g2 possesses a wide open diagonal but it doesn't bring much joy as there is nothing to attack. In contrast, if White could crash through the e5-point either with a well timed e2-e3 and d2-d4, or f2-f4, then threats would develop against the black king.

13 0-0 Nc6 14 b5 Nd4!

This had to be carefully thought out because it seems, after a cursory glance, that Black is presenting his opponent with a target on d4 which can be used to aid a central breakthrough.

15 Nxd4 cxd4 16 Qb4 Qc7 17 e3 Qc5!

The queen arrives just in time to solidify the pawns. Otherwise 17...dxe3 18 fxe3 would have been everything White wanted: his rook on f1 comes to life and the bishop on a1 has more scope, which can be further enhanced with a well timed d2-d4.

18 Qxc5

This looks practically forced as 18 Qb3 dxe3 19 dxe3 Be6 is awkward for White because the c4-pawn is in trouble (20 d3? Qxe3+).

18...dxc5 19 f4

White achieves his desired advance but it has been at considerable cost. The exchange of queens and knights has meant that White's attacking chances against the black king have evaporated. The only hope of winning is if the bishop can somehow get to attack the b6-pawn with Bc7. This is unlikely to happen, not least because White has his own weak pawn on c4 which can be attacked much more eas-

ily with the immediate ...Be6. All these considerations become academic after White's blunder on his next move.

19...dxe3 20 fxe5??

He had to recapture with 20 dxe3, when chances are equal.

20...exd2!

A nasty surprise for White. Van Wely is a very strong GM and was unlikely to have been in time trouble at move 20 – I wonder what he missed? It isn't difficult to see that after 21 exf6 Bg4 the pawn will queen and win Black the exchange.

21 h3 Rd8 22 Rd1 Ng4! (Diagram 3)

Perhaps this is what Van Wely missed. Another black piece utilises the g4-square. Now 23 hxg4 Bxg4 wins easily for Black. White has no choice but to eliminate the passed pawn and enter an opposite coloured bishop endgame two pawns down.

23 Bc3 Ne3 24 Rxd2 Rxd2 25 Bxd2 Nxd2 26 Kxg2 Kf8 27 e6

The only way to resist is to clear a line for the bishop to attack the b6-pawn as otherwise he will just lose his queenside pawns to ...Be6.

27...Bxe6 28 Bf4 Bxc4 29 Bc7

The bishop had dreamed for the whole game of attacking the base of Black's queenside pawn chain, but not under these disastrous circumstances.

29...Ke7 30 Kf3 Bxb5 31 Bxb6 Kd6

A long and laborious phase now begins. The drawing propensities of opposite coloured bishop endgames are well known, so Adams has to tread with care. Theory states that a player who is two pawns up has to create passed pawns with a gap of at least three files between them to overwhelm a defender's well placed king and bishop. However, in this particular scenario Black can exploit the weakness of White's remaining pawns to ensure that the white pieces don't achieve their optimum squares.

For the record, here are the remaining moves: **32 h4 Kd5 33 Ke3 Bd7 34 Bd8 Kd6 35 Ba5 h6 36 Kf4 f6 37 Bd8 Ke6 38 Ke4 Bc6+ 39 Kd3 Bb5+ 40 Ke4 Bd7 41 Kd3 Kd6 42 Ke4 Bg4 43 Kf4 Bd1 44 Ke3 Bc2 45 Kd2 Bb1 46 Ke3 Ke6 47 Bb6 c4 48 Bd4 Kf5 49 Bc3 Bc2 50 Kf3 Bd1+ 51 Ke3 g5 52 Bb2 Bh5 53 Bc3 Bf7 54 Kf3 Bd5+ 55 Kf2 Bc6 56 Ke3 Ba4 57 Kf3 Bd1+ 58 Ke3 Kg6 59 Kd4 Be2 60 Bb4 Kh5 61 Bf8 f5 62 Ke5 Bd3 63 hxg5 hxg5 64 Ba3 Kg4 65 Bc1 Be2 66 Bd2 Bd1 67 Kd4 Bb3 68 Ke5 Ba2 69 Bc1 c3 70 Kd4 c2 71 Ke5 Bb3 72 Bd2 Ba4 73 Bc1 Bd7 74 Bd2 Kxg3 75 Bxg5 Kf3 76 Bc1 Ke2 0-1**

Game 21

□ Anand ■ Adams

Linares 1999

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nf3 e6 3 Nc3 Bb4 4 Qb3

A more active approach than 4 Qc2.

4...c5

Black doesn't want to play ...Bxc3 without at least 'extracting' the tempo-losing a2-a3 from White.

5 g3 Nc6 6 a3 Ba5

Black retains the tension with a retreat that wasn't possible in the Van Wely game.

7 Bg2 0-0 8 0-0 d6

Adams heads for the pawn centre with which he did so well in the previous game. Perhaps a better alternative is 8...d5!? 9 d3 h6 (to rule out the pinning Bg5), when Black is well entrenched in the centre.

9 e3!

Having seen what happened in the game above you will agree that it is a good idea for White to rule out ...Nd4.

9...e5 10 d3 Rb8 11 Nd2 Bf5 12 Nd5!?

White uses the knight to strengthen his grip on the centre before Black has the chance to change his mind and play ...Bxc3.

12...Nxd5 13 cxd5 Ne7?!

According to Anand in Informator 75 Black should have given up his distant bishop for the other knight with 13...Bxd2! 14 Bxd2 Ne7, when White has only a slight edge.

14 Nc4

White's knights should never have been allowed to evade capture by the bishop. In trying to correct his error Adams seriously weakens his centre.

14...b5?

It was far better to curl up in a ball with 14...Bc7, although 15 a4 maintains the knight on c4 and maintains a pleasant plus for White.

15 Nxa5 Qxa5 16 e4 Bd7 17 Qd1!

An excellent retreat that demonstrates White has won the strategical battle. Black must have bitterly regretted lashing out with 14...b5 as now he can no longer bolster the defence of c5 with ...b7-b6. To make matters worse White gains time with the methodical stab at c5 by attacking the black queen.

17...f5 18 b4! (Diagram 4)

This temporary pawn sacrifice clears the way for a future destructive advance d3-d4, when the proud c5/d6/e5 centre will completely dissolve. Once this has occurred White's dark-squared bishop will become a tremendous piece.

18...cxb4 19 Bg5! Nc8 20 Qd2 f4

Rather than wait for White to blast open the centre Black makes a bid for counterplay on the kingside. This involves voluntarily surrendering the pawn bastion on e5. Therefore it is no longer necessary for

Anand to engineer a d3-d4 advance; his attention should instead be focused on quelling Black's activity. Once that has been carried out White's strong centre and marvellous dark-squared bishop will give him every chance to win.

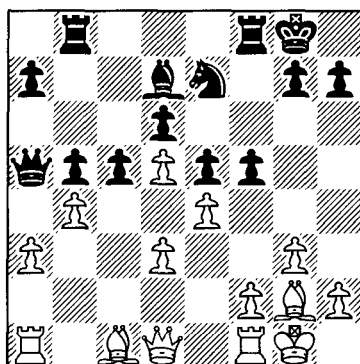


Diagram 4
White strikes

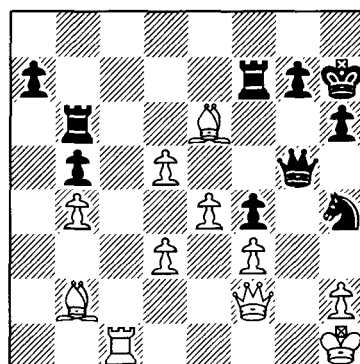


Diagram 5
The bishops rule

21 gxf4 h6 22 Bh4 exf4

Black is smashed in the centre after 22...Rxf4 23 Bg3 Rf8 24 f4! etc.

23 f3!

White clears the way for Bf2 and Bd4.

23...Qb6+ 24 Bf2 Qd8 25 axb4 Qg5

Adams is a fantastic defender and does everything possible to gain dynamic counterplay. But the logic of the position is against him – and it is difficult to trick someone rated 2781.

26 Kh1 Qh5 27 Rg1

After the game Anand thought that the crude 27 Bxa7 Nxa7 28 Rxa7 was the simpler way to win, but who could bear to part with such a beautiful bishop?

27...Rb7 28 Bd4 Rf7 29 Qf2 Kh7 30 Rgc1 Ne7 31 Ra6 Ng6 32 Rxd6 Nh4 33 Bb2 Rb6 34 Rxd7!

White kills off most of Black's swindling chances by eliminating the bishop.

34...Rxd7 35 Bh3

The bishop is suddenly transformed from a 'big pawn' on g2 into one half of a potent attacking duo.

35...Rf7 36 Bg4 Qg5 37 Be6 (Diagram 5) 37...Rfb7 38 Rg1 Qd8

Black's problem is that even if he survives the kingside attack he will be killed by the passed pawns.

39 Qf1!

Starting Out: The English

An elegant touch which echoes the quiet and equally deadly 17 Qd1!, and now the queen heads for h3 where she will cause mayhem.

39...Ra6 40 Qh3 Ra2 41 Be5 Rd2 42 d4 Rd3 43 Bf5+ Kg8 44 Bc8! Nxf3 45 Qe6+ 1-0

Black is obliterated after 45...Kh7 (45...Kh8 46 Qxh6+) 46 Qg6+ Kg8 47 Be6+ Kf8 48 Bxg7+ etc.

Thus far we have considered the main line if White plays the solid 4 Qc2 or 4 Qb3. A wholly different approach for White is 4 g4!?

The Startling 4 g4!?

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nf3 e6 3 Nc3 Bb4 4 g4!? (Diagram 6)

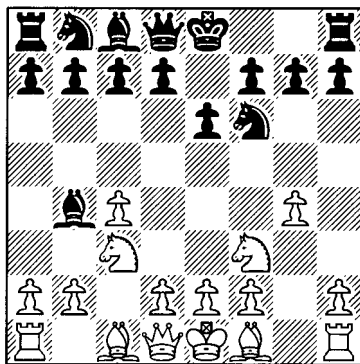


Diagram 6

White breathes fire into the game

Theoretical?

You had better learn a good line against this as Black or examine some variations if you intend to play this as White.

Strategies

I always regarded the Nimzo-English as a rather dry positional line until I saw this remarkable idea from the laboratory of GM Michel Krasenkow. The Polish Grandmaster clearly likes to push his g-pawn (see also his game against Macieja in Chapter Two).

In fact the pawn thrust is a logical response to Black's third move. As White has not yet played d2-d4 there is no pin on his knight; his centre remains very solid and is hardly going to be shattered if Black chooses to capture on c3. Therefore White can allow himself more liberties than he would dare in the main line Nimzo-Indian.

Furthermore, moving the bishop to b4 has undoubtedly weakened

Black's kingside and this justifies an immediate attack there.

The philosophy behind this line is similar to that in the Slav Defence line 1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 Nc3 c6 4 e3 Nf6 5 Nf3 Nbd7 6 Qc2 Bd6 7 g4!? etc. It also reminds me of the strategy employed by the English maverick International Master Michael Basman, who plays 1 g4!? as White. His reasoning is that the centre pawns should be held back so that they form a solid carapace around the king – they are, in effect, the equivalent of a castled position, but in the centre. Meanwhile the pieces can be developed on the wings. There is a lot of sense behind this; the principal objection is that it becomes difficult to co-ordinate the pieces if the king stays in the centre. In particular it is hard to get the rooks working together.

Here Krasenkow has held back his centre pawns so that Black can't respond to his wing assault with a withering counter-attack in the centre – the classical recipe for dealing with 'odd' moves on the wing like g2-g4. His king will remain in the centre for a time but it will be whisked away when appropriate to the queenside, not necessarily for its own safety but rather to bring the queen's rook into the game.

The immediate tactical justification for the move is that after 4...Nxg4 5 Rg1 Nf6 6 Rxg7 White has already succeeded in placing a rook on the seventh rank.

Game 22

□ **Krasenkow** ■ **Romanishin**

Lviv 2000

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nf3 e6 3 Nc3 Bb4 4 g4!? 0-0

Black's king castles into the storm. Perhaps the best move is 4...h6!?, the point being that it buys enough time for Black to arrange ...Ne4 before White can hit the knight with g4-g5. For example 5 Rg1 b6! 6 h4 Bb7 7 g5 hxg5 8 hxg5 Ne4 9 Qc2 Nxc3 10 dxc3 Bd6 11 Be3 Nc6 and Black was ready to complete the deployment of his pieces with ...Ne7, ...Ng6, ...Qe7 and ...0-0-0 in Van Wely-Timman, Wijk aan Zee 1999.

5 g5 Ne8

In contrast to the Timman extract above, the knight has been forced back to an ignominious square. It is therefore no wonder that Black is unable to generate sufficient counterplay in the centre.

6 Qc2 d5 7 b3!

White's queen's bishop will soon point menacingly towards g7.

7...Be7

White's refusal to play d2-d4 has robbed the bishop of any purpose on b4. Therefore Black relocates it on e7 with the hope of later contesting the key a1-h8 diagonal.

8 Rg1 c5 9 e3

Not only clearing the way for the bishop to enter the attack on d3 but

also making it more difficult for Black to set up a solid blockade of the danger diagonal with ...d5-d4.

9...Nc6 10 Bd3 (Diagram 7)

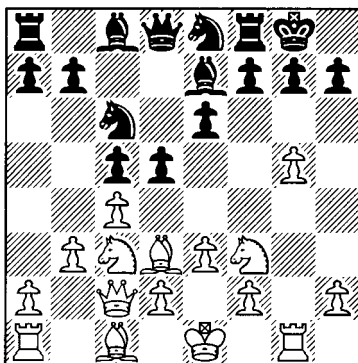


Diagram 7
The pressure builds

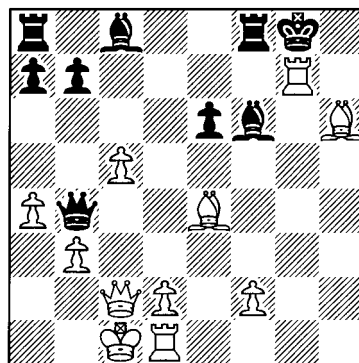


Diagram 8
Boiling point!

10...f5

After this White has the open g-file on which to build up his attack. However, there wasn't a good alternative for Black, for example 10...Nb4 11 Bxh7+ Kh8 12 Qb1, when 12...g6 13 Bxg6 fxg6 14 Qxg6 (intending 15 Rg3 etc.) is decisive, for 14...Rg8 runs into 15 Qh6 mate. In reply to 10...g6 White has 11 a3! (to prevent ...Nb4) followed by Bb2 and h2-h4-h5 with a lethal attack.

11 gxf6 Nxf6 12 a3 Qe8

Black's queen rushes to the defence of the kingside, but she becomes a target herself.

13 Bb2 Qh5 14 Be2 d4 15 Nxd4 Nxd4 16 exd4 Qxh2 17 0-0-0 cxd4 18 Ne4

Whether or not White is now winning is difficult to say for certain, but it is clear that in practice it would take an incredible defence to stave off such an onslaught.

18...Qf4 19 Bd3 Nxe4 20 Bxe4 h6 21 Bxd4 Bf6 22 Be3 Qd6 23 c5 Qa6 24 a4 Qa5 25 Bxh6 Qb4

A final, desperate roll of the dice. Black threatens mate in two, so White has to find a killing sequence with checks. Krasenkov finishes off in some style.

26 Rxg7+!! (Diagram 8) 26...Bxg7 27 Bh7+ Kh8 28 Bxg7+ Kxg7 29 Qg6+ Kh8 30 Qh5! Rxf2

If Black checks on a3 the king heads for c3.

31 Be4+ Kg7 32 Rg1+ Kf8 33 Qh6+ Ke7 34 Rg7+ Rf7 35 Qg5+ Ke8 36 Rg8+ 1-0

Mate follows on 36...Rf8 37 Qg6+ Ke7 38 Rg7+ Kd8 39 Qg5+.

The Mikenas Attack

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nc3 e6 3 e4!? (Diagram 9)

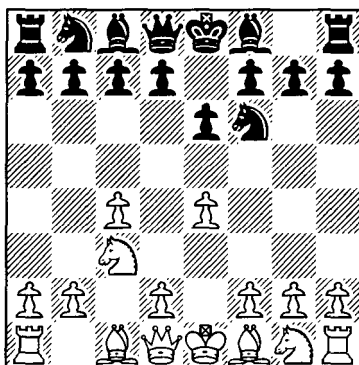


Diagram 9
A sharp Lithuanian idea

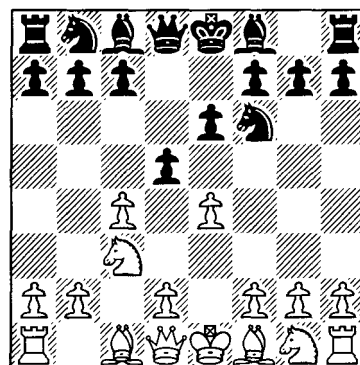


Diagram 10
A pawn race

Theoretical?

The Mikenas Attack is very dangerous against an unprepared opponent.

Strategies

3 e4 is surprisingly forcing. In view of the threat of 4 e5, chasing the knight back to g8, Black has little choice but to go into one of two sharp variations because 3...d6?! 4 d4 simply gives White a nice centre, while 3...Bb4 4 e5 Ng8 looks very silly.

Note that the diagram position could also arise from the alternative move order 1 c4 c5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 e4 if Black were now to play 3...e6, but this would be a bizarre decision to say the least when Black has so many good alternatives such as 3...Nc6, 3...d6 or even 3...e5. Therefore you shouldn't try to play the Mikenas as White against the 1 c4 c5 move order.

The Mikenas was big business when Kasparov used it to win some convincing games in the early 1990s. I would recommend it to players who like to attack as White as it is sure to upset opponents who were looking for a quiet life after 3 Nf3 Bb4.

Black has two responses, the more solid option being **3...d5 (Diagram 10)** – although it is not entirely comfortable for him.

The main sequence runs 4 e5 d4 (Black prefers to counterattack rather than retreat his knight) 5 exf6 dxc3 6 bxc3 Qxf6 7 d4 (Black

should equalise after 7 Nf3 e5 8 Bd3 Bd6 9 0-0 0-0 7...e5 8 Nf3 exd4 9 Bg5! (instead 9 cxd4 Bb4+ makes things much easier for Black) 9...Qe6+ 10 Be2 Be7 (and not 10...dxc3 11 Qd8 mate!) 11 cxd4 Bxg5 12 Nxg5 Qf6 13 Ne4 Qg6 14 Ng3 0-0 15 0-0 and White had a slight but definite advantage in Pelletier-Ribli, Tegernsee 2003.

Now let's look in some detail at the far sharper line with 3...c5, which seems to be the critical test of the Mikenas:

4 e5 Ng8 5 Nf3 Nc6 (Diagram 11)

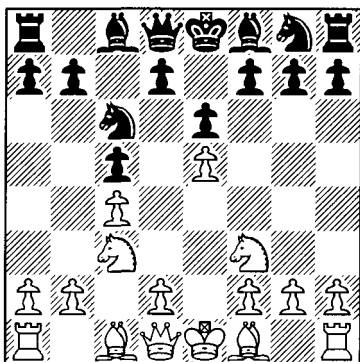


Diagram 11

The e5-pawn is out on a limb

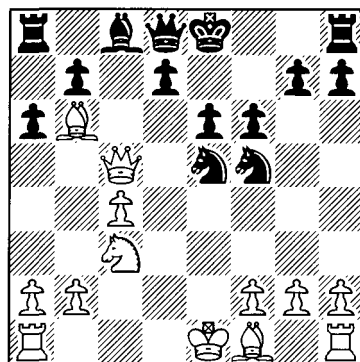


Diagram 12

White keeps the initiative

Black has let his knight be forced back to g8 in the hope that the pawn on e5 will prove weak. Indeed, if White now satisfied himself with simple developing moves he would find that after a sequence such as ...Nge7, ...Ng6, ...a7-a6 and ...Qc7 the pawn would be gradually encircled by the enemy pieces. Alternatively, if he were feeling less ambitious Black could simply liquidate the e5-pawn, for example 6 Be2?! d6. So White must play aggressively, even at the cost of a pawn.

6 d4! cxd4 7 Nxg4 Nxe5 8 Ndb5 f6

Black anticipates the knight being attacked after 11 Qxd6 – as occurs in the game. A transposing sequence is 8...a6 9 Nd6+ Bxd6 10 Qxd6 f6 11 Be3. Certainly 8...f6 is an ugly move as it develops nothing and weakens the kingside, although these drawbacks are outweighed by the necessity of defending the knight. An example of the danger facing Black is that the far more natural 8...d6 runs into 9 c5!, when 9...dxc5 10 Bf4! is horrible for him: if he exchanges queens then he will be facing the double threat of Nc7+ and Bxe5, while 10...f6 11 Bxe5 fxe5 12 Qh5+ is extremely nasty.

9 Be3 a6 10 Nd6+ Bxd6 11 Qxd6

It appears Black is in big trouble as his pieces on the queenside are shut in by the blockade on the dark squares, and if he tries to get his

kingside pieces out with 11...Ne7, then 12 Bb6 appears to win the queen. But things aren't that simple.

11...Ne7!

It looks like Black has made a fatal blunder but in fact this begins a clever combination to oust the white queen from the hole on d6.

12 Bb6 Nf5 13 Qc5 (Diagram 12)

Now Black can force an endgame with 13...Qe7 14 Qxe7+ Kxe7 but after 15 f4! Ng6 16 g3 d6 17 Bh3 Bd7 18 0-0-0 Bc6 19 Rhe1 White had built up a beautiful position in Bacrot-Dorfman, Marseilles 2001. The pressure on Black's centre more than compensates for the pawn.



TIP: If your opponent has an exposed king it is frequently worth sacrificing a pawn to be able to bring your rooks into the game, especially if your opponent's rooks are languishing in the corner. Kasparov has made a career out of such sacrifices.

Therefore from the latest diagram position Black should probably prefer 13...d6!, winning more time by attacking the queen. Then the unclear 14 Qa5 Qd7 is the subject of the illustrative game.

Game 23

□ Hodgson ■ Barsov

York 2000

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nc3 e6 3 e4

The Mikenas Attack is perfectly suited to Julian Hodgson's aggressive style.

3...c5 4 e5 Ng8 5 Nf3 Nc6 6 d4 cxd4 7 Nxd4 Nxe5 8 Ndb5 f6 9 Be3 a6 10 Nd6+ Bxd6 11 Qxd6 Ne7 12 Bb6 Nf5 13 Qc5 d6 14 Qa5 Qd7!

The moves up to here have been discussed above. Barsov now intends to tidy up with 15...Qc6 and 16...Nd7, when the white bishop is forced backwards and Black can free his queenside with ...b7-b6 and ...Bb7. White's compensation for the pawn would instantly evaporate. So Hodgson pre-empt's this plan with an immediate attack on the knight.

15 f4! Nc6 16 Qa3 Nce7!

Black still perseveres with the plan of ...Qc6 as he wants to remove his queen from the d-file before White plays 0-0-0 and Ne4, when the d6-pawn would drop.

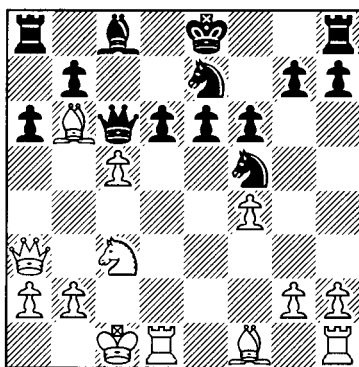
17 0-0-0 Qc6

The black queen also rules out 18 g4? in view of 18...Qxh1. Therefore Hodgson makes the only pawn thrust still available.

18 c5!? (Diagram 13) 18...Kf7

GM Alexei Barsov plays the French Defence as Black, so you would expect him to leap at the chance to play 18...d5 to solidify his centre. Then White can win the exchange with 19 Bb5 axb5 20 Qxa8 but after 20...0-0 Black has a pawn for it and an impressive wall of pawns in

the centre. Furthermore the white bishop on b6, as well as the queen, are on awkward squares. Perhaps Hodgson would have eschewed winning the exchange with the simple 19 Be2!?, planning to build up with g2-g4, chasing the knight from f5, followed by an eventual f4-f5 to exert further pressure on the black centre. A tough positional and tactical game would have been in prospect.



This deflection prevents Black from winning one of the bishops.

31...Qxa4 32 Qc5+ Kf7 33 Rd4 Qb5 34 Qc7+ Kg6 35 Qc2+ Kf7 36 Qc7+

A little repetition before White finds the winning method.

36...Kg6 37 Qc2+ Kf7 38 Bd5+! Ke8 39 Bc7 Rb6 40 Bxe5 fxe5 41 Qc8+ Ke7 42 Qc7+ 1-0

Black will be mated after 42...Ke8 43 Bf7+ or 42...Kf6 43 Qf7+ and so on, while 42...Qd7 43 Qxe5+ Kd8 44 Bf3 (simplest) sees the queen disappear.

Chapter Five

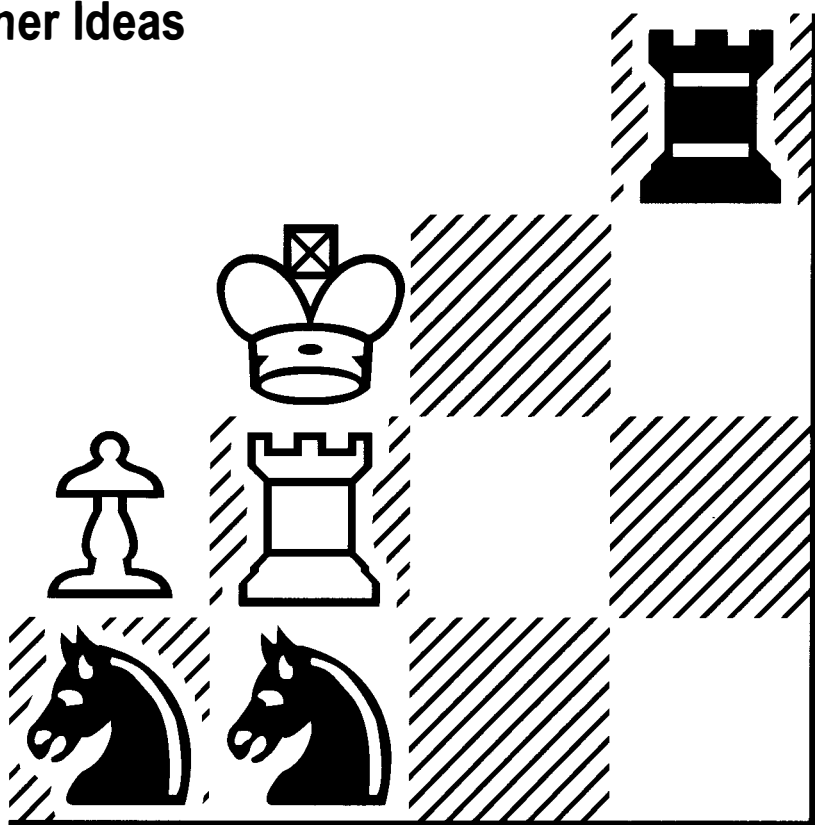
The Four Knights: Black Plays without ...d7-d5

 Introduction

 4 e3 Bb4

 4 g3 Bb4

 Other Ideas



Introduction

1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 Nf3 Nc6 (Diagram 1)

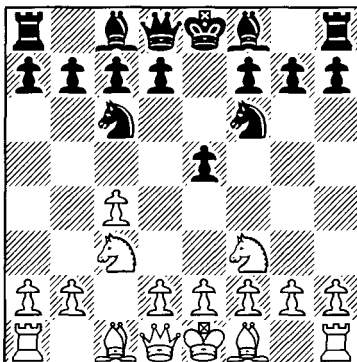


Diagram 1
The Four Knights

This variation is called the Four Knights because both players decide they like knights and bring all four of them out of the stables. This is probably the most common position in the English Opening and can lead to several distinct pawn structures. Variations in which Black answers 4 g3 with 4...d5 are analysed in Chapter Six; lines in which Black plays ...Bg7 can be found in Chapter Seven. Here we are mainly concerned with lines in which Black plays ...Bb4; two other ideas for Black are considered in the final part of the chapter.

Strategies

The system with ...Bb4 is related to the Nimzo-English (discussed in the previous chapter) in that Black plans a quick ...Bxc3. The difference is that here he has played ...e7-e5 rather than ...e7-e6. This means that he has an equal share of the centre and influence over d4, but the d5-square isn't guarded by a pawn. As a result the e4-square is also uncontested by a black pawn. This can hardly be remedied by the advance ...f7-f5 as it would take too much time to engineer and would loosen the kingside. Therefore Black begins a fight for the squares d5 and e4 by ...Bb4, which plans to liquidate – or at least harass – the knight on c3, which monitors both d5 and e4. Then he hopes to be able to free his game with a subsequent ...d7-d5 as in the style of the Dragon Reversed, or perhaps make a double-edged advance with ...e5-e4 work.

An Important Decision for White

White has to make a key decision on the fourth move between playing

the position after 4 e3 Bb4 or 4 g3 Bb4. Here we shall look at both moves in some detail.

4 e3 Bb4

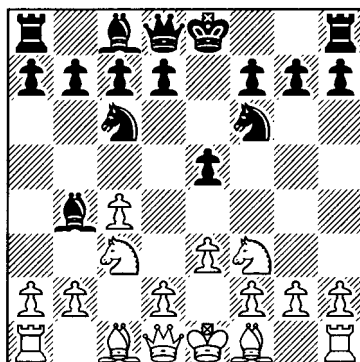


Diagram 2
White defends the d4-square

After 4 e3 the d4-square is protected so that White can play Qc2 without the risk of his queen being hit by ...Nd4. White also anticipates an attack on his knight on f3 with ...e5-e4 and thus clears the e2-square for the bishop in preparation of the manoeuvre Ng1-Ne2. Thereafter the knight can support action in the centre with Ng3 or – after the other knight has gone to d5 – Nec3. White can afford this slow redeployment of his knight as his centre is so solid. In fact he can often leave the king sheltering behind the e3-pawn for a long time and commence active operations on the wings; this may even involve a direct attack on the kingside.

Theoretical?

There isn't a great amount of theory to learn, but some of the ideas are rather quirky and it would therefore be hazardous to make things up as you go along. It is best to know what has happened before.

The dynamics of the struggle often lead to unusual looking manoeuvres. Let's see how things might work out in practice.

1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 e3 Bb4 5 Qc2

Idea One: Black Castles

5...0-0 6 Nd5!

An obvious sin against the precepts of Classical chess – and there is much worse to follow! White moves his knight for the second time in the opening before developing his other pieces. Nevertheless, the

move is positionally well motivated. White realises that in this position his knight is more valuable than the bishop. Therefore he moves it away and leaves the bishop hanging in the air on b4. White also hopes to gain time for a queenside pawn advance by harassing the bishop with a2-a3. The knight has another useful function on d5, physically ruling out Black's desired ...d7-d5 advance.

6...Re8

Here we see the difference between a move that forms part of a plan and one that merely 'looks right'. It was natural to play 6...d6 but this renounces the plan of a quick ...d7-d5 to seize space in the centre. Moreover, the useful retreat with ...Bf8 would be prevented.

7 Qf5!? (Diagram 3)

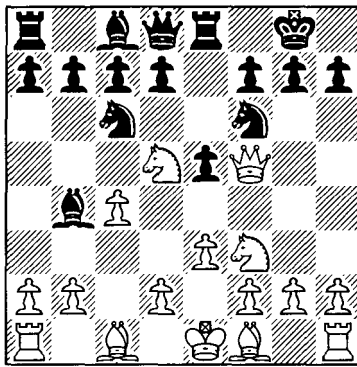


Diagram 3
Has White gone mad?

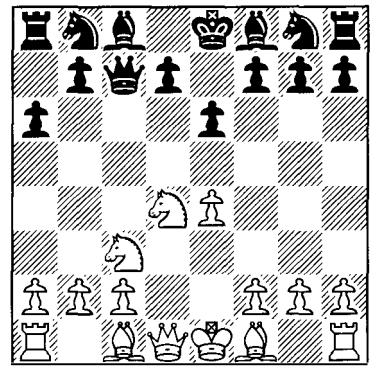


Diagram 4
The queen is strong on c7

White takes an extraordinary liberty with his development in order to threaten to inflict doubled pawns upon Black with 8 Nxf6+. Strategically speaking this is a desirable aim, but can he really get away with it? After all, Black has already castled and has four pieces developed, whilst the white king is still sitting in the centre.

In fact the pawn structure with d2, e3 and f2 forms a very tough shell which is almost unbreakable. It allows White to make some manoeuvres that are desirable in the long term without risking being destroyed by a central breakthrough.

Compare White's play with Black's in the Kan Variation in the Sicilian:

1 e4 c5 2 Nf3 e6 3 d4 cxd4 4 Nxd4 a6 5 Nc3 Qc7 (Diagram 4)

Here the d7/e6/f7 shell is comparable to the d2/e3/f2 shell in the English. This has afforded Black the luxury of a couple of strategically desirable moves at the cost of rapid development. Thus ...a7-a6 prepares ...b7-b5, gaining space on the queenside, while the queen is well placed on c7, looking down the c-file towards the potentially weak

pawn on c2 as well as having an influence on the b8-h2 diagonal. Remember that White has an extra tempo, so the Kan is riskier than the English! The weakest square in Black's position is on f7, so ...e7-e6 shields it very nicely from the attentions of a bishop on c4. Likewise, in the English the e3-pawn shields the f2-square.

A similar scheme to 7 Qf5 after 1 e4 e5 or 1 e4 c5 would be fraught with danger. Indeed it would be too risky if White had played the alternative bishop development with the moves g2-g3 and Bg2. White can only delay his development because his centre is exceptionally solid.

Returning to the position after 7 Qf5, here are a couple of examples of play after 7...d6 8 Nxf6+ which demonstrate that White has at least equal chances.

Variation One

8...Qxf6 9 Qxf6 gxf6

Obviously the exchange of queens removes virtually all the danger to the white king. Now Black has fractured pawns on the kingside, although White has, in fact, no significant advantage from this because the pawns are difficult to attack. Instead White should gain space on the queenside with 10 a3 Bc5 11 b4 Bb6 12 Bb2, but after 12...a5 White has only a slight edge.

Variation Two

It is sharper if Black keeps the queens on with 8...gxf6. Now White could push the solidity of his position to the limit with 9 Qc2 e4 10 Ng1 (Diagram 5) with a wonderful position in which White has only his queen developed!

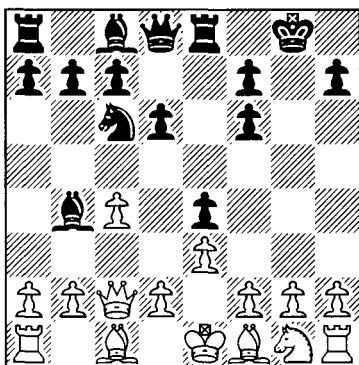


Diagram 5

White is short of development

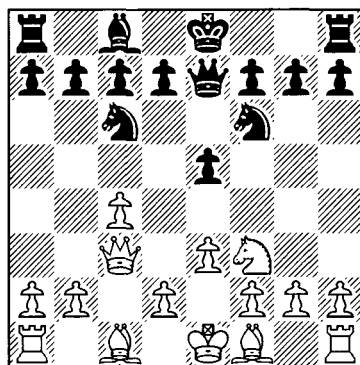


Diagram 6

A standard position

Formally White is a lot of tempi down, but his d2/e3/f2 structure is

super solid. All French Defence players (me included) know the value of this structure! Instead **9 Qh5** is a less laid back approach. The queen is a potential threat to the black king, so Black could find nothing better in Korchnoi-Karpov, Amsterdam 1987 than **9...d5 10 cxd5 Qxd5 11 Be2 Be6 12 0-0 e4 13 Qxd5 Bxd5 14 Nh4** with an eventual draw. Black has the bishop pair and active pieces but the structural weaknesses on the f-file shouldn't be underestimated.

Idea Two: Black Captures the Knight

In practice Black normally takes the chance to eliminate the knight with **5...Bxc3** in order to prevent this variation and so facilitate the space gaining advance ...d7-d5. From the beginning play might go **1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 e3 Bb4 5 Qc2 Bxc3 6 Qxc3 Qe7 (Diagram 6)** – Black has to defend the hanging e5-pawn – with the following position:

7 a3

With this move White aspires to a good strategical layout of his pieces with b2-b4 and Bb2, when e5 is attacked and there is pressure on the queenside. This plan is scotched by Black's accurate reply, but **7 a3** remains a very useful precautionary move for a reason that soon becomes clear.

7...d5

The logical follow-up to the exchange on c3. Another approach is **7...a5** but this doesn't stop White opening the queenside, although he has to be careful to avoid a couple of knight forks: **8 b4!? axb4 9 axb4 Rxa1 10 Qxa1 e4 (10...Nxb4 11 Qxe5) 11 b5! exf3** (c2 is protected after **11...Nb4 12 Nd4) 12 bxc6 fxg2 13 cxd7+ Nxd7 14 Bxg2 0-0 15 0-0** as in Agdestein-Adams, Hastings 1991. White has the two bishops but his slightly loose kingside prevents him from having a substantial advantage.

8 d4

White meets Black's central advance head on, hoping the opening of lines will benefit his bishop pair. After **8 b4? d4** Black has excellent chances in the centre – note that White can't take twice on d4 in view of the discovered check. If instead **8 cxd5 Nxd5 9 Qb3 Nb6** Black has a comfortable game, for example **10 d3 a5!** (clamping down on the queenside to prevent White getting any initiative there) **11 Bd2 a4 12 Qc2 0-0 13 Be2 Rd8 14 0-0 Bf5** and Black can increase the attack on the d3-pawn by doubling rooks on the d-file, when if White replies **e3-e4** he leaves a hole on d4.

8...exd4

Here we see that if instead of **7 a3**, which gains control of b4, White had played **7 Be2**, then Black would have been able to disrupt White's game with **8...Ne4! 8 Qc2 Qb4+**.

9 Nxd4 Nxd4 10 Qxd4 (Diagram 7)

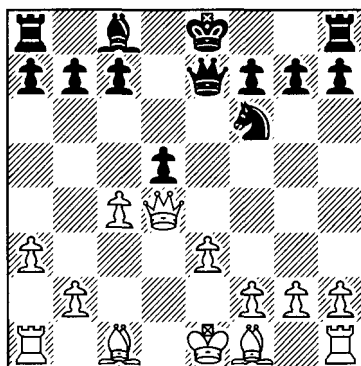


Diagram 7

White has the two bishops

Now 10...c5 11 Qh4 is fairly equal, for example 11...Bd7 12 cxd5 Nxd5 13 Qxe7+ Kxe7 14 e4 Nc7 15 Be3 b6 and White will be hard pressed to prove that his bishops give him any edge. In the first example that follows we see how a world class player tries to generate more tension with 10...0-0!?

Game 24

□ Chernin ■ Bareev

Panormo 2001

1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 Nf3 Nc6

Sometimes the sharp gambit line 3...e4? 4 Ng5 b5 is seen. Now 5 cxb5 d5 gives Black lots of counterplay, but 5 d3! is a strong and simple answer. After 5...bxc4 6 dxe4 White doesn't win a pawn but Black has a smashed centre and a weak pawn on c4.

4 e3 Bb4

A solid line favoured by former World Champions Petrosian and Karpov is 4...d6!?, for example 5 d4 exd4 (or 5...Bg4!? 6 Be2 Be7) 6 exd4 g6 7 d5 Ne7 8 Bd3 Bg7.

5 Qc2 Bxc3 6 Qxc3 Qe7 7 a3 d5 8 d4 exd4 9 Nxd4 Nxd4 10 Qxd4 0-0!?

Black ignores the threat to d5 as after 11 cxd5 Rd8 he will regain the pawn (12 Bc4 Be6 or 12...c6) and the open d-file will be of benefit to his rook.

11 Bd2!?

It will be seen that one of the problems White has in the Four Knights is finding an active role for the queen's bishop. This is especially the case when White has played 4 e3, obstructing its natural diagonal. Here White comes up with an interesting idea to activate it via b4.

11...Rd8



Black again avoids 11...c5 as he is obviously unimpressed with White's idea.

TIP: If you think your opponent is preparing a bad move, give him the chance to play it.

12 Bb4 Qe8 13 c5

White wisely keeps the centre closed as he is outgunned there.

13...Bd7!

Beginning a notable manoeuvre against the bishop pair. Bareev prepares to exchange light-squared bishops in order to win control of the e4-square and leave White with the bishop on b4, which is tied down to the defence of the c5-pawn.

14 Bd3 Bb5 (Diagram 8)

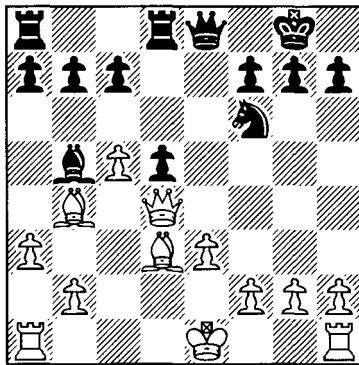


Diagram 8
A useful challenge

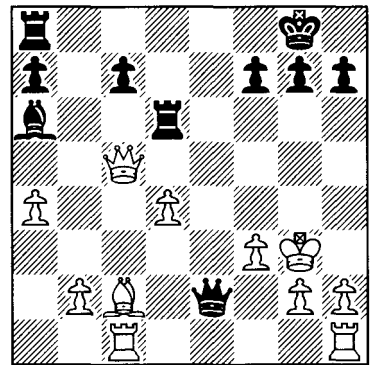


Diagram 9
Is the king safe?

15 Bc2

White prefers to keep a grip on the light squares, even if this means surrendering the right to castle. Now the tempo of the battle speeds up. Black wants to open lines to get at the white king before White has time to organise an attack of his own with moves like g2-g4 and Bc3, when he has pressure on g7.

15...b6! 16 a4 Ba6 17 f3

Naturally White can't contemplate 17 cxb6 axb6, when Black's pawns are ready to roll with 18...c5. Instead he covers the e4-square and clears a square for his king on f2.

17...bxc5 18 Bxc5 Nd7! 19 Kf2

Not 19 Qxd5? Ne5 20 Qb3 Qc6! 21 Bd4 Nxf3+ 22 gxf3 Qxf3 and White can only deal with the double threat of mate on e2 and 23...Qxh1+ with 23 Kd2, when 23...c5 tears apart the king's cover.

19...Nxc5 20 Qxc5



If White is left in peace for just one move he will play 20 Rhd1 with an excellent game due to the weakness of c7. The dynamism of Black's position won't survive the central deployment of White's rooks. Therefore he must strike immediately.

TIP: If you have an advantage that depends on a lead in development you either have to prevent the opponent from getting his pieces out or to try to convert it into another, more tangible advantage, such as a win of material or a superior structure.

20...Rd6!

Threatening to win a piece with 21...Rc6.

21 Rac1 d4!

The breakthrough comes just in time before 22 Rhd1. A bad mistake would be 22...Rc6? 23 Qxc6! Qxc6 24 Bxh7+ Kxh7 25 Rxc6 and Black has lost a lot of material.

22 exd4 Qe2+ 23 Kg3 (Diagram 9)

The white king looks in great danger but Black can't quite finish him off. With his next Black clears the way for a check on g6.

23...Bd3 24 Bxd3 Qxd3 25 h3 Qd2 ½-½

White has to deal with the threat of 25...Rg6+ by defending g2, and after 26 Rhg1 Qxb2 27 Qxc7 Qxd4 28 Kh2 there is no more fight left in the position.

Game 25

□ **McNab** ■ **Chandler**

Bath 1987

1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 e3 Bb4 5 Nd5

When this game was played this was a popular move, but now the immediate 5 Qc2 holds sway. I have chosen as examples two games by Scottish GM Colin McNab because they demonstrate clearly the progress of opening theory.

5...e4

This both attacks the knight and defends against the threat of 6 Nxb4 Nxb4 7 Nxe5, when White would win a sound centre pawn.

6 Ng1

White has lost time, but on the other hand the e4-pawn has become isolated from its companions and can be attacked with Qc2, Ne2 and Ng3 etc.

6...0-0 7 a3 Bd6 8 Qc2

We have pointed out above that the d2/e3/f2 centre can withstand considerable punishment, but in the next game it becomes clear that with this move White has pushed it beyond its limits. Instead 8 Ne2 is safer, when 8...Re8 9 Nec3 Be5 10 d4 exd3 11 Bxd3 Bxc3+ (parting with the two bishops in order to relieve the pressure in the centre) 12 Nxc3 d6 13 0-0 Be6 was fairly equal in Miles-Bacrot, Havana 1998.

8...Re8 9 Ne2

White is yet to put his pieces on good squares, but if nothing happens in the next five moves he can play Nec3, Be2, b2-b3 (or the bolder b2-b4) and Bb2, when his strategic layout of pieces would be excellent. The pawn on e4 is isolated from its colleagues. Therefore Black needs to find something fast. This isn't easy because the centre is blocked.

9...Ng4

A direct attacking move, but it leaves e4 insufficiently defended.

10 Ng3!

Meeting the threat of ...Nxh2 with a counterattack against e4.

10...Bxg3

This exchange is a direct consequence of his last move as Black needs to meet the threat to e4 and clear the way for ...d7-d6. Nevertheless, in giving up his excellent bishop Black leaves the white bishop on c1 with no rival, opens the h-file and strengthens the white centre. White has to try to weave one big advantage out of these small pluses.

11 hxg3 d6 12 Be2 h6

Already Black's plan looks suspect, for he is suddenly mated after 12...Bf5 13 f3! exf3? (13...Nf6 14 g4 Bg6 15 f4, threatening 16 f5, is anyway horrible for Black) 14 Qxf5 fxe2 15 Qxh7+ Kf8 16 Qh8.

13 f3 exf3 14 gxf3 Nge5 (Diagram 10)

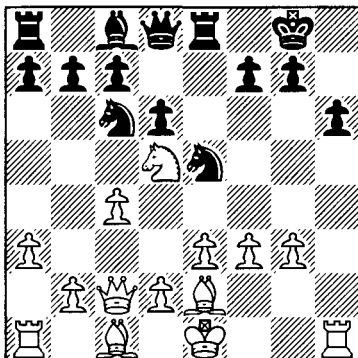


Diagram 10
Is 15 d4 sound?

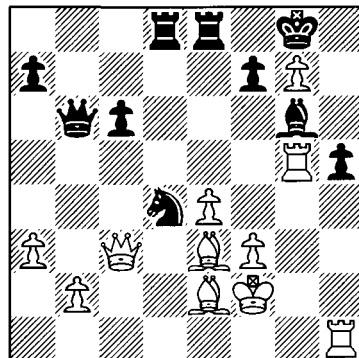


Diagram 11
The dark squares decide

15 Kf2!

White has to tread carefully as 15 d4? allows Black to break up the centre and win with 15...Nxd4 16 exd4 Nxf3+ 17 Kf2 Nxd4.



WARNING: Always be on the lookout for tactics from the opponent – they are much more difficult to see than your own combinations.

15...Be6

Black has a lead in development, but what can he do with it? Meanwhile White's better positional assets – a strong centre and the bishop pair – make themselves felt.

16 d4

The white centre is now a fantastic wall of pawns.

16...Ng6 17 Nf4!

Having a superiority in the centre, White turns to a direct attack.

17...Nxf4

This opens the g-file and further increases White's pawn mass in the centre, but there was no other way to deal with the double threat of d4-d5 and Nxg6.

18 gxf4 d5 19 f5

This thrust combines a direct attack on the black king with gaining further control of the centre.

19....Bc8 20 cxd5 Qxd5 21 f6 Bf5 22 Qc3 Bg6

Now it takes just two moves for White's sleeping queenside pieces to come to life, after which he has a decisive attack.

23 Bd2 Rad8 24 Rag1 Qf5 25 fxg7 h5 26 e4!

The pawns roll forwards in view of 26...Rxe4 27 Bd3.

26...Qf6 27 d5 Nd4 28 Bg5 Qb6 29 Be3 c5 30 dxc6 bxc6 31 Rg5! (Diagram 11)

A strong move that prepares a breakthrough on the h-file while simultaneously dissuading Black from playing ...c6-c5, which would break the pin on the knight for a couple of moves.

31...Rd6 32 Bc4 Kxg7 33 Rhxh5 c5 34 e5 Rdd8 35 Rg3 Qc6 36 Bh6+ Kh7 37 Bd3 Kg8 38 Be4

No doubt in time pressure, White misses the simpler win 38 Bxg6 fxg6 39 Qc4+ Re6 40 Rxc6+.

38...Qa6 39 Bd3 Nb5 40 Qc4! Rxd3 41 Qxd3 Qb6 42 Rxc6+ fxg6 43 Qd7 1-0

Colin McNab had a fantastic success with 8 Qc2 in this game. Therefore it is no surprise that later in the same year he decided to play it again at the British Championship, against a young player called Michael Adams. At the time of writing Adams is rated fifth in the world, but back in 1987 he was an extremely promising sixteen-year-old.

However, it was clear that the strength of his play was accelerating at an astonishing rate. One reason was his deep opening preparation. In an earlier game Adams had needed to struggle to save a draw against McNab, but things were very different in the game that follows.

Game 26

□ **McNab** ■ **Adams**

Swansea 1987

1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 e3 Bb4 5 Nd5 e4 6 Ng1 0-0 7 a3

Bd6 8 Qc2 Re8 9 Ne2 (Diagram 12)

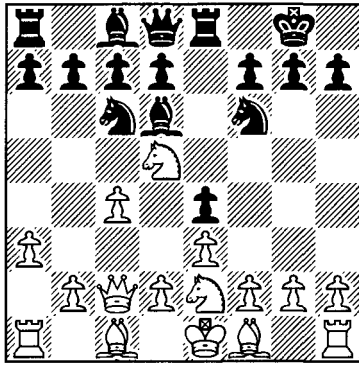


Diagram 12
The moment of truth

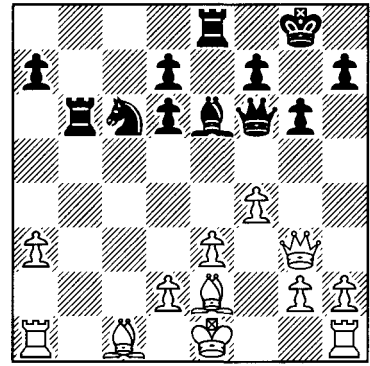


Diagram 13
The rook is cornered!

Here Adams unleashed...

9...b5!!

A brilliant move that was first used by the creative Ukrainian GM Oleg Romanishin back in the 1970s.

10 b3?!

A poor reaction. White should have played 10 Nxf6+ Qxf6 11 cxb5, although Black has a strong initiative after 11...Ne5!, when White dare not grab a second pawn with 12 Qxe4? due to the surprising 12...Bb7!, when 13 Qxb7 Nd3+ 14 Kd1 Nf2+ followed by 15...Nxb1 wins, while 13 Qc2 Ng4, hitting f2, gives Black a fearsome attack.

10...bxc4 11 bxc4 Nxd5 12 cxd5 Ne5 13 Ng3

After 13 Qxe4 Ba6 Black plans a lethal check on d3. The clearance of lines on the queenside and in the centre means that the opening has been a great success for Black. White has not had the ghost of a chance of a kingside attack.

13...Bb7 14 Nxe4 Bxd5! 15 Nxd6 cxd6

Black isn't bothered by the doubled pawns. The game will be decided by attack so he is pleased to have the chance to harass the queen with ...Rc8.

16 Qf5?

White's main problem is that he can't develop his kingside without dropping the g2-pawn. Therefore McNab comes up with the idea of putting his queen on h3 in order to develop his king's bishop without allowing ...Bxg2. However, it proves a disastrous decentralisation as the rook on a1 becomes a target. The queen had to stay on the queenside to help the defence there. The cold-blooded 16 Bb2 was the best hope.

16...g6 17 Qh3 Qf6 18 Rb1 Be6 19 Qg3 Qf5 20 Ra1 Rab8 21 Ba6 Rb6 22 f4 Nc6 23 Be2 Qf6 (Diagram 13)

Now White has to weaken himself in a fatal way as the rook on a1 has no more squares to run to.

24 d4

Now the once proud centre comes crashing down.

24...Nxd4! 25 exd4 Bc4 26 Qc3

White can't even bail out with 26 0-0 in view of 26...Bxe2 27 Rf2 Qxd4, threatening the rook as well as mate in two on d1.

26...Rxe2+ 27 Kd1 Qe6 28 Re1 Bb3+ 29 Qxb3 Rxe1+ 0-1

Adams didn't invent 9...b5, but by preparing the idea he scored a straightforward win against a player who is very hard to beat. This shows the importance of opening theory. It also serves as a warning that, if you intend to play the same opening line all the time, you have to expect some midnight oil from your opponent. This applies whether you are participating in international tournaments or playing the same players regularly in club or local competitions.

This ends our discussion of 4 e3. Now we turn to White's slightly more popular alternative.

4 g3 Bb4

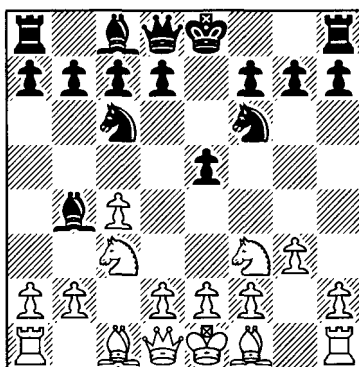


Diagram 14

White prepares Bg2

Strategies

White prepares to put his bishop on the strategically natural g2-square, from where it exerts pressure on the centre squares e4 and d5 and, beyond them, Black's queenside. However, the fact that White has spent a move on 4 g3 rather than putting up barricades in the centre with 4 e3 means that his centre is going to be that bit more

vulnerable to counterattack, at least for the first phase of the game. As usual, the knight on f3 is a target for a black lunge with ...e5-e4, and here it is far more disruptive than after 4 e3 as the knight doesn't have the cosy e2-square waiting for it if it retreats to g1. Normally the knight will go to g5, which is a much less secure square. On the other hand, the adventuresome pawn on e4 is being hit by considerable firepower, so the advance ...e5-e4 is by no means clearly favourable to Black – the pawn might just drop off! As will be seen, Black sometimes follows up ...e5-e4 with ...e4-e3. In view of the volatile situation in the centre after 4 g3 White will aim to castle kingside quickly.

Theoretical?

Kasparov has been involved in some heavyweight tussles with Karpov and others in this variation. In particular you have to know about the pawn sacrifice 9...e3!? – Kasparov has only ½/2 against it with White, so it might cause you some problems!

Game 27

□ **Kasparov** ■ **Ivanchuk**

Moscow 1988

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nc3 e5 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 g3 Bb4 5 Bg2

The sensible move, although 5 Nd5 led to an embarrassing debacle for Black in Petrosian-Ree, Wijk aan Zee 1971 after 5...Nxd5?! 6 cxd5 e4?? 7 dxc6 exf3 8 Qb3, when Black resigned as he is losing a piece after 8...Qe7 9 a3, intending cxb7 etc.

Instead 5...Bc5! is a solid reply for Black, e.g. 6 Bg2 d6 7 0-0 0-0 8 d3 h6 (preventing Bg5) 9 e3 a6, providing a retreat square on a7 for the bishop.

5...0-0 6 0-0 e4!

Black drives the white knight from its ideal square.

7 Ng5

The critical move. Instead 7 Ne1 Bxc3 8 dxc3 h6 9 Nc2 d6 followed by ...Re8 gives Black smooth deployment behind his spearhead on e4.

7...Bxc3 8 bxc3 Re8 9 f3 exf3

The critical 9...e3!? is examined in the next game.

10 Nxf3 d5 11 d4!

White ignores the attack on c4 as he is more concerned with bringing his queen's bishop into the attack and mobilising his pawns in the centre.

11...Ne4

Instead 11...dxc4 12 Bg5 is a very annoying pin. Even if Black avoided disaster on the f-file he would be unable to prevent White gaining a strong centre with a combination of the moves Qc2, Bxf6 and e2-e4. Consequently Ivanchuk moves his knight to e4 immediately.

12 Qc2 dxc4

Black cannot strengthen his hold on e4 with 12...Bf5 in view of 13 Nh4. Therefore, without any joy, he takes the pawn.

13 Rb1!

Kasparov went as far as giving this move two exclamation marks in Informator 46. Indeed it leaves Black curiously lacking in constructive ideas; it is almost as if he is in zugzwang as whatever he tries to improve his situation in the centre seems to leave him in a worse position! Thus after 13...f6, to guard e5, then 14 Ne5! comes anyway, when 14...fxe5 15 Bxe4 gives White decisive pressure against h7. In the game Ivanchuk tries to bolster the knight on e4 but this also ends up creating a fatal weakness in his king's defences.

13...f5 14 g4!

A logical move to undermine the defence of e4.



TIP: A move on the wing with the eye on the centre denotes the hand of the master – Aaron Nimzowitsch.

14...Qe7?

Kasparov points out that the only defence was 14...fxg4, although after 15 Ne5! Nd6 (15...Nxe5 16 Bxe4, hitting h7 and e5) 16 Nxc6 bxc6 17 e4 (**Diagram 15**) White has achieved his aim:

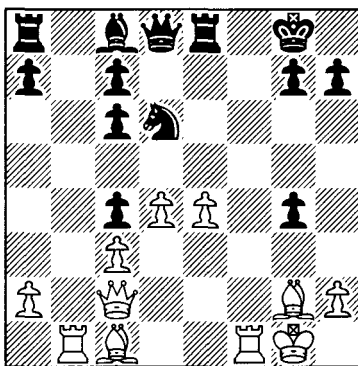


Diagram 15

Black has ragged pawns

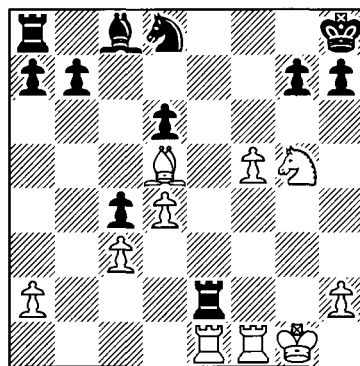


Diagram 16

Black is doomed

Black has two extra pawns but no one would envy him this position: his centre is wrecked, with the d- and f-pawns both having been deflected from their task of monitoring the centre. Only the c6-pawn, despite appearances, is putting up resistance by contesting the d5-square. Looking at the pieces we see that Black's bishop can be placed on only one of three squares – e6 (where it is boxed in by its own pawns on c4 and g4), d7 (where it is similarly obstructed by the pawns on c6 and g4) or, finally, a6 (where it stares at the c4-pawn).

The knight will be driven from the centre by e4-e5 at some point; meanwhile Black's rooks have no activity. Therefore we can conclude that the black forces can attack nothing and can only wait to be attacked themselves. It is no wonder that Ivanchuk tried to play more actively, though it leads to disaster.

15 gxf5 Nd6

Or 15...Bxf5 16 Ng5!, uncovering an attack on the bishop. In that case we see the value of 13 Rb1 as White can, if necessary, trade a couple of times on e4 and then win the ending after Rxb7.

16 Ng5! Qxe2

There was no good answer to White's next move.

17 Bd5+ Kh8 18 Qxe2 Rxe2 19 Bf4! Nd8

Black is without hope due to his weak back rank. For example Kasparov gives 19...Bxf5 20 Bxd6 Bxb1 21 Nf7+ Kg8 22 Nd8+ Kh8 23 Rf8 mate.

20 Bxd6 cxd6 21 Rbe1! (Diagram 16) 21...Rxe1 22 Rxe1 Bd7 23 Re7 Bc6 24 f6! 1-0

24...gxf6 25 Rxh7 mate, or 24...Bxd5 25 Re8+ Bg8 26 f7 Nxf7 27 Nxf7 mate!

Game 28

□ Topalov ■ Gelfand

Novgorod 1997

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nc3 e5 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 g3 Bb4 5 Bg2 0-0 6 0-0 e4 7 Ng5 Bxc3 8 bxc3 Re8 9 f3 e3!?

Karpov used this surprising pawn sacrifice to win a game against Kasparov in their World Championship Match in 1987. Compared to the previous game we see the following:

1. Black succeeds in keeping the f-file closed so his king is safe from attack.
2. Instead of getting back to a good square on f3, White's knight is left in limbo on g5.
3. White's centre becomes disjointed, being impressive on the kingside but ragged on the queenside.

10 dxe3

In the original game Kasparov declined the pawn offer with 10 d3, when there followed 10...d5 11 Qb3 Na5 12 Qa3 c6 13 cxd5 cxd5 14 f4, and now 14...Bg4 was the most active.

10...b6

Evidently Black plans to attack the c4-pawn with ...Ba6, combined if necessary with ...Na5 in good old Nimzo-Indian style. Fourteen years after his World Championship match debacle mentioned above, Kasparov changed his mind and took the pawn on e3, when there followed 10...Qe7 11 Nh3 Qc5 12 Nf4 Qxc4 13 e4 d6 14 Qd3 Ne5 15 Qxc4

Nxc4 16 g4 and White had an initiative on the kingside to compensate for his queenside weaknesses in Kasparov-Sadvakasov, Astana 2001.

11 e4 h6 12 Nxf7!?

This is one way to solve the problem of the what to do with the knight! Topalov clears the way for his kingside pawns to advance and seize key points. The modest course was 12 Nh3, when Black looks comfortable after 12...Ba6.

12...Kxf7 13 f4 Kg8 14 e5 (Diagram 17)

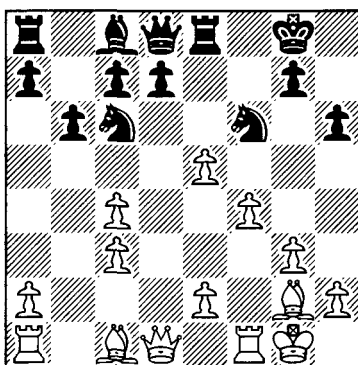


Diagram 17
Onward!

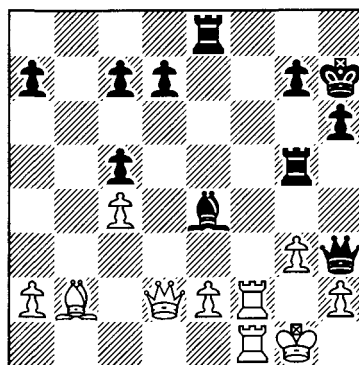


Diagram 18
Black closes in

14...Nh7 15 Ba3?

White had to keep the pawns rolling with 15 f5!, exploiting the weakness caused by 10...b6 as 15...Rxe5? drops a piece to 16 Bxc6. Instead Gelfand gives 16...Qe7 16 f6 gxf6 17 Bd5+ Kg7 18 Qd2! Qxe5 19 Qxh6+ Kh8 with an unclear position.

15...Bb7 16 Be4 Kh8 17 Bc2

This is Topalov's idea, which appears very menacing. If White is given a free move 18 Qd3 is decisive in view of 18...Nf8 19 Bxf8, destroying the defence of h7 – that's why he put the bishop on a3.

17...Nxe5!!

A strong riposte that destroys White's plan and leaves him with a shattered centre.



TIP: If your opponent sacrifices a piece for an attack, see if you can find a way to return the material to gain the initiative.

18 fxe5 Rxe5!

Very tempting was 18...Ng5 with the threat of 19...Nh3 mate, but this allows 19 e4!, obstructing the diagonal, when Black is in trouble as 19...Rxe5 allows the check on f8.

19 Bxh7

After 19 Qd3 Be4 20 Qd4 Qe8 White's attack is arrested.

19...Kxh7 20 c5 Qe8

White is losing because of his flimsy pawn structure and the enormous difference in power between the two bishops.

21 Qd3+ Be4 22 Qd2 Qe6 23 Rf2 bxc5 24 Raf1 Re8 25 c4 Qh3

Threatening mate with 26...Rg5xg3+ etc.



TIP: Opposite coloured bishops are notoriously drawish in the endgame, but in an aggressive middlegame situation such as this their presence often makes it feel like the attacker is a piece up!

26 Bb2 Rg5 (Diagram 18) 27 Qc3 Re6 28 Qe3 Rg4 29 Rc1 h5! 0-1

White is powerless to prevent 30...h4, when g3 drops.

Other Ideas

Theoretical?

The ideas here are offbeat so there isn't a mass of theory to learn. On the other hand, you should look at the notes carefully as often the best response to an unusual move is something equally odd looking!

Idea One: 4 d3

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nc3 e5 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 d3 (Diagram 19)

If now 4...d5 5 cxd5 Nxd5 White can choose between 6 e3, when he has a Hedgehog with colours reversed, or 6 a3, when I leave it to you to decide whether it is a Najdorf, with the extra move Nc3 thrown in, or a Classical Sicilian with the extra move a2-a3!

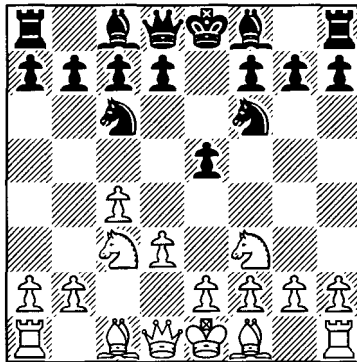


Diagram 19
Sicilian Reversed...?

Alternatively White could play 6 g3 with a Dragon Reversed, but the

fact that White avoided 4 g3 suggests that he is reticent to enter this line. None of these options is bad for Black as long as he is content to build up a solid position in the centre – it would be asking too much of his position to play sharp Sicilian lines a tempo down.

Nevertheless, it makes a lot of sense for Black to continue in the style of this chapter with...

4...Bb4

Now the knight really is pinned. Play can continue:

5 Bd2

White avoids doubled pawns and hopes to activate the bishop on c3. However, this doesn't seem to be a very promising strategy. Now, as an illustration of Black's counterchances, we'll look at a fine game from the European Club Championships.

Game 29

□ Gritsak ■ I.Sokolov

Halkidiki 2002

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nc3 e5 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 d3 Bb4 5 Bd2

Black's plan can be broken down into clear phases.

Phase 1: Eliminate the knight that protects d5 and play ...d7-d5.

5...Qe7 6 e3 0-0 7 Be2 Bxc3 8 Bxc3 d5 9 cxd5 Nxd5

Phase Two: Attack the d3 pawn with doubled rooks and the bishop on f5.

10 0-0 Rd8!

Instead 10...Nxc3 looks like a strategic mistake after 11 bxc3 as White has an extra pawn to strengthen his centre, but in fact 11...e4!? would then break up White's centre. I assume Black rejected this course as he is looking for a positional advantage rather than the equality that then results after 12 Nd4.

11 Qa4 Rd6 12 Rac1 Bf5! (Diagram 20)

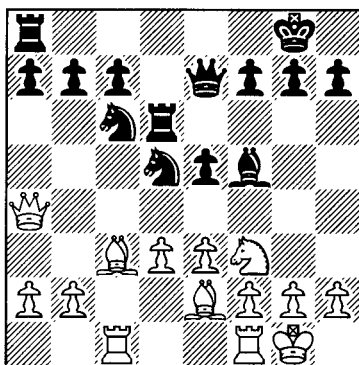


Diagram 20
Black hits d3

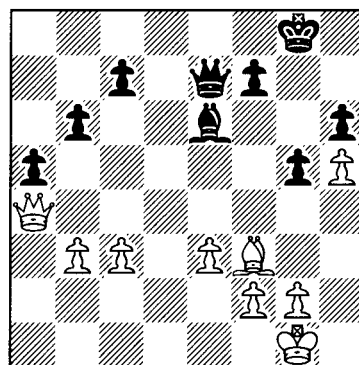


Diagram 21
The h5-pawn is weak

13 Rfd1

13 e4 Nf4 and Black saves the piece by attacking e2. Strategically speaking White is keen to avoid e3-e4 as this concedes a hole on d4.

13...Rad8 14 Ne1

Phase Two has now been completed. Black has an impressive build-up on the d-file but White's forces staunchly defend the backward d3-pawn.

Phase Three: Convert the positional pressure into a permanent advantage.

I'm sure that when Sokolov began his plan he didn't have an absolutely clear idea of how he was going to proceed in this third phase. As in the old saying, it is a case of having to cross a bridge when you arrive at it and not before: the bridge is bound to exist when you have carried out a methodical build-up in the centre. We should remember Nimzowitsch's dictum that when all the pieces are well placed and controlling important centre squares they will – as if by accident – be well placed to carry out the correct plan.

14...e4!

This gives White a highly unpleasant choice. He could play 15 d4, which replaces the backward pawn on d3 with a solid bulwark on d4. The bishop on c3 wouldn't be very happy about this – indeed you could say this spells the defeat of the 5 Bd2 plan as the bishop is obstructed by its own pawn. Nevertheless, White could tolerate an aggrieved bishop if it meant security in the centre. In fact what makes the position after 15 d4 unacceptable for White is that it leaves Black with an overwhelming space advantage on the kingside. In particular the knight is denied the f3-square so it can't aid the defence of h2. Nor can the other pieces do much to protect the kingside – the queen is too far away. Therefore Black can quickly generate a decisive attack with moves like ...Qh4 and ...Rh6, when h2 looks terribly weak – if White ever plays h2-h3 then ...Bxh3! would follow, when the king's defences are broken. Here we see Nimzowitsch's dictum in action: the rook was placed on d6 to exert pressure on d3 and, 'by accident', it ends up perfectly placed to swing over to the kingside and help deliver mate. Therefore White chooses to exchange on e4, but this leads to a bad endgame.

15 dxe4

The fact that the threat of a mating attack in the middlegame compels White to simplify into a poor endgame shows the close connection between the different phases of the game.



TIP: You should always be willing to exchange one advantage for another – flexibility is the key word!

15...Bxe4 16 Nf3

White decides that he has to meet the threat of 16...Qh4 forthwith, even though this means damage to his queenside pawn structure.

16...Nxc3 17 bxc3

An ugly move but instant defeat follows on 17 Rxc3 Rxd1+ 18 Bxd1 b5! 19 Qb3 Na5 as the queen can no longer defend the bishop on d1 without being lost.

17...h6 18 Rxd6 Rxd6 19 Rd1 Rxd1+ 20 Qxd1

Phase Four: Exploit the weak pawn on the queenside.

20...b6 21 Qa4 Na5 22 Nd2 Bd5 23 Bf3 Be6 24 Nb3 Nxb3

Black is willing to unite White's pawns as now he has a queenside pawn majority that can be turned into an outside passed pawn.

25 axb3 a5 26 h4 g6 27 h5?

A pseudo-attacking move that leaves a weak pawn on h5. White has to defend the pawn with 27 g3, when he still has drawing chances.

27...g5 (Diagram 21)

Now comes the decisive *Phase Five: Combine threats to the h5-pawn with the creation of a passed pawn on the queenside.*

28 Bc6 Qd6!

Intending a check on d1 with a double attack on b3 and h5.

29 b4 Qe5 30 bxa5 bxa5 31 c4 Qc5 32 Bb5 c6! 33 Bxc6 Qxc4 34 Qxc4 Bxc4 35 Ba4 f6 36 f4 Bf7 37 fxg5 fxg5 0-1

White resigned or lost on time. Either way it is hopeless, for example 38 g4 Be6 39 Bd1 Kg7 40 Kf2 Bd7 41 Ke1 a4 42 Kd2 a3 43 Kc1 (or 43 Kc3 Kf6 44 Kb3 Ba4+! 45 Kxa4 a2) 43...Be6 and with White's king tied down by the passed pawn Black's own king can quickly decide matters on the kingside.

Idea Two: 4 d4

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nc3 e5 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 d4 (Diagram 22)

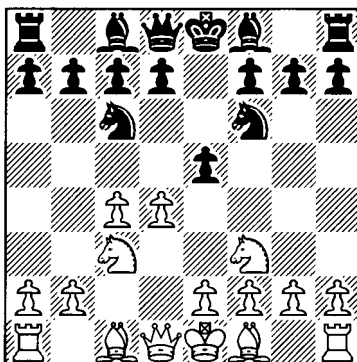


Diagram 22
Gaining space

White seizes space at once, but of course this makes ...Bb4 considerably more potent.

Other ideas for White include 4 a3 with the noble intention of ruling out ...Bb4. Nevertheless, it costs time and Black can respond boldly with 4...d5 5 cxd5 Nxd5 6 Qc2 Be7. Now White can prepare Bb5 to undermine the knight on c6, but this was neutralised in Smyslov-Miles, Bugojno 1984 after 7 e3 0-0 8 Bb5 Nxc3 9 bxc3 (9 Bxc6 Nd5!?) 9...Qd5 10 c4 Qe6 with equality.

Alternatively White can play a strange king of Botvinnik System (see Chapter Seven) with 4 e4, but 4...Bb4 5 d3 d6 6 Be2 h6 7 0-0 Bc5 looks comfortable for Black.

Game 30

□ Solleveld ■ Sutovsky

Amsterdam 2002

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nc3 e5 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 d4 exd4

This is a better response by Black than 4...e4 5 Ng5.

5 Nxd4 Bb4 6 Bg5 h6 7 Bh4 0-0

The ambitious move. More positional was the line 7...Bxc3+ 8 bxc3 Ne5 9 e3 0-0 10 f3!, when White prepares a future e3-e4 and also makes a bolt hole for the bishop on f2 in case it is harassed by the knights. After 10...d6 11 Be2 Qe7 12 0-0 White has the two bishops, pressure on f6 and the chance to grab more space in the centre with e3-e4. Meanwhile Black is solid, has easy development and can try to attack the doubled pawns.

8 Rc1 Nxd4 9 Qxd4 g5!

Black breaks the pin on the knight as part of an energetic bid to take advantage of White's lack of kingside development. There is no room for half measures after this severe weakening of his kingside pawns; Black will suffer if his activity fails to prevent White deploying his pieces. Therefore a tense battle is in prospect.

10 Bg3 c5! 11 Qd6!

White prevents Black from freeing his game with ...d7-d5 (or so he thinks).

11...Ne4! (Diagram 23)

There is no time for Black to hesitate – he has to do or die.

12 Qd3?

White loses his nerve. He had to play 12 Qxh6, when 12...Qb6! (otherwise White has Be5) 13 Qxb6 axb6 14 a3 Bxc3+ 15 bxc3 Rxa3 16 Bc7! gives him the chance to try to exploit the bishop pair in the end-game, although Black is sufficiently active.

12...d5!

Black blasts open the centre. Despite the exchange of queens that follows Black gains a huge attack as White king's bishop and rook are still slumbering.

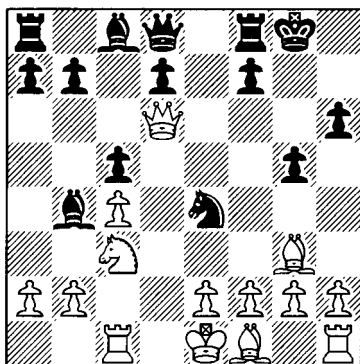


Diagram 23
Black pounces

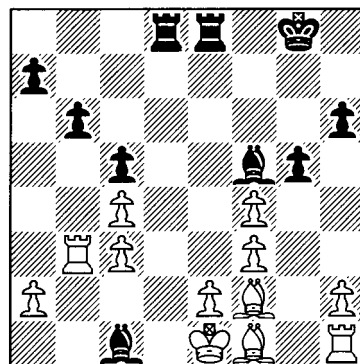


Diagram 24
The end is nigh!

13 Qxd5 Qe7 14 Qe5 Qxe5 15 Bxe5 Re8 16 Bg3 f5!

Now 17 e3 can be met with 17...f4, winning material due to the potential discovered check on the e-file. This means that White is prevented from developing his kingside.



TIP: Don't just think about manoeuvres with the big pieces – at some point in every attack the pieces will need the help of the pawns.

17 f3 Nxc3 18 bxc3 Ba3 19 Rb1 f4 20 Bf2 b6!

There is no hurry as White can't improve his position, for example if he decides to put the bishop on g2 it will only leave e2 indefensible.

21 g3 Bf5 22 Rb3 Bc1 23 gxf4 Rad8! (Diagram 24)

With the threat of 24...Bc2 and 25...Rd1 mate.

24 e4 Bd2+ 25 Ke2 Rxe4+!

A pretty finish. White's king often hides behind the centre barricades in the Four Knights, and if these collapse it is all over.

26 fxe4 Bg4 mate.

Idea Three: 4 g3 Nd4!? and Others

1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 g3

Black can try to reach the lines of Chapter Seven with 4...g6, but White doesn't have to keep the centre closed with d2-d3. Instead he can open lines with 5 d4, when a possible line is 5...exd4 6 Nxd4 Bg7 7 Bg2 0-0 8 0-0 Re8. If then 9 Nxc6 Black does best to recapture with 9...dxc6!, clearing the way for the development of his queen's bishop. Then the c4-pawn will prove at least as weak as the doubled pawns after ...Be6 etc. Consequently White should probably settle for 9 Nc2, with a very slight edge.

4...Nd4!? (Diagram 25)

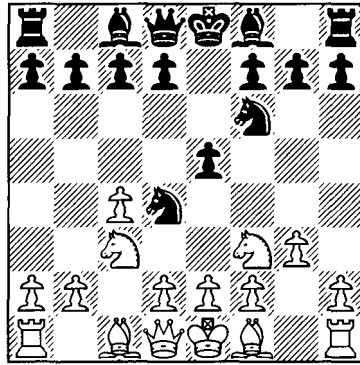


Diagram 25
A cheeky move

We are used to White taking liberties with his development in the English but it comes as a surprise from Black. By exchanging knights Black hopes to ease the tension in the centre and so equalise more easily after a subsequent ...d7-d5.

It would be perilous for White to take on e5: 5 Nxe5 Qe7, when 6 Nd3?? Nf3 is mate and 6 f4 d6 7 Nd3 Bf5!? gives Black a dangerous initiative for the pawn.

Sometimes 4...Bc5 is seen. Then White can apply a Fork Trick to clarify the situation in the centre: 5 Nxe5!?, and now 5...Nxe5 6 d4 is nice for him so critical is 5...Bxf2+ 6 Kxf2 Nxe5 7 e4. White has the two bishops and the makings of a broad centre, but he has to be a bit careful about his loose king position. Then 7...c5 8 d4! is a pleasant edge for White, so perhaps Black should prefer the cautious 7...d6, when 8 d4 Ng6 9 h3 leaves White with space and a strong dark-squared bishop, but also with a certain fragility in his pawn structure.

5 Nh4

An equally unexpected reply. The knight runs away to the edge of the board! White hopes that the apparent loss of time can be recouped with e2-e3. Natural development with 5 Bg2 looks preferable, when 5...Nxf3+ 6 Bxf3 Bb4 is similar to the 4 g3 Bb4 main line but without knights on c6 and f3. White might have a very slight edge here but, if this is the best he can do, then we will be seeing a lot more of 5...Nd4.

5...c6!

Black takes the chance to support the ...d7-d5 advance in a way not normally available to him.

Game 31

□ **Gulko** ■ **C.Hansen**

Esbjerg 2000

1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 g3 Nd4 5 Nh4 c6 6 e3 Ne6 7 d4?!

This leads to difficulties. White should have settled for quiet development with 7 Bg2.

7...exd4 8 exd4 d5!

Action has begun in the centre, and what is the knight doing on h4? Perhaps White should have returned it to the centre immediately with 9 Nf3. After the text he rapidly loses control of events.

9 c5?



WARNING: A general pawn advance without the support of pieces can lead only to disaster.

9...b6! 10 b4 a5 11 Na4 (Diagram 26)

A second white knight goes to the edge of the board in a bid to prevent the break up the queenside pawns. There is now a fearful symmetry between the knights on a4 and h4.

11...Nd7! 12 b5 Bb7

Now the momentum of the white pawns is spent and, as they collapse, they bring down the foundations of White's position.

13 Ba3 bxc5 14 dxc5 Ndxc5 15 Rc1 Nxa4 16 Bxf8 Kxf8 17 bxc6

An intermediate move that leads to a quick defeat. The only way to play on was 17 Qxa4.

17...Bxc6! 18 Rxc6 Qe8 (Diagram 27)

The attack on the rook gains time for a decisive discovered attack in view of 19 Qxa4 Nc5+, when White's queen drops.

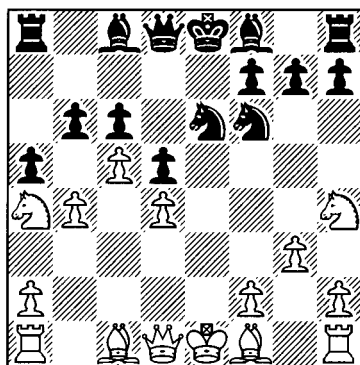


Diagram 26
White's wayward knights

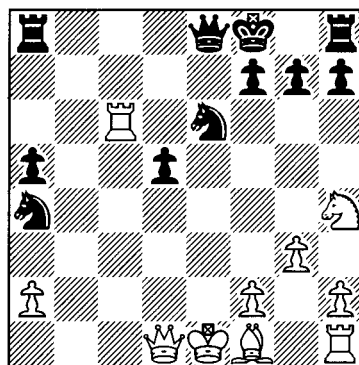


Diagram 27
A discovered check looms

19 Rc1 Nf4+ 20 Kd2

Also hopeless is 21 Be2 Nb2! and a big check on d3 follows.

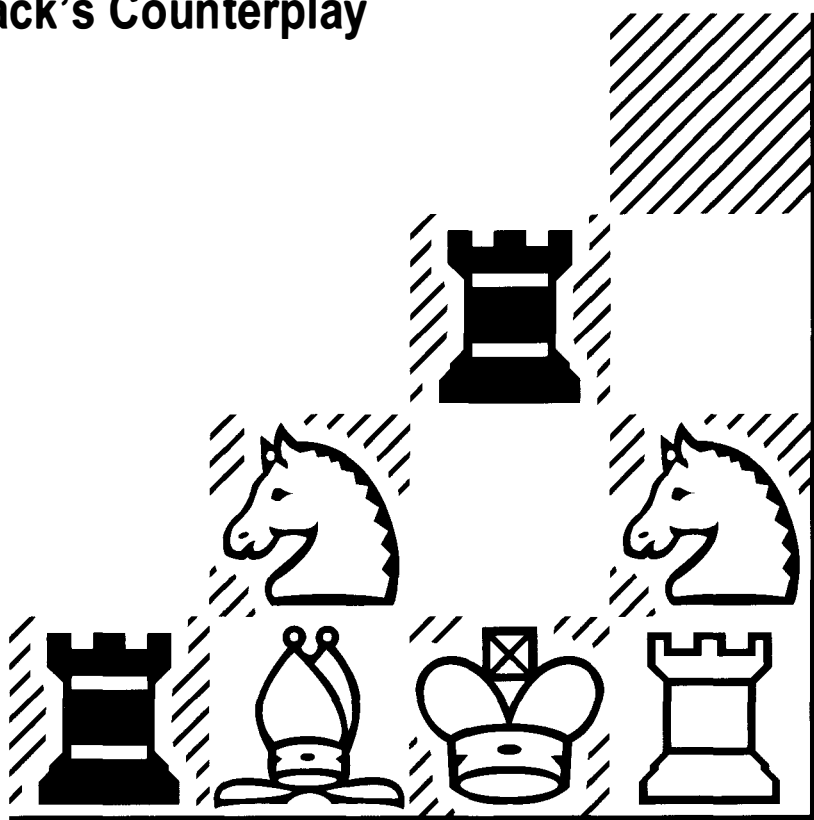
20...Qe4! 21 gxf4 Qxf4+ 22 Ke1 Qe4+ 23 Kd2 Qb4+ 24 Ke2 Qe4+ 25 Kd2 Qxh4 26 Qf3 Qb4+ 0-1

27 Ke2 Re8+ wins quickly for Black.

Chapter Six

The Reversed Dragon

- Introduction
- The Vulnerable Knight on c6
- White's Queenside Pressure
- Black's Counterplay



Introduction

I suggest that the reader begin by playing through the illustrative games quickly in order to get a feel for this variation.

Theoretical?

A variation featuring games by Kasparov, Karpov and Topalov is bound to have accumulated its share of theory. However, the important thing is to be aware of White's attacking method on the queen-side and the resources that Black can apply to meet it.

Strategies

1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 g3 d5 5 cxd5 Nxd5 6 Bg2 Nb6 (Diagram 1)

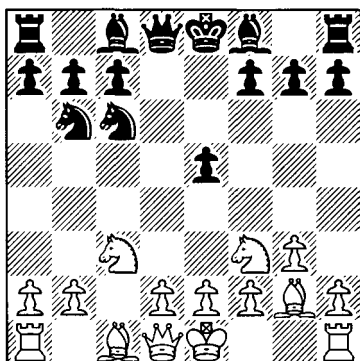


Diagram 1

Black has more space

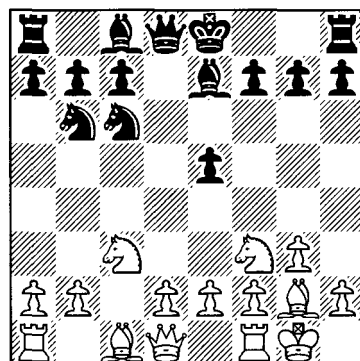


Diagram 2

The Dragon Reversed

The knight retreats immediately in order to help the queen deter White from pushing d2-d4. After all, Black has a space advantage and he wants to keep it!

7 0-0 Be7 (Diagram 2)

Black has directed play into a Sicilian Dragon with colours reversed. But a comparison of the two versions – one for White, the other for Black – is of surprisingly limited value. This is because the philosophy of the play is markedly different. When White takes on the Sicilian Dragon we don't necessarily expect him to plunge into the Yugoslav Variation or another sharp line, but we do expect a direct, aggressive deployment of his pieces. Thus the idea equivalent to 6...Nb6 as White would raise eyebrows – namely 1 e4 c5 2 Nf3 Nc6 3 d4 cxd4 4 Nxd4 Nf6 5 Nc3 g6 and now we would regard 6 Nb3, which decentralises the knight for no good reason, as inferior. Taking this further,

after 6 Nb3 Bg7 7 Be2 0-0 we wouldn't approve much of 8 Be3 either, seeing that there is the more aggressive 8 Bg5 available.

Thus when White plays against the Dragon he is looking to keep an advantage, even in a quiet line, whereas in the Dragon Reversed Black is trying to set up a solid position and has no thoughts as yet of seizing the initiative. The extra tempo, or the lack of it, makes the whole difference. David Bronstein once described the right to move next as the most powerful weapon in chess. Certainly as regards opening theory it sets the whole basis for the struggle.

To summarise, White has his extra tempo, but he can't exploit it easily as Black has no intention of attacking him. For this reason the Dragon Reversed generally leads to a more positional battle than the Sicilian Dragon.



TIP: Don't worry – you won't face massive kingside attacks as White in this line. But remember that if you enjoy playing the Sicilian Dragon as Black it doesn't necessarily follow that you will enjoy playing the Dragon Reversed as White.

The Vulnerable Knight on c6

All is well for Black apart from one thing – White's pressure on the h1-a8 diagonal and, in particular, the susceptibility of the knight on c6 to attack. Almost every other black piece can be placed on a square where it is secure from attack, but the poor knight has to stay on the c6-square, an unfortunate intersection of the power of the bishop on g2 and a rook on c1 or queen on c2. The knight is obliged to stay on c6 to guard the e5-pawn and help deter White's d2-d4 (or d3-d4). The knight is such an important piece that White is sometimes willing to give up the exchange to eliminate it.

White's Queenside Pressure

This can be increased with a2-a3 and b2-b4, with two main ideas:

1. Playing Ne4 (or sometimes Na4) followed by Nc5, when the knight attacks the b7-pawn and can only be removed by ...Bxc5, when the reply b4xc5 gives White the two bishops and an extra centre pawn. The idea of Nc5 is also sometimes supported by Rc1 or Qc2.
2. Dislodging the knight from c6 with b4-b5 in order to win the e5-pawn.

Where should the rook go? White has to decide where he wants to put his queen's rook. It can go to b1 to support the b2-b4 advance or can be held back and put on c1 later, where it exerts pressure on the c-file and in particular against the knight on c6. On c1 it would also support the Ne4 and Nc5 idea. Generally speaking, if White plays Bb2 – a useful developing move, aiming at the e5-pawn – he will choose Rc1, as on b1 the rook would be obstructed by the bishop.



NOTE: White often plays d2-d3, but this move, although necessary in the scheme of things, isn't normally forced at an early stage. Thus White can sometimes profitably delay it and put the tempo to immediate use in expanding on the queenside.

Black's Counterplay

The good news for Black is that he has a space advantage and can easily develop. His king is unlikely to be facing a direct attack once he castles kingside. However, he needs to defend accurately against the queenside pressure described above. Black usually plays ...f7-f6 to bolster e5 – he believes he can make this slight structural concession because otherwise he is solidly placed. Often he meets White's b2-b4 with ...a7-a5, literally forcing the pawn to advance to b5. Generally he is less afraid of this advance than of permitting the pawn to remain on a square where it supports the Nc5 idea. After b4-b5 Black's knight can spring forwards from c6 to d4, sometimes even if this means sacrificing the e5-pawn.

Game 32

□ Karpov ■ Hjartarson

Seattle 1989

1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 g3 d5 4 cxd5 Nxd5 5 Bg2 Nb6 6 Nf3 Nc6 7 0-0 Be7 8 a3

White wastes no time beginning queenside expansion.

8...Be6 9 b4 0-0 10 Rb1!

Definitely not 10 b5?! Nd4 11 Nxe5?? Bb3 12 Qe1 Nc2. It is also more accurate to put the rook on b1 immediately rather than play 10 d3, which invites the disruptive 10...a5!? 11 b5 Nd4, again offering the e-pawn. This time 12 Nxe5 doesn't lose by force, but it certainly gives Black ample compensation in open lines after 12...Bf6.

10...f6

In contrast to the excitement of ...Nd4! in the note above, thanks to Karpov's precise play Black is more or less obliged to play this defensive move in view of the threat of 11 b5.

11 d3

Only now does White allow himself the luxury of this move.

11...Qd7?

This is a routine developing move with no clear plan in mind. Even worse, it puts the queen on a square where she is a target after Ne4 and Nc5. As White has an obvious way to improve his position – namely increasing the pressure on the queenside – it is no good Black trying to keep everything nice and tidy. He has to gain dynamic chances even at the cost of loosening his pawn structure or else he will gradually drift into trouble. White would keep an edge after 11...Nd4 12 Bb2 Nxf3+ 13 Bxf3 c6 14 Ne4 and so on but probably best

was 11...a5!?, which is the subject of the next – very short! – game.

12 Ne4!

Of course Karpov isn't going to miss the chance to put Black in a positional bind.

12...Nd5 13 Qc2 b6? (Diagram 3)

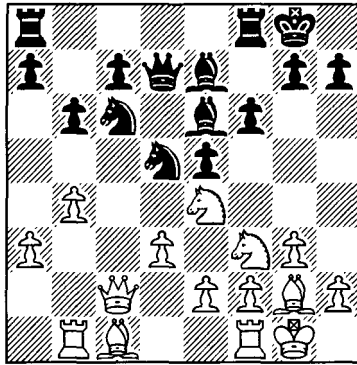


Diagram 3
Black weakens c6

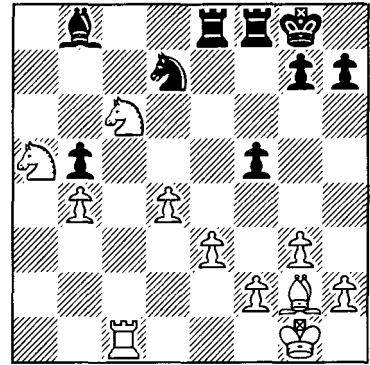


Diagram 4
White dominates

A case of the cure being more harmful than the disease. Black wants to keep the knight out of c5 but this creates a horrible weakness on the c-file. He had to fight it out with 13...a5! etc.

14 Bb2 Rac8 15 Rbc1 Nd4 16 Bxd4!

The correct capture. 16 Nxd4 exd4 17 Bxd4? Nxb4 is nothing for White.

16...exd4 17 Qc6!

White has to prevent Black supporting the d4-pawn with ...c7-c5.

17...Qxc6 18 Rxc6 Bd7 19 Nxd4!

White destroys the enemy centre, after which his light-squared bishop becomes very strong. In contrast Black's bishop becomes almost useless, being hampered by its own pawns and unable to find anything to attack. As White will soon pick up a second pawn for the exchange it is hardly possible to describe this as a sacrifice – there is absolutely no risk involved. Note that White wouldn't have had this strong continuation if he had made the routine capture 16 Nxd4.

19...Bxc6 20 Nxc6 Rce8 21 Rc1 f5 22 Nd2 Nf6 23 Nxa7 Bd6 24 e3 c5 25 Nc4 Bb8 26 Nc6 b5 27 N4a5 cxb4 28 axb4 Nd7 29 d4 (Diagram 4) 29...g5

Now White is willing to rid Black of his bishop as he sees that getting a rook to the seventh rank will win another pawn.

30 Nxb8! Rxb8 31 Rc7 Nf6 32 Nc6 Rb6 33 Ne7+ Kh8 34 Nxf5



TIP: It is often possible to defend against one passed pawn, and sometimes even split passed pawns can be stopped – but connected passed pawns usually win very easily.

34...Ra6 35 Rc1 Ra2 36 h3 Rb2 37 e4 Rxb4 38 g4 h5 39 e5 hxg4
Desperation; otherwise the pawns just roll onwards.

40 exf6 gxh3 41 Bxh3 Rxf6 42 Rc8+ Kh7 43 Rc7+ Kg6 44 Rg7+ Kh5 45 f3 1-0

A neat mating finish.

Game 33

□ Suba ■ Garcia

Malaga 2001

1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 g3 d5 4 cxd5 Nxd5 5 Bg2 Nb6 6 Nf3 Nc6 7 0-0 Be7 8 a3 Be6 9 b4 0-0 10 Rb1 f6 11 d3 a5!?

Rather than the indecisive 11...Qd7 in the previous game Black strikes immediately at b4. This might well be the best idea so I guess I should apologise for presenting it in a game that Black loses in 15 moves, but I simply couldn't resist!

12 b5 Nd4 13 Nd2 (Diagram 5)

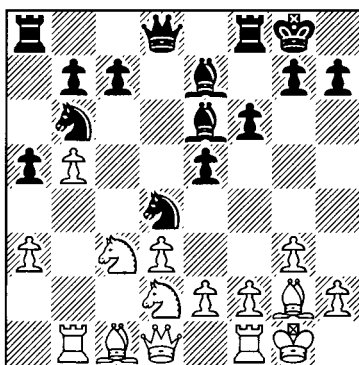


Diagram 5

How to defend b7?

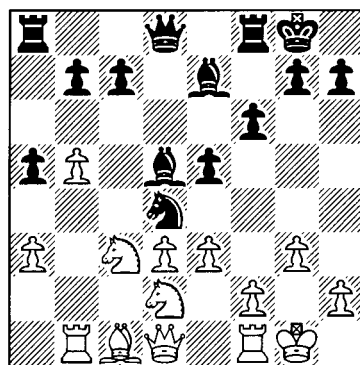


Diagram 6

Whoops!

After this quiet retreat Black had no wish to defend his b7-pawn with a passive move by the queen or rook. Instead he found what he thought was the complete answer to his problems...

13...Nd5??

Very natural: Black recentralises his knight and offers an exchange of pieces to free his game. No doubt he looked at 14 Nxd5 Bxd5 15 Bxd5 Qxd5 with a good game, but he hadn't looked at the other capture. In fact 13...Qc8 wouldn't have been more than a slight edge to White. Perhaps best is 13...Bd5!, offering the exchange of pieces the other way. Then after 14 Nxd5 Nxd5 there is the threat of a fork on c3, and

15 Bb2 a4!? looks fine for Black.

14 Bxd5! Bxd5 15 e3 (Diagram 6) 1-0

Black resigned as he loses a piece after 15...Ne6 16 e4. The bishop is trapped in the centre of the board. This really was a devilish trap as 13...Nd5 looked right and 14 Bxd5 looked wrong. It just shows you can't be too careful when you are relying on your instinct. I recall Romanian GM Florin Gheorghiu once missing the win of a piece in a similar scenario.

Game 34

□ Kasparov ■ Salov

Moscow 1988

1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 g3 d5 5 cxd5 Nxd5 6 Bg2 Nb6 7 0-0 Be7 8 a3 Be6 9 d3

White avoids the immediate 9 b4 0-0 10 Rb1. This approach keeps open the option of Bb2 and Rc1.

9...0-0 10 b4 Nd4

Salov seeks immediate action but he just ends up in a slightly worse position. Instead 10...f6 transposes to Bacrot-Topalov (Game 35).

11 Bb2!

White develops simply. Much too risky is 11 Nxe5? When, besides 11...Bf6, White has to reckon with 11...Nb3, attacking the rook and planning the fork 12...Qd4.

11...Nxf3+ 12 Bxf3 c6 13 Ne4 Nd7

Defending against 14 Bxe5 and directed against Nc5.

14 Qc2

White has emerged with a pleasant edge due to his potential pressure on the queenside. It is now extremely instructive to see how Kasparov outplays his young opponent.

14...Bd5 15 Nd2 Bxf3 16 Nxf3 Bd6 17 Nd2!

Intending to exchange the knight for the bishop, which will give White the better long term prospects.

17...Qe7 18 Ne4 Rae8

18...Bc7 19 b5 looks awkward for Black.

19 Nxd6 Qxd6 (Diagram 7)

20 a4!

White begins the famous Minority Attack, which is best known from the Queen's Gambit Declined. It is so called because the two pawns of the attacker terrorise the three of the defender. Here b4-b5 will undermine the c6-pawn and force a concession.

20...Qxb4? 21 Ba3 nets White the exchange.

20...f5 21 b5 c5

Perhaps around here Black thought he was doing well in view of his

space advantage in the centre and the prospects of a kingside attack. Indeed, if it were his move now, then ...f5-f4 gives him the makings of a strong attack, as White's kingside misses the defence of the light-squared bishop. Therefore Kasparov has to find a way to neutralise Black's attack so that he can prove the superiority of his bishop over the knight in an endgame.

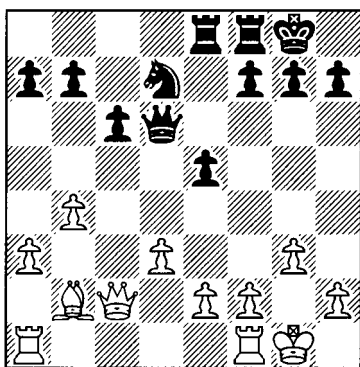


Diagram 7

White has Bishop v. Knight

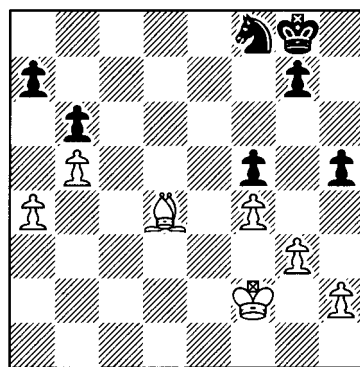


Diagram 8

a7 and b6 are weak

22 e3!

White has to fight immediately for control of the centre squares. The ability to meet Black's projected attack with d3-d4 or f2-f4 is far more significant than the hole created on f3 or the fact that d3 now becomes a backward pawn.

22...Rf7

After 22...f4 23 exf4 exf4, planning 24...Ne5 with a big attack, White can play 24 d4!, gaining control of the e5-square long enough to frustrate Black's knight – 24...cxd4 (or 24...fxg3 25 hxg3) 25 Qc4+ (he could also take the exchange with 25 Ba3, though it would be riskier) 25...Kh8 26 Qxd4 Qxd4 27 Bxd4, when having the better minor piece gives White the edge in the endgame.

23 Rfe1 Nf8 24 Qc4!

Here the queen prevents ...Qd5, pins the rook on f7 and helps support a d3-d4 advance.

24...Rd8 25 Rad1 b6 26 Kg2 Ng6 27 f4!

White clamps down on any counterplay and forces open the diagonal for his bishop.

27...exf4 28 exf4!

We all learn at the start of our chess experience to recapture with a pawn towards the centre. Here is one of the many exceptions. After 28 gxf4? Black gains a strong attack with the immediate 28...Nh4+. The text brings the rook to life on the e-file and keeps the enemy knight at

bay.

28...Qd5+ 29 Kf2!

White edges the king closer to the centre. Naturally he would be pleased if Black straightened out his pawn structure for him with 29...Qxc4 30 dxc4.

29...Rfd7 30 Rc1!

Another great positional move. At first glance it looks odd as the rook gives up the defence of the d3-pawn and moves to a blocked file. In fact Kasparov is preparing a strong temporary pawn sacrifice that will open the c-file.

30...h5

Unfortunately for Black 30...Qxd3 isn't legal, while 30...Qxc4 31 dxc4 Rd2+ 32 Re2 will leave him once again in a bad endgame.

31 Qxd5+ Rxd5 32 d4! cxd4 33 Rc7

The pawn on d4 can't advance without g7 dropping, but if Black does nothing his queenside pawns will fall. Therefore he has little choice but to allow a multiple exchange into an awful bishop versus knight endgame.

33...R8d7 34 Rxd7 Rxd7 35 Rd1 Nf8 36 Rxd4 Rxd4 37 Bxd4 (Diagram 8)

In such positions the long range bishop is always more powerful than the knight, but here it is particularly bad for Black as the pawns fixed on the dark squares a7 and b6 are easy targets.

37...Ne6 38 Ke3!

Black escapes after 38 Be5 Nc5 39 Bb8 Nxa4 40 Bxa7 Nc3 by eliminating all the queenside pawns, whereas now the king and pawn endgame would be lost after 38...Nxd4 39 Kxd4 Kf7 40 Ke5, and the king will capture the queenside pawns.

38...Kf7 39 Be5 Nc5 40 Kd4!

Black's vulnerable pawns can't run away so the priority is to safeguard the b5-pawn.

40...Nxa4 41 Bb8 Ke6 42 Bxa7 g6 43 Kc4

Black has no good answer to 44 Kb4, when the knight has to give up the b6-pawn.



TIP: The best way to exploit an endgame advantage is to create an 'outside' passed pawn – that is, a pawn on the opposite side of the board to the main mass of pawns.

43...h4 44 gxh4 Nb2+ 45 Kc3 Na4+ 46 Kb4 Nc5 47 Bxb6 Nd3+ 48 Kc4 Nxf4 49 Bf2 Nh3 50 Ba7 Kd7 51 Kd5 Nf4+ 52 Ke5 Nh5 53 Bc5 f4 54 Bf2 Ke7 55 Ke4 Ke6 56 Bd4 Kd6 57 Kf3 Kd5 58 b6 1-0

The king has to retreat to c6, when White goes after the g6-pawn with Kg4 etc.

A marvelous positional display from White.

Game 35

□ **Bacrot** ■ **Topalov**

Dubai 2002

1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 g3 d5 5 cxd5 Nxd5 6 Bg2 Nb6 7 0-0 Be7 8 d3 0-0 9 a3 Be6

Instead Black could prevent the space gaining b2-b4 with 9...a5. However, White has a strong response discovered by Suba: 10 Be3 Re8 11 Rc1 Bg4. Now 12 Na4? allows 12...Nd4 with counterplay, but instead the simple 12 Re1!, defending e2 and therefore taking the sting out of ...Nd4, is strong – 12...Bf8 13 Na4 Nxa4 14 Qxa4 Bd7 15 Qb3 and White has a definite edge.

10 b4 f6

The safest move. Black defends e5 again and looks for counterplay with a7-a5.

We saw 10...Nd4 in the Salov game.

11 Bb2

Bacrot puts the bishop on b2 and retains the option of Rc1. Here 11 Rb1 transposes to the Karpov and Garcia games where we recommend 11...a5 – see the notes to the Garcia game. Topalov adopts the same counter-thrust against 11 Bb2.

11...a5!? 12 b5 Nd4 13 Nd2 c6

Here 13...Nd5? loses a piece in the same fashion as the Garcia game after 14 Bxd5 Bxd5 15 e3 etc.



WARNING: The move recommended in the notes to the Garcia game – 13...Bd5 – looks distinctly risky here because White has played Bb2 rather than Rb1: after 14 Nxd5 Nxd5 there is no fork threatened on c3, and White has ideas of Bxd4 and Qb3. So don't play it here!

Instead Topalov chooses to block the diagonal with 13...c6. This means accepting that his queenside pawns will become disjointed. On the other hand, Black can trust in an overall solid position with active pieces. The idea of 13...c6 works better when White has played Bb2, as in the present game, than after Rb1 (as in the Karpov and Garcia games). This is because White has no immediate pressure with his rook down the b-file against the newly created weakness on b7.

14 bxc6 Nxc6 15 Nb5? (Diagram 9)

White plans an attack on c6 with Rc1, but this just wastes time.

Natural is 15 Rc1, although Black is solid enough after 15...Qd7, with a hard fight ahead.

15...a4! 16 Rc1 Ra5!

Now White has nothing better to do than call an end to his queenside expedition.

17 Nc3 Rf7 18 f4?

White tries again to play actively. It was very difficult to sit and do

nothing, especially after the fiasco on the queenside, but this impulsive thrust just weakens his dark squares in the centre. Perhaps 18 Qc2 Nd4 19 Qb1 was the best way for White to do nothing.

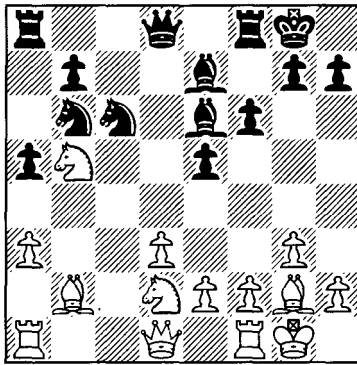


Diagram 9
White's first mistake

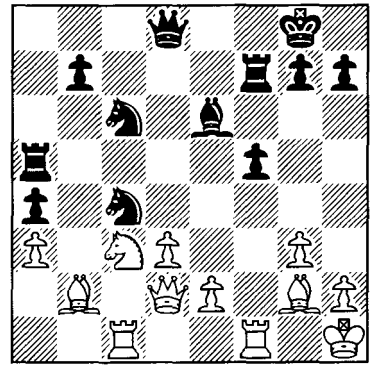


Diagram 10
White is punished

18...exf4 19 Rxf4 f5!

A thematic move that takes away the e4-square from the white pieces and prepares to push back the rook with Bg5, when the bishop can exploit the hole on e3. It gets even worse for White after his inaccurate reply.



NOTE: According to Jon Speelman it takes three 'medium sized' mistakes by White and two from Black to achieve a lost position. White now makes his third and fatal error.

20 Kh1?

Perhaps he should play 20 Rf1 without being pushed as the text allows Black a winning combination.

20...Bg5 21 Rf1 Bxd2! 22 Qxd2 Nc4! (Diagram 10)

Topalov exploits the pin on the d-file. The only move that keeps the bishop defended will cost White the exchange.

23 Qc2 Ne3

White suffers severe punishment for creating this hole with 18 f4.

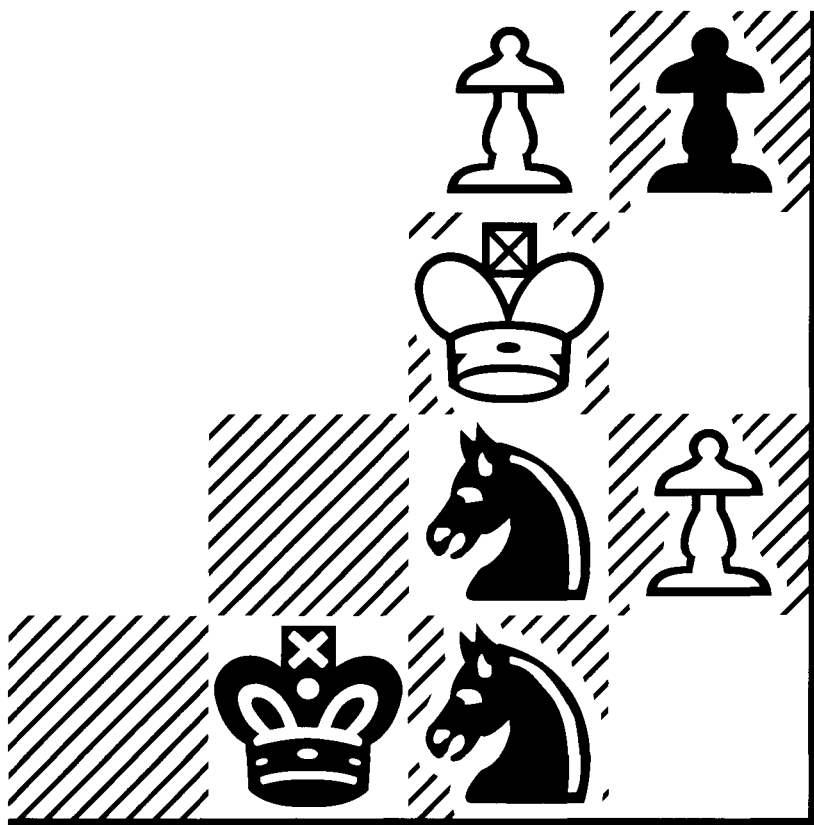
24 Qd2 Nxf1 25 Rxf1 h6 26 Rf4 Bb3 27 Qe1 Ne7 28 Qf2 Nd5 29 Qd4 Qd7 30 Nxd5 Bxd5 31 e4 Bc6 32 Qc3 Rb5 0-1

There isn't much point playing on against a 2700 player when the exchange down.

Chapter Seven

Black Plays a King's Indian Set-up

- Introduction
- The Botvinnik System
- The Standard Set-up



Introduction

In this chapter we look at all lines in which Black adopts a King's Indian style response to the English. These range from the offbeat 1 c4 Nf6 2 Nf3 g6 3 b4 to the main lines of the Four Knights.

The Botvinnik System

This is a very interesting response by White. It is defined by the move e2-e4, as in the following sequence: 1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nc6 3 g3 g6 4 Bg2 Bg7 5 e4 (Diagram 1)

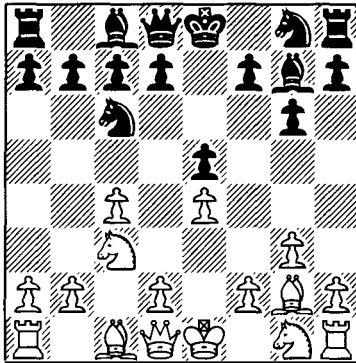


Diagram 1
Botvinnik System

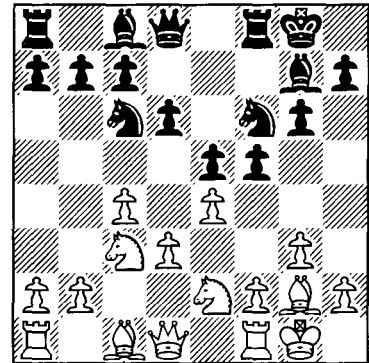


Diagram 2
White controls f4

It looks like White has gone crazy! He has shut in his bishop on g2 and left himself with a hole in the centre on d4! These objections to 5 e4 are valid but there are a lot of good things about the move.

Theoretical?

In comparison with the main lines of the King's Indian there is hardly any theory to learn here. Nevertheless, you need to have some knowledge of the key battle plans for both players.

Restraint of Black's Kingside Attack

First it is worth remembering that a good strategy considers the needs of all the pieces, not just one or two. The bishop on g2 is certainly not happy about finding its route to d5 and the queenside closed, but e2-e4 is an essential move in White's overall plan. One of the fundamental ideas of the Botvinnik System is to draw the fangs of Black's intended assault on the kingside. This direct attack – in which Black plays moves such as ...Nh5, ...f5-f4 and ...g6-g5 in a bid to deliver mate – can be very dangerous if White plays in standard English

style against the King's Indian set-up. You can see that I know this from experience as I've given a game in which I was mated! Psychologically speaking, it is also a good idea to put up barriers against a player intent on a kingside attack: he might destroy his own position by lunging at White's ultra-solid fortress. But just why is White more secure in this variation? Let's see how things might develop from the previous diagram: **5...d6 6 Nge2 f5 7 d3 Nf6 8 0-0 0-0 (Diagram 2)**

Here Black is itching to play ...f5-f4 but White has extra control of this square because he has put his knight on e2. If necessary White could play f2-f4 himself to clear the decks and prevent Black's kingside pawns rampaging forwards. However, as long as Black isn't threatening anything White would desist from this advance – unless it could be made advantageously, – as this entails a certain weakening of his own centre. More likely White would settle for f2-f3!? to strengthen his control of e4.

From all this it is clear that playing Nf3 does not at all fit in with White's set-up because it leaves f4 less well protected and obstructs the f2-pawn. Therefore White has to hold back on developing his king's knight – you can't play the main line Botvinnik System if you intend to open with the Réti move order 1 Nf3.

The d5 and d4-squares

In practice, the d5-square usually proves much more useful for White than the d4-square for Black. The reason for this will be better understood if, from the diagram above, we consider **9 Nd5! (Diagram 3)**

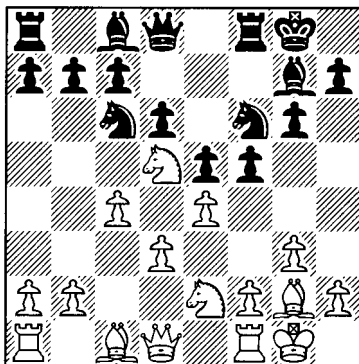


Diagram 3

The excellent d5-knight

White's vice like grip on the d5-square has allowed him to put his knight on an excellent station right in the heart of the centre. Strictly speaking the d5-square isn't an outpost square as it can still be controlled by a black pawn. However, in practice it takes time and incon-

venience for Black to organise ...c7-c6 to evict the knight, so the beast is often left sitting pretty. If Black eliminates it with 9...Nxd5, then after 10 cxd5 White can begin an attack against the c7-pawn with Rc1, Qc2 etc.

The knight on d5 works well in combination with Bg5, when the pin on the knight is very annoying. For example after 9...Be6 10 Bg5 Black is unable to break the pin with 10...h6? because 11 Nxf6+ Bxf6 12 Bxf6 wins a pawn. In contrast, although Black has a genuine outpost square on d4 – a knight sitting there can't be driven out by a pawn – it is much less valuable than the d5-square for White. This is because an exchange of knights on d5 improves White's pawn structure and opens the way for an attack on c7, whereas Black does not benefit from an exchange on d4. In fact after 9...Nd4? 10 Nxd4 exd4 11 exf5 Black has to play 11...gxf5, leaving himself with a weak pawn on f5 and a dead square on f4, as 11...Bxf5 12 Nxf6+ Qxf6 13 Bxb7 costs him a pawn.

Winning plans

Whereas White's initial thoughts in the Botvinnik are to frustrate Black's attacking aspirations on the kingside, it shouldn't be regarded as a purely defensive system. With Nd5! White makes it clear that he also has aggressive intentions. His winning chances usually come through pressure on the c-file or against the enemy centre pawns. As will be seen in the illustrative game, the advance c4-c5 can be a key part of strategy.

And what is Black doing while all this is happening? Normally he masses his pieces in the centre and hopes that White will lose control and let him develop a kingside attack after all. There is a lot of latent power in Black's set-up; just a couple of careless moves by White would be enough to let the Kings Indian lion out of its cage. Nevertheless, Black has to be very patient in this set-up.

Move Order and the Botvinnik System

The vagaries of move order are even more significant here than in other lines of the English. It makes a big difference whether Black has played 1...e5 or 1...Nf6.

After 1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nc6 3 g3 g6 4 Bg2 Bg7 5 e4 d6 6 Nge2 I would go as far to say that 6...Nf6, despite looking very natural, is in fact a doubtful decision. The best square for the knight is undoubtedly f6, but if Black is going to push his f-pawn he will lose time with ...Nh5. Therefore it is much better to play 6...f5 immediately. I am reminded of Philidor's maxim that pawns are the soul of chess: here, certainly, the requirements of the f7-pawn come before the desires of the knight. After 6...Nf6 7 d3 O-O 8 O-O Be6 9 Nd5 Black is solidly placed but it is more difficult for him to generate counterplay than in the main line. Of course, if Black has opened with the very popular 1...Nf6 or devel-

oped the knight at some other early moment he doesn't have the luxury of first playing ...f7-f5. Well, in that case I think he should avoid playing ...e7-e5 until he knows that White isn't going to play the Botvinnik. For example 1...Nf6 2 Nc3 g6 3 g3 Bg7 4 Bg2 0-0 5 d3 d6, and now if 6 Nf3 or 6 e3 Black can happily play 6...e5. If, on the other hand, White wants to play a Botvinnik he has to play 6 e4 here as he has run out of useful waiting moves. But after 6 e4 Black can avoid 6...e5 in favour of 6...c5!, when only White's bishop on g2 is shut in, while the g7-bishop has an open diagonal and influence over the d4-square. In view of this I don't think White should play e2-e4 until Black has committed himself to ...e7-e5. Then the bishop on g7 suffers the same restriction as White's.

So to sum up – if you are White and after 1...Nf6 Black avoids ...e7-e5 you should renounce the Botvinnik in favour of another variation; if you are Black and open 1...Nf6 you should hold back on ...e7-e5 until White can't play the Botvinnik any longer. In the example above, this was move six.

Black's Best Anti-Botvinnik Move Order

Funnily enough, the Dutch Leningrad move order gives Black the most flexibility when facing the Botvinnik.

1...f5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 g3 g6 4 Bg2 Bg7 5 d3 0-0 6 e4 (Diagram 4)

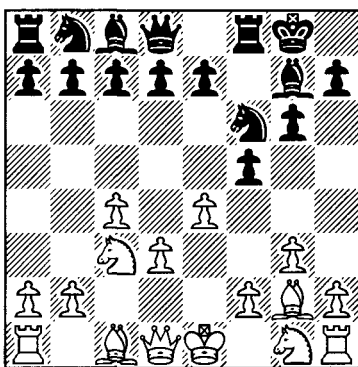


Diagram 4
The Botvinnik grip?

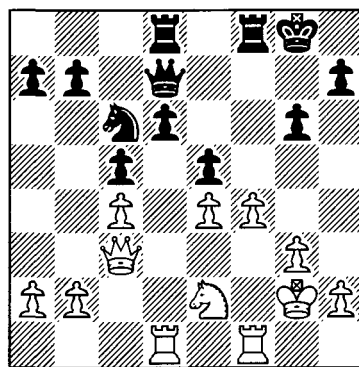


Diagram 5
Planning ...Nd4

Again White has to play this immediately if he wants a Botvinnik. For example 6 Nf3 leaves the knight on the wrong square in the event of a subsequent e2-e4 (it belongs on e2). Now Black can play 6...fxe4 This exchange is usually a positional error if Black has already played ...e7-e5 as it just clarifies White's hold on d5 and gives him potential pressure on the d-file. But Black's 15th move will show it is a good idea here.

7 dxe4 d6 8 Nge2 c5!

Black has useful influence over both d4 and e5.

9 0-0 Nc6 10 f4 Be6!

Black gains time for his plan of exchanging light-squared bishops by attacking c4.

11 Nd5 Qd7 12 Qd3 Bh3 13 Bd2 Bxg2 14 Kxg2

The exchange of bishops has noticeably loosened White's kingside.

14...Rad8 15 Rad1 e6!

This move, to evict the knight from d5, would have been impossible if Black had played an early ...e7-e5.

16 Nxf6+ Bxf6 17 Bc3 Bxc3 18 Qxc3 e5! (Diagram 5)

An excellent positional move that plans ...Nd4, when Black's knight dominates the centre or Black gets a protected passed pawn after a trade on d4. Here a draw was agreed in Gelfand-Kindermann, Biel 1995. Evidently Black was happy to draw with his very strong opponent because, objectively speaking, he has the edge here.

So should you play 1...f5 and risk a Dutch?! Of course most players would be reluctant to play 1...f5 just in case White pulled a dirty trick with 2 d4!, suddenly steering the game to a main line Dutch. But if you are convinced your opponent is a die-hard English player and would never risk 2 d4 or a subsequent d2-d4 this is the move order to choose. Even if after 1...f5 White played a different English variation you would soon transpose to King's Indian territory, for example 1 c4 f5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 g3 g6 4 Bg2 Bg7 5 0-0 d6 6 Nc3 e5 7 d3 reaches the Thipsay game, below.

Game 36

□ **Psakhis** ■ **Danielsen**

Torshavn 2000

1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nc6 3 g3 g6 4 Bg2 Bg7 5 e4 d6 6 Nge2 f5

Black advances the pawn before putting his knight on f6 – the best square. Instead he could try to play in the style of the Hansen-Hodgson game given later in the chapter with 6...Nge7 7 d3 h5, hoping to get a rapid attack with 8...h4. The purpose of putting the knight on e7 rather than f6 is so that 8 Bg5 can be answered by 8.f6, driving away the bishop. However, I think 8 h4!, stopping the pawn in its tracks, should be good for White. Then after 8...0-0 9 0-0 the inclusion of h4/h5 means that a subsequent ...f7-f5 by Black will leave a hole on g5.

7 d3 Nf6 8 0-0 0-0 9 Nd5

This is the key position in the variation and has been discussed above.

9...Be6

Black anticipates the looming pin by preparing to move his queen out of the way.

Instead he could challenge the knight with 9...Ne7 with the idea of ...c7-c6. Then 10 Nxf6+ Bxf6 11 Bh6 Bg7 (perhaps Black should retain some tension with 11...Rf7, although 12 Qd2! is a solid reply) 12 Bxg7 Kxg7 13 d4 gives White a comfortable edge in the centre as Black's kingside is looking rather empty. The knight and bishop that Black had hoped were going to lead an attack on White's king have vanished.

10 Bg5!

The white bishop and knight form a formidable piece duo on the fifth rank.

10...Qd7 11 Qd2 Rf7

It looks logical to double rooks on the f-file, but 11...Nh5! (**Diagram 6**) was more to the point, when White already has to reckon with 12...f4.

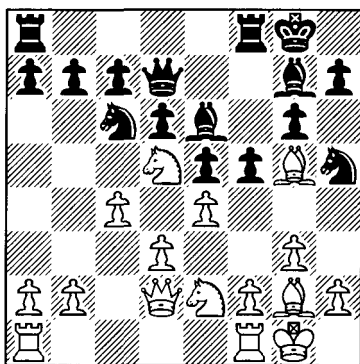


Diagram 6

Black seeks counterplay

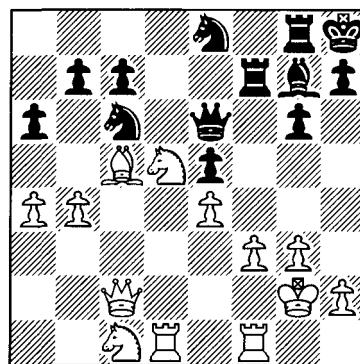


Diagram 7

The knight relocates

Then after 12 exf5 Black has to decide whether to recapture with bishop or pawn. There is an old saying attributed to Botvinnik that every Russian schoolboy knows that Black should recapture on f5 with the pawn in such situations in order to keep the e4-square defended. However, after 12...gxf5 13 f4! the firm blockade on the f4-square stymies Black's attack – the f-file remains closed so that the black rook cannot get at the white king and the c8-h3 diagonal is blocked so that Black can't offer the exchange of bishops with ...Bh3 to weaken the light squares in front of White's king.

Therefore 12...Bxf5! looks the better recapture. Then White can try to gain space on the queenside with 13 b4, but Black has a solid structure and active pieces.

I'm sure that a brilliant strategist like Botvinnik would have recaptured with the bishop, despite the advice above; he would have realised the true nature of the position.



WARNING: Never play according to rules and precepts without looking at the actual position in front of you. The pieces always move in the same way, and checkmate ends the game – but everything else is uncertain.

12 f3

White sets up a barrier (to the black rooks) on f3. If Black doesn't create some counterplay White will prepare a breakthrough on the queenside with c4-c5 with a clear advantage. I imagine someone with a name like G.Kasparov playing Black would find a way to liven things up on the kingside and thereafter bamboozle his opponent with a wonderful piece of tactical wizardry. Nevertheless, among lesser mortals, I believe White has much the better chances here.

12...Raf8 13 Rac1 fxe4

Black decides he needs to make this capture in order to clear the way for ...Bh3. However, the d6-pawn is now vulnerable to a frontal attack. Now we can see clearly that things would have been so much better for Black if he had played 11...Nh5! and cajoled White into making the pawn exchange himself with 12 exf5.

14 dxe4 Ne8

An awkward looking move but, for some reason, Black wants to over-protect as a prelude to ...Bh3. Dropping the knight to the back rank isn't a convincing way to start an attack.

15 Be3 Bh3 16 c5!

White has finished his preparations and now makes the thematic advance. Black's strategy has failed as he has no kingside activity.

16...Bxg2 17 Kxg2 a6 18 Rcd1 Qc8 19 Qc2 Kh8 20 b4 Rg8 21 a4 dxc5

Black has to concede the fight for d6 or be overrun by b4-b5 etc. Now the e5-pawn becomes a target.

22 Bxc5 Qe6 23 Nc1! (Diagram 7)

An excellent redeployment of the knight. From d3 it will attack e5 and also support the bishop on c5 when the next wave of the queen-side assault begins.

23...Bf8 24 Nd3 Bd6 25 Qb2 Rgf8 26 b5 axb5 27 axb5 Nb8 28 b6!

White attacks the defender of the defender. After 28...c6 29 Bxd6 Nxd6 30 Nxe5 Black's centre is destroyed.

28...Nd7 29 N3f4!

Black's queen is suddenly trapped!

TIP: Favourable tactics appear automatically when you have won the strategic battle.

29...Rxf4 30 Nxf4 Rxf4

I guess Black was in time pressure as it was simpler to resign. Some brief fireworks finish things off.



31 Bxd6 Nxd6 32 gxf4 Nc4 33 bxc7 Qc6 34 Rxd7 Qxd7 1-0

After 34...Nxb2 35 Rd8+ White has a new queen, as he will now after 35 Qxb7.

The Standard Set-up

Strategies

If White avoids the Botvinnik System there will be a struggle between White's c4/d3 and Black's d6/e5 pawn centre. Here is a very useful rule of thumb when choosing the best strategy in any given position: try to get another pawn alongside your furthest advanced pawn. The best example of this is that after 1 e4 it is a good idea to play 2 d4 if the opponent allows it. In the English versus King's Indian set-up discussed here White's pawn spearhead is on c4, which suggests he should prepare b2-b4 or d2-d4.

Black's leading pawn is on e5, which suggests ...f7-f5 or ...d7-d5. As will be seen, players do indeed base their plans on these moves, except that White generally avoids trying to advance a pawn to d4 as such a move would be at least inconsistent and time wasting if he has already played a preliminary d2-d3. If White had wanted to play c2-c4 and d2-d4 he should have played 1 d4!

The layout of pieces chosen by each player to implement their plans – or to prevent the opponent carrying out the desired strategy – can be broken down into several distinct scenarios.

Theoretical?

Not very, but you can still lose quickly in Scenario One if you fail to judge correctly the relative strength of the attacks by White and Black on the queenside and kingside respectively. Of course this means that Scenario One also offers you the most winning chances as your opponent also faces difficult problems! But if you are looking for security the safest ways for White to handle the position are Scenarios Two and Four.

Scenario One: Black has Delayed ...Nf6

If Black has chosen a move order that allows him to play ...f7-f5 before ...Nf6 it frequently becomes a straight fight between White's pressure on the queenside and Black's kingside attack. The following position can be regarded as archetypal and is reached after the moves **1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nc6 3 g3 g6 4 Bg2 Bg7 5 Nf3 d6 6 d3 f5 7 0-0 Nf6 (Diagram 8)**

Black has the optimal setup for a kingside attack thanks to the fact that he has delayed ...Nf6. In doing so he has been able to achieve the ...f7-f5 advance without any effort. Now play can go:

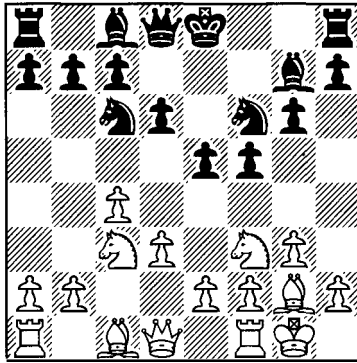


Diagram 8
Black has played ...f7-f5

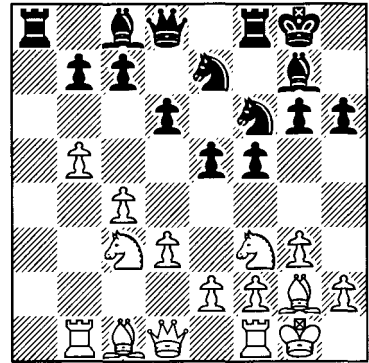


Diagram 9
A key position

8 Rb1

The alternative 8 Bg5 is considered below. By putting the rook on b1 White prepares to gain space on the queenside with b2-b4 followed by b4-b5, a2-a4 etc. The first decision Black has to make is whether to obstruct White's plan with...

8...a5!?

It is only a temporary measure, as after...

9 a3 0-0 10 b4 axb4 11 axb4

White has achieved his advance. However, Black's rook has a ready-made open a-file. This is double-edged, as Black isn't intending to attack on the queenside and the open file could easily fall into White's hands. However, Black has narrowed the pawn front by a file so that he isn't left with a potentially weak pawn on a7. The consensus of opinion seems to be that 8...a5 is a good idea. Let's look at how play can develop.

11...h6

This move has several purposes. For example, it rules out Bg5 and could be used to support a kingside pawn push with ...g6-g5. However, the main reason for the text is to prepare ...Be6 without being hit by Ng5. After 11...Be6 12 b5 Ne7 13 Ng5 Black has nothing better than 13...Bc8 in view of the attack on b7.

12 b5 Ne7 (Diagram 9)

Black's Battle Plan on the Kingside

White has to increase his pressure on the queenside as doing nothing isn't an option: Black will build up his own attack on the kingside. If White insists on 'passing' I can promise you it will be checkmate in ten moves: ...g6-g5, ...f5-f4, ...Qe8, ...Qh5, ...Bh3, ...Ng4, ...f4xg3, ...Bxg2, ...Rxf3 and ...Qxh2 mate.

Or if Black is more positionally minded he might play ...Be6, then ...Rb8 (to guard against an attack on b7 after Nd2), then ...Qd7, massing his pieces in the centre before an attack with ...g6-g5, ...f5-f4 and ...Bh3. Naturally the advance ...f5-f4 would have to be carefully judged by Black as it gives away pawn control of e4. In other words, for his plan to be successful Black's pressure on the f-file and/or the opportunity of ...Bh3 would have to outweigh the weakening of his control of the light squares.



WARNING: When he advances b2-b4 in this variation White has to watch out for the sudden counterstroke ...e5-e4, winning material due to the influence of the bishop on the long diagonal.

White's Queenside Action

What should White do? He could lash out with 13 b6. If then 13...cxb6 Black's centre is weakened and the b-file opened – all for a mere doubled pawn which he can't even hold onto after 14 Qb3 Ra6 15 Be3. Therefore a much better response by Black would be 13...c6. This keeps his centre intact and adds a guardian to the d5-square. Nevertheless White could perhaps claim a tiny edge with 14 c5!?, so best would be 13...c5!, closing the queenside and ruling out any c4-c5. True, it leaves a hole on d5, but this square is well fortified and will be even more so after a subsequent ...Be6. With the centre nice and solid, and no queenside attack by White in sight, Black can begin his own kingside attack in peace. White could build up more forces with 13 Qb3 or 13 Bb2, but he has a dynamic alternative:

13 c5!? (Diagram 10)

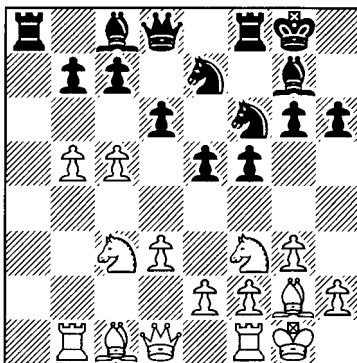


Diagram 10

White breaks up the queenside

Black now has a large number of possible replies: some lead to a decent position whilst others are downright bad.

Option 1: Take the pawn with 13...dxc5

Of course, this is anti-positional, as White can now grab the e5-pawn with 14 Nxe5, after which he has achieved his aim of smashing up Black's centre. Still, tactics always come before strategy, even in the English! And isn't White living dangerously in snatching a pawn right in front of the dark-squared bishop?

So we had better check out that White doesn't drop a piece: 14...Qd4. This looks strong as two knights are forked. But the simple 15 Qb3+ Kh7 16 Nf3 avoids disaster whilst keeping all the positional trumps for White. Looking more deeply, there is the little trick 15 Nc4 Qxc3?? 16 Bb2 winning the queen, but it was wholly unnecessary to be able to see this tactic before venturing 13 c5, as 15 Qb3+ was perfectly safe.

Option 2: Utilise the hole White has left on d5

Another try for Black is 14...Nfd5, unleashing the bishop on g7. Then after 15 Nxd5 Nxd5 Black appears to have two threats – a knight fork on c3 and ...Bxe5. In fact we see that ...Nc3 can always be met by Qb3+, so this is no threat. But in any case with 16 Bb2 White can defend the knight and cut out ...Nc3 altogether. Now nothing tactical is happening, which means that White's superior pawn structure is the key feature of the position. Again it is possible for White to find a more tactical solution to the problem – both 16 Nxg6! (intending 16...Nc3 17 Qb3+) and 16 Bxd5+! Qxd5 17 Nxg6 leave White material up. But I repeat, you didn't have to see any of this to justify 13 c5! – as long as it doesn't lose material it is good for White!

Option Three: Advance the d-pawn with 13...d5

Black offers the e5-pawn. If White refuses the offer he is admitting that his strategy has been a complete failure as Black can race forwards with ...e5-e4, dislodge the knight from c3 with ...d5-d4 or simply maintain his centre. Then 13 c5 would be seen to be a stupid move as it has given up all pawn pressure on d5. So the only reply is 14 Nxe5. Black can cause the white knights some discomfort after 14...d4 15 Na4 Nfd5, but 16 f4!? or 16 Nc4 look better for White. As Steinitz would say 'an extra pawn is worth a little trouble.'

Option Four: Advance the e-pawn with 13...e4!?

Black's idea is that White has given up pawn control of d5, so that this bold thrust can be strongly supported by ...d6-d5. After 14 dxe4 fxe4 15 cxd6! (a vital counter) 15...cxd6 (Black is a pawn down after 15...exf3 16 dxe7 Qxe7 17 Bxf3) 16 Nd4 d5 both sides have achieved their aims: White has won the beautiful d4-square for his knight, while Black has established a pawn centre.

Option Five: Ignore the queenside with 13...Nh5?

This worked out badly for Black in one of my own games after 14 b6! d5? (after 14...e4 15 Qb3+ the knight is defended and 16 dxe4 follows, so Black has to try 14...dxc5 15 bxc7 Qxc7, although 16 Nb5, intending Be3, gives White a huge initiative for the pawn) 15 bxc7 Qxc7 16 Nb5! Qxc5 17 Nxe5! (the Fork Trick destroys Black's centre) 17...d4

(17...Bxe5 18 d4 and Black loses his vital bishop) 18 Nc4 f4 19 Nbd6 Ra7 20 Qb3 Be6 21 Ba3 Bxc4 (the overwhelming force of White's pieces wins material – 21...Qg5 22 Ne4 and the knight on e7 drops) 22 Bxc5 Bxb3 23 Bxa7 Bd5 24 Nb5 Bxg2 25 Kxg2 Nf5 26 Rfc1 1-0, McDonald-Quillan, Swansea 1987.

Option 6: Bolster the centre with 13...Be6!

Undoubtedly the best idea. Black takes control of the a2-g8 diagonal. Now 14 b6 dxc5 15 bxc7 Qxc7 16 Nb5 Qb8 17 Nxe5! wins back the pawn for 17...Qxe5 18 Bf4 sees the queen trapped in the centre of the board! However, 17...g5 or the messy 17...Ba2 (18 Bf4!) both give Black a lot of dynamic play to compensate for the inferior pawn structure. Another line is 14 Bd2 Nd7! (forcing White's hand on the queenside before he can undermine c7 with b5-b6) 15 cxd6 cxd6 16 Na4 b6!, creating a strongpoint for his knight on c5. Akopian-Anand, Belgrade 1988 continued 17 Bb4 Nc5 18 Bxc5 dxc5 19 Qc2 Ra7!, Black completing the evacuation of the long diagonal with an unclear position.

Instead of the immediate bid for a queenside push with 8 Rb1 White could play **8 Bg5 (Diagram 11)**

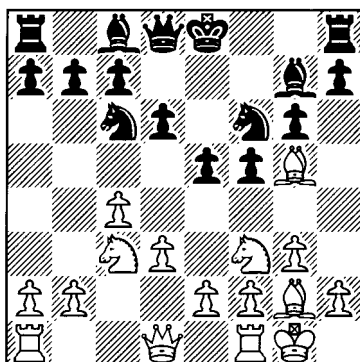


Diagram 11

White pins the knight

White is willing to give up his bishop for the knight on f6 in order to increase his influence over both d5 and e4 and to remove one of the potential attackers on the kingside. It sounds good, but I suffered a disaster in the following game when I tried it as White:

Game 37

□ McDonald ■ Thipsay

Lloyds Bank London 1986

1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nc6 3 g3 g6 4 Bg2 Bg7 5 Nf3 d6 6 d3 f5 7 0-0 Nf6 8 Bg5 h6 9 Bxf6 Qxf6 10 Nd5

White immediately takes control of the square he has won with the trade on f6.

10...Qf7 11 b4!? 0-0

White was hoping for 11...e4 12 dxe4 Bxa1 13 Qxa1 0-0 14 b5 when he has pressure and a pawn in return for the exchange.

12 Rb1 g5 (Diagram 12)

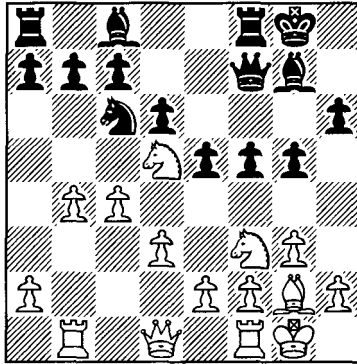


Diagram 12

Black's kingside expansion

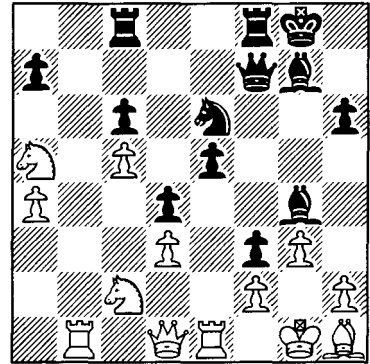


Diagram 13

The beast awakes!

13 a4

An interesting alternative was 13 Qa4, intending the advance b5-b6 to exploit the pin on the a-file.

13...Nd8 14 b5 c6 15 Nb4 Be6

The knight has been evicted from d5, but on the other hand there is now a target on c6. Unfortunately I became over-excited by this and embarked on a wholly over-ambitious manoeuvre with my knights.

16 Nd2 Rc8 17 Nb3

Interesting was 17 f4, for example 17...exf4 18 gxf4 Bd4+ 19 Kh1. Black's dark-squared bishop is then an excellent piece, but all is not perfect as the knight on d8 is completely boxed in by its own pieces and the bishop on e6 has nothing to attack.

17...g4 18 bxc6 bxc6 19 Na5 Qd7 20 Na6? f4!

White has moved his knights to the furthest possible point from his king. Therefore it is no surprise that he now comes under a strong attack.

21 Be4

21 Nb8 Qe8 leaves the knight on b8 looking rather odd!

21...Qf7 22 Nb4 d5

This move signals the complete defeat of White's opening strategy: he can no longer put pressure on c6 as Black has seized control of the centre.

23 Bh1 f3 24 exf3 gxf3

With his proud bishop buried on h1 it is no wonder that White finds himself outgunned when the tactical battle begins.

25 Re1 Bg4 26 Nc2 d4 27 c5 Ne6! (Diagram 13)

The knight that has spent most of the game sitting idly on the back rank is going to play a starring role in the final attack.

28 Nc4 Qh5 29 Rb7 Ng5 30 h4 Nh3+ 31 Kf1 Bf6!

Black plays the attack with great skill. The bishop will sacrifice itself on h4 to open lines against the king.

32 Re4 Bxh4 33 Nxe5

It looks like White has achieved a lot of counterplay, but there came:

33...Nxf2!

This detonates what is left of White's defences.

34 gxh4 Nxe4!

Black finds the correct way to win White's queen. Not immediately 34...Nxd1 35 Rxd4+ (35...Kh8 36 Ng6+ etc.).

35 dxe4 Bh3+ 36 Kg1 f2+ 37 Kh2 Qxd1

My opponent was in bad time trouble – I don't normally play on in such positions!

38 Nxd4 Qxh1+ 39 Kxh1 f1Q+ 40 Kh2 Qg2 mate.



NOTE: It might seem unfair to White that he only gets to aim for queenside pressure whereas Black is playing for higher stakes (mate!). However, while Black sometimes scores a spectacular victory – as in the above game – the odds of White achieving queenside pressure are higher, so White is more likely to win, or at least draw, than to lose.

Scenario Two: White Plays Nge2

The game above demonstrates the power of Black's attacking set-up with ...f7-f5 if White plays with insufficient accuracy. Therefore it is no wonder that instead of Nf3 White often chooses to take an extra precaution with e2-e3 and Nge2, when the king's knight helps to control the f4-square. This also retains the option of blocking the f4-square if necessary with f2-f4.

Game 38

□ **M.Gurevich** ■ **Kamsky**

Reggio Emilia 1991

1 c4 e5 2 g3 Nc6 3 Bg2 g6 4 Nc3 Bg7 5 Rb1

A useful semi-waiting move, for 5...d6 6 b4 sees White gain space on the queenside, while 5...Nf6 can be answered by 6 d3 and 7 Nf3, putting the knight on a more active square than e2 now that Black has given up on the option of ...f7-f5. Perhaps the best feature of 5 Rb1 is that White takes the power out of any ...h7-h5 advance by keeping Nf3 in reserve – see Hansen-Hodgson, below.

5...a5

Black prevents b2-b4. Another way for play to develop was 5...f5 6 d3 Nf6 7 e3 0-0 8 Nge2.

6 d3 d6 7 e3

As Black hasn't played ...Nf6 White decides to put the knight on e2.

7...f5 8 Nge2 Nf6 9 b3

White forgoes the plan of queenside expansion with a2-a3 and b2-b4 in favour of a plan involving Bb2 and f2-f4, when he has pressure against Black's centre. 5 Rb1 will be seen to have been of value later in the game as a white knight will utilise the b5-square that has been weakened 5...a5.

9...0-0 10 Bb2 Bd7?

A passive square for the bishop. A much more inspired approach is 10...Be6, which begins an immediate fight for the d5-square. M.Gurevich-P.Nikolic, Antwerp 1997 continued 11 Nd5 Bf7 (so that he can play 12...Nxd5 without losing a piece to the fork after 13 cxd5) 12 Nec3 Nxd5 13 Nxd5 Nb8!, preparing to evict the knight from its central square with 14...c6. Black's retreating manoeuvres ...Bf7! and ...Nb8! are very instructive.

11 Qd2 Rb8

Black seems to have no plan in mind and makes a series of rather aimless moves with his pieces.

12 0-0 b6?! (Diagram 14)

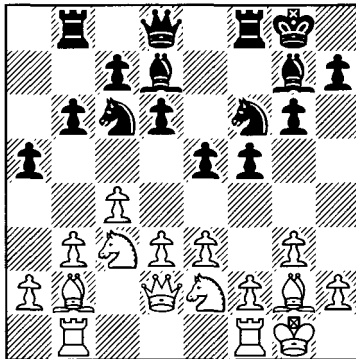


Diagram 14
Black's ugly queenside

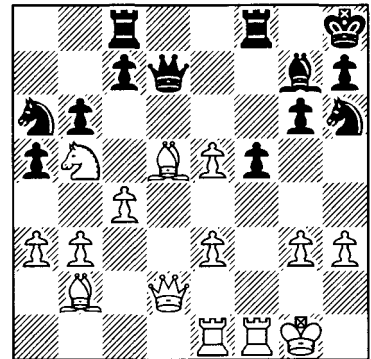


Diagram 15
Who's fooling who?

This looks ugly as it takes away the support of the knight on c6. It also means that a subsequent ...c7-c6 by Black to drive away a knight from d5 will leave Black's queenside even more fragile.

13 Rbe1 Kh8 14 f4

A lot of English devotees like this type of set-up as White's centre is

now almost invincible. In contrast it can be a frustrating experience for Black – who has shown by his move order that he likes the King's Indian – to find himself facing a brick wall.

14...Ng4

The knight heads for h6, but why? It was better to leave it on f6 (where it defends d5) and shuffle another piece.

15 Nd5

Meanwhile White purposefully increases his grip on both d5 and b5.

15...Be6 16 h3 Nh6 17 Nec3 Qd7 18 Nb5 Rbc8 19 d4!

At last Gurevich decides it is time for a pawn advance in the centre. There is now the positional threat of 20 Ndxc7! Rxc7 21 d5, when White regains his piece having severely undermined Black's centre.

19...Bxd5 20 Bxd5 Nb4

Black had relied on this move, which threatens his own fork with 21...c6, to save him from his difficulties, but favourable tactics rarely appear when the strategical battle has been lost.

21 dxe5! dxe5

After 21...c6 22 Nxd6 cxd5 23 Nxc8 Rxc8 24 a3 Nc6 25 cxd5 White has a crushing position.

22 a3 Na6

Black still puts his trust in the ...c7-c6 threat. 22...Nxd5 23 Qxd5 Qxd5 24 cxd5 is good for White as Black can't get rid of the weak c-pawn in view of 24...c6 25 Na7.

23 fxe5! (Diagram 15)

White falls for the 'trap' and gets a winning position.

23...c6 24 e6 Qe7 25 Bxg7+ Qxg7 26 Nd6 Rc7

26...cxd5 27 Nxc8 Rxc8 28 cxd5 wins easily for White, but now 27 Bg2 Nc5, intending ...Nxe6, gets Black back into the game.

27 e4!

The killer move. The passed pawns are overwhelming after 27...cxd5 28 exd5 even if White doesn't get the exchange thrown in as well. White could play Nb5 and d5-d6, etc.



NOTE: A pair of connected passed pawns can be worth more than a piece, especially if they can easily reach the sixth rank. In the middlegame such pawns are even stronger in the centre as their advance spreads confusion among the defender's pieces.

27...Re7

Black wriggles on but he is left a passed pawn down.

28 exf5 gxf5 29 Bxc6 Nc5 30 Kh2 Nxb3 31 Qg2 Nc5 32 Bd5 Nd3 33 Re3 Ne5 34 Qe2 Ng6 35 Ref3 Qf6 36 Nxf5!

A decisive breakthrough. The black rooks will be no match for the queen, especially as White will shortly have a second passed pawn.

36...Nxf5 37 Rxf5 Qxf5 38 Rxf5 Rxf5 39 h4!

The king will be very safe on h3 if necessary. Black now fights grimly but the end is inevitable.

39...Rg7 40 Qb2 Ne7 41 Qxb6 Rf8 42 Qd6 Kg8 43 Be4 Rc8 44 c5 Kh8 45 Qe5 Ng8 46 c6 Rcc7 47 Qxa5 Nf6 48 Bf3 Rce7 49 Qd8+ Ng8 50 Qd4 Rc7 51 Qe5 Ra7 52 h5 Rac7 53 a4 Nh6 54 Kh3 Ng8 55 a5 Ra7 56 Be4 Rac7 57 g4 h6 58 Kg3 Rce7 59 Bg6 Rc7 60 Bf7 Rxc6 61 e7 Nxe7 62 Qxe7 Rc3+ 63 Kh4 Rxf7 64 Qe5+ 1-0

One drawback of the Nge2 deployment is that, in contrast to Nf3, White can't answer the lunge with ...h5-h4 with Nxh4. Hodgson exploited this perfectly in the following game.

Game 39

□ C.Hansen ■ Hodgson

Hamburg 2001

1 c4 e5 2 g3 Nc6 3 Bg2 g6 4 Nc3 Bg7 5 e3

White prepares to put his knight on e2. If he wanted to prevent ...h7-h5 he could have played like Gurevich (above) with 5 Rb1, when after 5...d6 6 b4 h5? 7 Nf3! it is hard to see why Black has played ...h7-h5.

5...d6 6 Nge2 h5!? (Diagram 16)

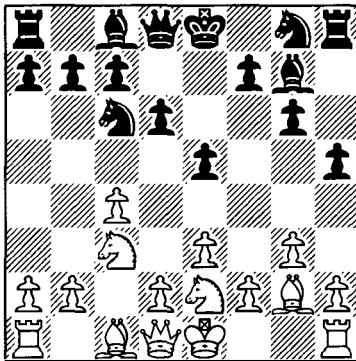


Diagram 16
Black reacts to Nge2

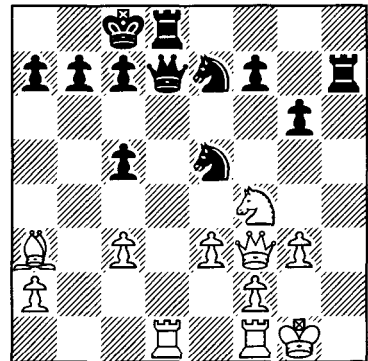


Diagram 17
Uncompromising play!

An ambitious counterstroke on the kingside, beyond the reach of White's knight on e2.

7 d4?!

A logical reply, but 7 h4 was safer.

7...exd4 8 Nxd4 Nge7

The knight eyes a strong square on f5.

9 Nde2?

Too passive, although 9 Nxc6 Nxc6 10 h3 (to maintain control of g4)

10...Be6 would be very comfortable for Black.

9...h4 10 0-0

White castles into the attack, no doubt because he wanted to clear the h1-square for his bishop as 10...h3 would otherwise be awkward.

10...hxc3 11 hxc3 Bh3 12 Bxh3 Rxh3 13 Nf4 Rh7 14 c5

White gives up a pawn in a bid to stave off Black's attack, which would soon become decisive after ...Qd7, ...0-0-0 and ...Rdh8.

14...Bxc3 15 bxc3 dxc5 16 Qf3

Of course exchanging queens leads to a lost endgame.

16...Qd7 17 Ba3 0-0-0 18 Rad1 Ne5! (Diagram 17) 19 Qe4

19 Qe2 Rdh8! 20 Rxd7 Rh1+ 21 Kg2 R8h2 mate.

19...Qxd1 20 Rxd1 Rxd1+ 21 Kg2 N7c6 22 Nh3 b6 23 g4 Kb7 24 Kg3 f5!

A decisive opening of lines.

25 gxf5 gxf5 26 Qxf5 Rg7+ 0-1

27 Kf4 Rf7 or 27 Kh2 Ng4+ or, finally, 27 Kh4 Rd8!, and the white king is defenceless.

Scenario Three: Black has Played an Early ...Nf6

If Black has opened 1...Nf6, or played ...Nf6 at some other early point before ...f7-f5, then a similar position is reached to that in Scenario One, above, but with the black pawn still on f7. For example **1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 g3 g6 5 Bg2 Bg7 6 0-0 0-0 7 d3 d6 8 Rb1 (Diagram 18)**

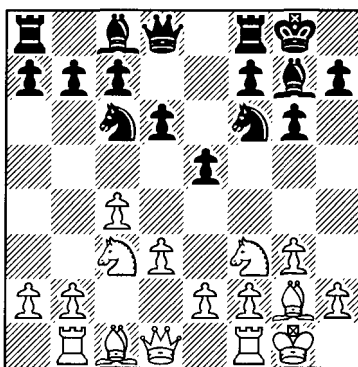


Diagram 18

Black hasn't arranged ...f7-f5

Now it is harder for Black to develop a kingside attack as this involves moving the knight out of the way of the f-pawn, typically with ...Nh5. The knight might prove to be well placed on h5 if Black man-

ages to carry out a concerted attack with ...f5-f4, but it is a risky business as Black is giving up the fight for the key centre squares d5 (with ...Nh5) and e4 (with both ...Nh5 and ...f5-f4). White might well seize these squares with Nd5 and the manoeuvre Nd2-e4. Therefore if he hasn't played an early ...f7-f5 Black often prefers to play in the centre with moves such as ...Be6 and ...c7-c6 followed by ...d6-d5.

Game 40

□ Bareev ■ Bacrot

Sarajevo 2000

1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 g3 g6 5 Bg2 Bg7 6 0-0 0-0 7 d3 d6 8 Rb1

The move order has meant that Black was unable to play a quick ...f7-f5.

8...a5

Instead Black could try for immediate action with 8...Nd4, when 9 Nxd4?! exd4 10 Nb5 Ng4 11 h3 c6! gives Black the initiative after either 12 hxg4 cxb5 13 cxb5 Bxg4 or 12 Na3 Nh6 13 Nc2 Nf5. White should carry on with his queenside advance with 9 b4! here.

9 a3 h6

Black prepares ...Be6 by ruling out Ng5, and also prevents Bg5. In a game from the same tournament Bacrot had played 9...Re8, when 10 Bg5 h6 11 Bxf6 Bxf6 12 b4 axb4 13 axb4 Bg7 14 b5 Ne7 15 Qb3 gave White useful queenside pressure in M.Gurevich-Bacrot, Sarajevo 2000.

10 b4 axb4 11 axb4 Be6 12 b5 Ne7 13 Qb3 c6? (Diagram 19)

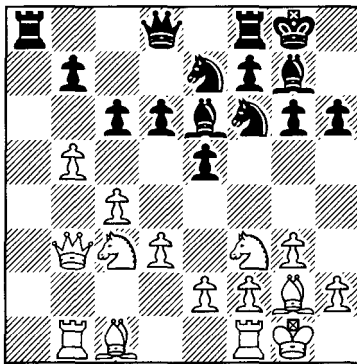


Diagram 19
Black weakens d6

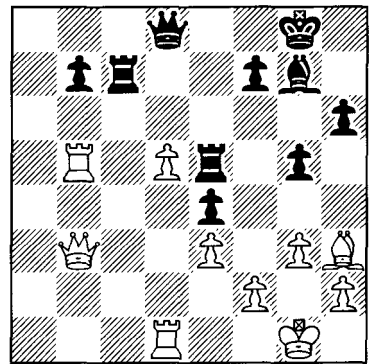


Diagram 20
A helping hand

Black wants to play ...d6-d5. This is a logical idea but Bareev is able to make sure it doesn't work. Instead 13...Nd7! keeps Black very solid, for example 14 Ba3 b6!? 15 Nd2 Rc8, intending ...Nc5.

14 Ba3!

In contrast to the note above the bishop now has a target on d6. And beyond this square the bishop is ready to eliminate the knight on e7, which will defend the d5-pawn after ...d6-d5.

14...Re8 15 Rfc1 g5?!

Bareev suggests the more solid 15...Qd7 or 15...Kh7.

16 e3 Bf5 17 Ne1 Be6

Black should have kept the knight tied down to the defence of d3. Instead 17...Rc8 bolsters the centre.

18 Nc2!

The knight takes the opportunity to reach an aggressive square.

18...d5

This leads to trouble but 18...Bf5 doesn't prevent White's build-up: 19 Nb4! when, in the event of 19...c5 White can pick up the b7-pawn in return for the d3-pawn – 20 Nbd5! Bxd3 21 Nxf6+ Bxf6 22 Nd5 Nxd5 (forced) 23 Qxd3 Nb6 24 Bxb7 with a clear advantage.

19 Bxe7 Rxe7 20 Nb4!

White makes a temporary pawn sacrifice to establish a passed pawn on the d5-square.

20...dxc4 21 dxc4 cxb5 22 Nbd5! Bxd5 23 Nxd5 Nxd5 24 cxd5 e4

The only move to prevent White from reinforcing the passed pawn with 25 e4.



TIP: A passed pawn is usually much stronger when it is protected by another pawn.

Nevertheless, 24...Ra5! was a tougher defence in order to maintain a passed pawn which gives at least a semblance of rivalry to the pawn on d5.

25 Rc5

Now White regains his pawn, after which the pawn on d5 is much more valuable than the pawn on b7 which, although also passed, is too far back to offer Black any counterplay.

25...Rc8 26 Rxb5 Re5 27 Rd1 Rc7 28 Bh3! (Diagram 20)

The bishop clears the way for the passed pawn. Black's bishop can't obstruct the pawn as 28...Bf6 29 d6! Rxb5 30 dxc7 wins for White.

28...Qf6 29 d6 Rxb5 30 Qxb5 Rc2 31 Bf5 Bf8 32 d7 Be7 33 d8R+!?

A rook and not a queen? Bareev analysed this game for Informator 78 and the score of the game there confirms that he chose to underpromote. Perhaps he thought that the rotten black bishop didn't deserve the glory of capturing a queen. In any case White now has a forced win.

33...Bxd8 34 Qe8+ Kg7 35 Rxd8 Rc1+ 36 Kg2 Qxf5 37 Qf8+ Kg6 38 Rd6+ 1-0

38...f6 39 Qe8+ Kg7 40 Rd7+, or 38...Kh5 39 Qxh6+ Kg4 40 h3 and Black has been mated by a pawn.

Scenario Four: White Plays an early b2-b4!?

Finally, White has an interesting early option in 1 c4 Nf6 2 Nf3 g6 3 b4!? (Diagram 21)

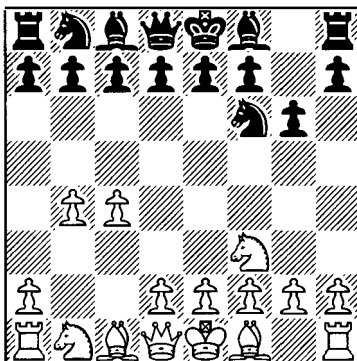


Diagram 21
White prepares Bb2

White immediately clears the b2-square so that with Bb2 he can fight for control of the key diagonal. Play could develop as in Scenario Three after, for example, 3...Bg7 4 Bb2 d6 5 g3 0-0 6 Bg2 e5 7 d3. Black could try to upset White's build-up with a well timed ...a7-a5, perhaps even 3...a5!?, when White does best to continue 4 b5.

Game 41

□ Korchnoi ■ Belotti

Novi Sad 1990

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nf3 g6 3 b4 Bg7 4 Bb2 0-0 5 e3!?

Rather than prepare Bg2 White decides to put the bishop on e2, from where c4 can be monitored.

5...c6

5...d6 6 d4!? is interesting.

6 d4 d5

Now the game has transposed to a type of Slav in which Black has fianchettoed on g7.

7 Nbd2 Bg4

Two days after this game was played Korchnoi reached the same position against GM Ian Rogers, who preferred 7...a5!? 8 b5 cxb5 9 cxb5 Nbd7 10 Bd3 Ne8, when the knight was manoeuvred to d6 in order to attack b5, control c4 and support ...Bf5 to exchange bishops. White

kept a slight edge after 11 Ba3 Nb6 12 0-0 Nd6 13 Rc1.

8 Be2 Nbd7 9 h3!

White immediately acquires the two bishops. Instead 9 0-0 Re8 10 Rc1 Rc8 11 Qb3 Ne4! equalised quickly for Black after 12 Rfd1 Nb6 13 cxd5 Nxd2 14 Rxd2 cxd5 in Smyslov-Ftacnik, Beersheba 1990.

9...Bxf3 10 Bxf3 b5?

White is able to defeat the idea behind this move, after which it proves to be a serious weakening of the queenside. 10...Re8 11 b5!? might favour White, who softens up the defence of d5. Perhaps 10...Nb6!? is best, when after 11 c5?! (11 Rc1!?) 11...Nbd7 Black can be pleased that the c-file is closed.

11 cxb5 cxb5 12 a4! (Diagram 22)

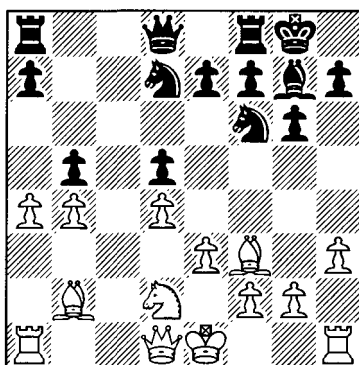


Diagram 22

White strikes the queenside

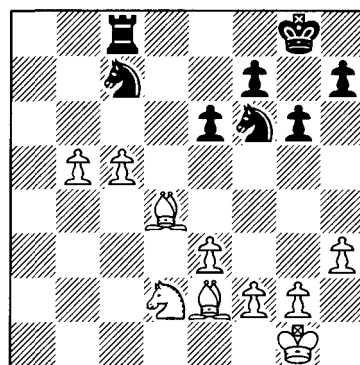


Diagram 23

The pawns decide

It is essential to remove the b5-pawn before Black has the chance to play 12...Nb6, when the knight has control of both a4 and c4.

12...bxa4 13 Qxa4 Nb6 14 Qb3 Qd7 15 0-0 Rfc8 16 Ra5 e6 17 Rfa1 Rc7

Black can't free himself with 17...Nc4 18 Nxc4 Rxc4 in view of 19 Qxc4! dxc4 20 Bxa8 c3!? (hoping for 21 Bxc3? Qc8 with a double attack on a8 and c3) 21 Ba3! and White's rooks outweigh the queen.

18 Rc5!

The rook is perfectly placed here as it rules out any counterplay on the c-file.

18...Rb8 19 Be2 Bf8 20 Qc3!

Black is unable to dislodge the rook as after 20...Bxc5 21 dxc5 the pressure that the white queen and bishop are suddenly exerting on kingside will win the knight on f6.

20...Na8 21 b5 Rbc8

Black prepares to capture on c5 but it leads to ruin.

22 Rxa7! Bxc5

22...Rxa7 23 Rxc8, or 22...Rxc5 23 dxc5 Qxa7 24 Qxf6 and mate follows on h8.

23 Rxc7 Nxc7 24 dxc5 d4

Black had relied on this defence but in the endgame White's passed pawns and strong bishops are far more powerful than the black rook and knight.

25 Qxd4 Qxd4 26 Bxd4 (Diagram 23) 26...Nce8 27 b6 e5 28 Ba6!

White keeps connected passed pawns as 28 Bxe5? Rxc5 29 b7 Nd7! is far from clear thanks to the counter 28...Rc2.

28...Rd8

28...Ra8 29 b7.

29 Bxe5! Nd7

29...Rxd2 30 b7 Nd7 31 c6! etc.

30 Bd4 Nxc5 31 Bxc5 Rxd2 32 b7 Rb2 33 Ba7 Nc7 34 b8Q+ Rxb8 35 Bxb8 Nxa6

It appears that Black has avoided disaster. Indeed if you put the black knight somewhere like e6 he should hold the draw. In such situations, with pawns on only one side of the board, it is better to have a knight rather than a bishop as the knight can control squares of both colours. However, the bishop can also do something that the knight can't...

36 Bd6!

The bishop completely immobilises the knight. The only hope for Black to rescue his piece is to dislodge the bishop from d6, but White's e-pawn prevents this just in time.

36...f5 37 f3 Kf7 38 e4 fxe4 39 fxe4 Ke6 40 e5

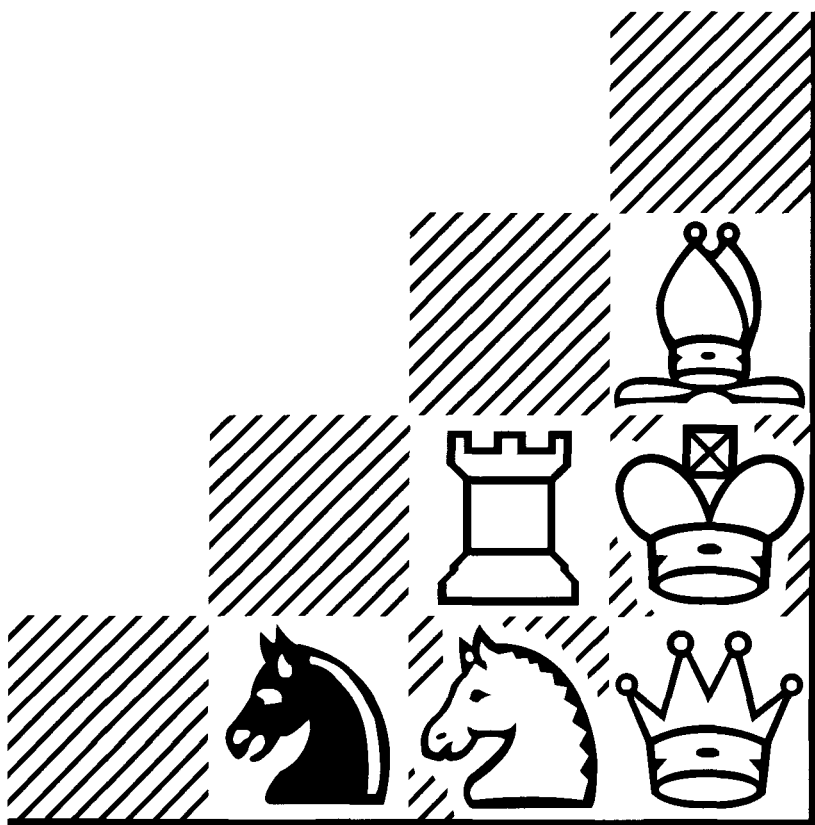
If Black waits then White brings up his king. Instead he prefers a lost king and pawn endgame.

40...Kd5 41 Kf2 Nc5 42 Bxc5 Kxc5 43 Kf3 1-0

Chapter Eight

Réti Lines

- Introduction
- The Slav Treatment: 1...c6
- The Queen's Gambit Treatment: 1...e6



Introduction

Although this book is about the English Opening, in this chapter we'll look at games in which White plays 1 c4 and – in order to avoid transposing to a 1 d4 opening – is obliged to enter Réti lines. These are defined by a black pawn structure d5/c6 or d5/e6.

The Slav Treatment: 1...c6

Strategies

As the Slav Defence is a popular opening versus 1 d4 it is no surprise that many players are also keen to adopt it against the English. After the typical sequence **1 c4 c6 2 Nf3 d5 3 g3 Nf6 4 Bg2** Black wants to complete the triangle of pawns on light squares with ...e7-e6. This will give him a very secure centre, with the pawn on d5 forming a solid barrier against the bishop on g2. However, he would like to first develop his light-squared bishop outside this structure, as after 4...e6 the bishop would be condemned to spend a long time as a passive piece. So that means Black has to choose whether to play **4...Bf5 (Diagram 1)** – the New York System – or **4...Bg4 (Diagram 2)** – Capablanca's System.

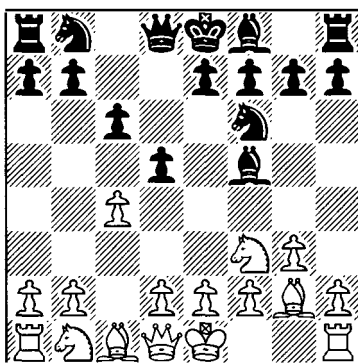


Diagram 1
New York System

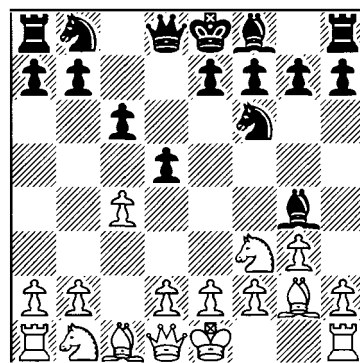


Diagram 2
Capablanca's System

Theoretical?

Compared to the sharp main lines of the Slav this is a very quiet system for Black. The crux of the matter concerns Qb3 from White, lines which need to be looked at before you play a competitive game.

An Important Word on White's Move Order

In practice, most of the games in these lines begin with the Réti move order **1 Nf3 Nf6 2 g3 d5 3 Bg2 c6 4 0-0 (Diagram 3)** and now **4...Bf5** or **4...Bg4**. There are two things to notice about this sequence compared to one beginning **1 c4 c6 2 Nf3 d5**.

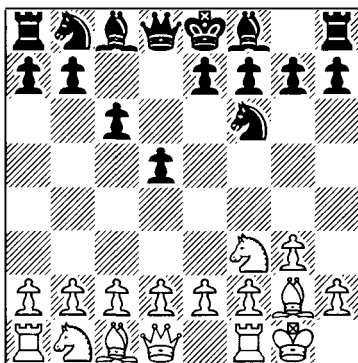


Diagram 3
A non-English position

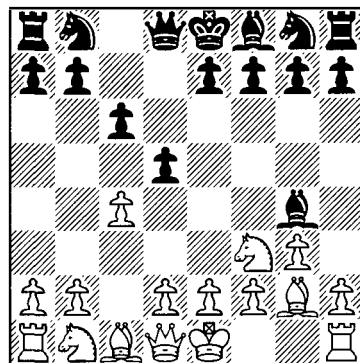


Diagram 4
Black refuses to cooperate

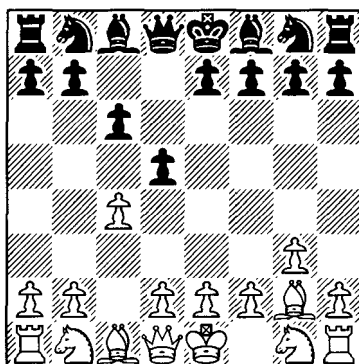
First, in the **1 Nf3** move order White has the option of giving up on **c2-c4** altogether and instead basing his strategy on the preparation of **e2-e4**. This is especially attractive against **4...Bf5** as it gains a tempo by hitting the bishop. A typical sequence for White would be **d2-d3**, **Nbd2** and **Qe1** followed by **e2-e4**. Discussion of this method is outside the scope of this book (White doesn't even play **c2-c4**!) but it is worth considering if you are planning to begin your games with **1 Nf3**.

The second point is much more relevant to the chapter here. In contrast to **1 Nf3 Nf6**, after **1 c4 c6 2 Nf3 d5** Black hasn't committed his knight to **f6** immediately. This becomes important in the Capablanca System after **1 c4 c6 2 Nf3 d5 3 g3 Bg4 4 Bg2 (Diagram 4)**:

Black can play **4...Nd7!**, cutting out the variation **4...Nf6 5 Ne5 Bh5 6 cxd5 cxd5**.

Consequently I suggest that White should also be crafty with his move order and open with **1 c4 c6 2 g3! d5 3 Bg2 (Diagram 5)**, waiting for Black to commit his knight to **f6**.

Now **3...Bg4?** is simply bad after **4 cxd5 cxd5 5 Qb3**, hitting **b7** and **d5**, while the risky **3...dxc4** is analysed below. Therefore Black has nothing better than **3...Nf6**, when **4 Nf3** follows and we are back in familiar territory after **4...Bf5** or **4...Bg4**, having persuaded Black to play **...Nf6**. I have incorporated this move order into the illustrative games that follow.

**Diagram 5**

It makes sense to delay Nf3

The New York System

The New York System, in which Black plays ...Bf5, was so named because it was used by Emanuel Lasker as a counter to Réti's newly invented hypermodern opening at the 1924 New York tournament (for the same reason it is sometimes known as Lasker's System). It is no surprise that Lasker, who had a classical attitude towards the openings, should bring out his bishop and station it on a square where it guards an important centre point.

White's Pressure on b7

Whilst it is possible to meet the New York System with a purely positional approach involving b2-b3 and Bb2, here we'll concentrate on lines in which White makes an immediate attempt to exploit the fundamental drawback of moving the light-squared bishop out of the pawn chain: namely the weakness left on the b7-square. It is self-evident that an undefended square or pawn is only a weakness if it can be attacked, and the best way to do it is with Qb3. Of course, once White has played b2-b3 there is no turning back to this plan as White can no longer put his queen on this square.

Let's see how the pressure on b7 works out in practice:

1 c4 c6 2 Nf3 d5 3 g3 Nf6 4 Bg2 Bf5 5 0-0

White can also try to exploit the weakness of b7 with 5 cxd5 cxd5 6 Qb3 (**Diagram 6**).

Now Black has to be careful as to which square he chooses for his queen. After 6...Qc7 7 Nc3 she could become vulnerable to attack after a subsequent d2-d3 and Bf4. In the event of 6...Qd7 7 Ne5! Qc7 8 Nc3 Qxe5 9 Qxb7 the rook is doomed, while 8...e6 9 Nb5! is very awkward, as this time 9...Qxe5 10 f4 pockets the queen! Instead in V.Loginov-

Z.Almasi, Budapest 1991 Black made do with 8...Nc6 but was left with a nasty weakness on c6 after 9 Nxc6 bxc6 10 0-0.

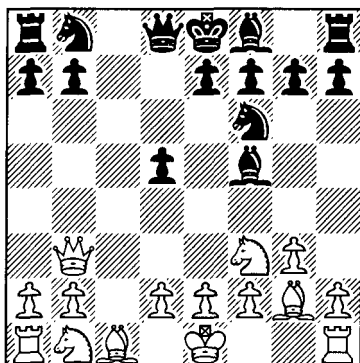


Diagram 6
Immediate attack on b7

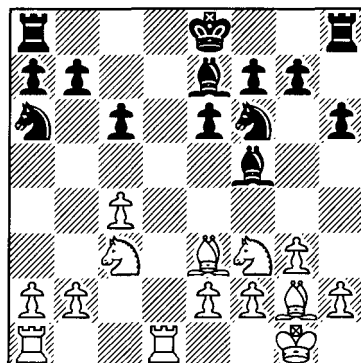


Diagram 7
A weak point on c6

So the safest for Black is 6...Qc8! 7 Nc3 e6 8 0-0 Be7 9 d3 Nc6 10 Bf4 0-0 11 Rac1, when White only has slight pressure on the queenside.

5...h6

Black immediately clears the h7-square for his bishop. This is a useful precaution against White playing Nh4 at a favourable moment and exchanging knight for bishop. Although the position is quite blocked the bishop pair would become valuable once lines open up. Instead 5...e6 is more straightforward, when White can try out the same plan recommended below: 6 d3 Be7 7 Be3!? and 7...dxc4 8 dxc4 Qxd1 9 Rxd1 led to a speedy collapse in V.Loginov-Zetthofer, Oberwart 1996 because Black forgot about the pressure on his queenside – 9...Na6?! (9...Nbd7) 10 Nc3 h6? (**Diagram 7**) (The correct defence was 10...Ng4 11 Bd2 Bc5 12 Be1, when White has been pushed backwards somewhat but maintains his positional plus; in any case the knight would be better on d7 than a6) 11 Nd4! and now Black realised that if he carried on with his plan of 11...Bh7 there comes the combination 12 Nxc6!, winning a sound pawn because 12...bxc6?! 13 Bxc6+ picks up the exchange and two pawns. Black compounded his misery even further with 11...0-0? (11...Rc8! grovels) when, after 12 Nxf5 exf5, White not only acquired the advantage of the bishop pair but also won a pawn as after 13 Bh3 there was no good way to defend f5 (13...g6 14 Bxh6).

6 d3 e6 7 Be3

Rather strange looking but perfectly logical. As noted above, the bishop on f5 has deserted the defence of the queenside, so White wants to attack the b7-pawn. But if he plays 7 Qb3, then 7...Qb6 shields the pawn and offers an unwelcome exchange of queens as 8 Qxb6? axb6 improves Black's pawn structure, with the open a-file for

his rook and a slightly more compact pawn structure. Consequently White first plays 7 Be3, which prevents ...Qb6. Then after 8 Qb3 Black will be obliged to defend his b7-pawn in a more awkward way. Black can pre-empt this plan with 7...dxc4 8 dxc4 Qxd1 9 Rxd1 (Diagram 8).

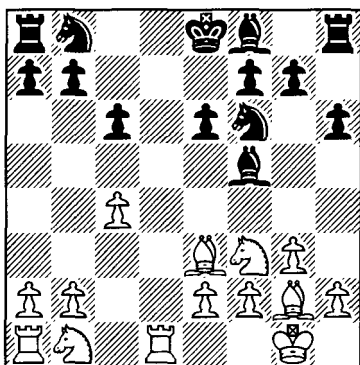


Diagram 8

Black to play and annoy a rook

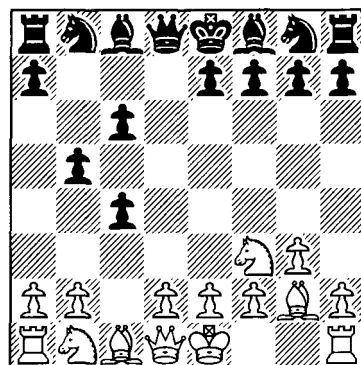


Diagram 9

Black grabs a pawn

Generally speaking the exchange of queens would ease Black's game but, having spent the opening building a solid barrier against the bishop on g2 it is understandable that he doesn't want to start to dismantle it. Still, this would have given Black better chances of equality. 9...Bc2!? forces the rook to a worse square, for example 10 Rdc1 Bh7, when the rook has surrendered control of the d-file, or 10 Rd2 Bh7 and the threat of 11...Ng4 is awkward for White as the bishop on e3 has no retreat.

Black Captures on c4

After 1 c4 c6 2 g3 d5 3 Bg2, at some point before the sixth move Black could try taking on c4 and holding onto the pawn, for example 3...dxc4 4 Nf3 b5 (Diagram 9)

This is a risky plan but it has to be met resolutely:

5 a4 Bb7 6 b3!

It is very important that White is prepared to sacrifice a pawn. As compensation he gains strong pressure against the queenside pawns.

6...cxb3 7 Qxb3 a6 8 Ba3

Now White gained excellent chances in F.Schirm-G.Montavon, Hamburg 1997 after 8...Nf6 9 Nc3 e6 10 Bxf8 Rxf8 11 0-0. Black can't castle, his queenside pawns are vulnerable and White can prepare a pawn breakthrough in the centre.

Another try for Black is 4...Nf6 5 0-0 Na6 6 Na3 Qd5, which attempts to hold onto the pawn without the weakening ...b7-b5. How-

ever, White still gets a useful initiative for the pawn after **7 Re1 Qc5 8 b3! cxb3 9 d4 Qh5 10 Qxb3 e6 11 e4**, as in J.Stocek-A.Filipenko, Pardubice 2000.

If sacrificing a pawn is anathema to you (even when it is strong!) you could defend c4 immediately with 3 b3. However, this would cut out the promising lines based on Qb3.

Game 42

□ Korchnoi ■ Polugaevsky

London 1984

1 c4 c6

As is so often the case, the game actually began as a Réti: 1 Nf3 Nf6 2 g3 d5 3 Bg2 c6 4 0-0 Bf5 5 d3 h6 6 c4 e6.

2 g3 d5 3 Bg2 Nf6 4 Bg2 Bf5 5 0-0 h6 6 d3 e6 7 Be3 Be7?!

As indicated in the discussion above the exchange of queens with 7...dxc4 8 dxc4 Qxd1 9 Rxd1 eases Black's defensive task.

8 Qb3 Qc8

An awkward necessity as big pieces like queens don't like to be reduced to defending pawns.

9 Nc3 0-0 10 Rac1!

In this type of structure Black likes to respond to c4xd5 with ...c6xd5, not only because this clears the way for ...Nc6, putting the knight on a good centre square, but also because it keeps the pawn structure in the centre symmetrical – White has d3/e2 facing d5/e6. By putting his rook on c1 and exerting potential pressure against the black queen White forces Black to recapture ...e6xd5. Then the development of Black's queen's knight becomes problematic, and the pawn structure favours White for reasons outlined in the note to move 14.

10...Bh7 11 cxd5 exd5

Of course not 11...cxd5 12 Nxd5.

12 Ne5!

By preventing the ...c6xd5 recapture White has ruled out ...Nc6. Now he makes the other development 12...Nbd7 unattractive as well in view of the pin 13 Bh3!, when there is already the threat of 14 Nxd7 Nxd7 15 Nxd5, or even immediately 14 Nxd5. Note that if Black had been able to recapture ...c6xd5 there would have been no Bh3 pin available.

12...Bd6 13 Bd4

White consolidates his hold on the central dark squares. After 13...c5? 14 Nxd5 Black again falls apart.

13...Bc7 14 e4! (Diagram 10)

White's pressure on the queenside means that Black can't do anything active with his pawns there: he can only keep them in a solid defensive formation. Therefore White changes the pawn structure so

that he gains a 4-3 pawn majority on the kingside, while Black is 3-2 up on the queenside. White can use this extra pawn to increase his space advantage, whereas Black's extra pawn on the other wing has no positive role.

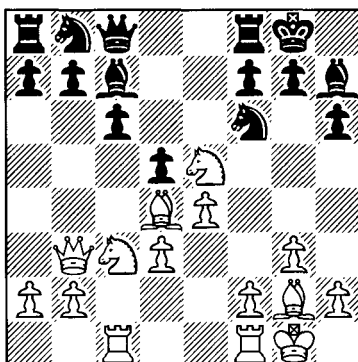


Diagram 10

White uses his pawns

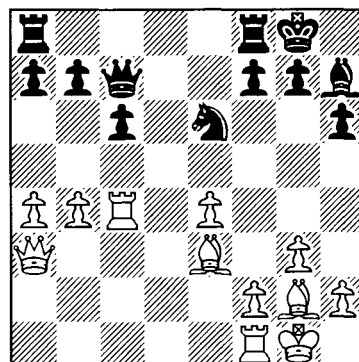


Diagram 11

Three positional advantages

14...dxe4 15 dxe4 Na6 16 Nc4 Nd7 17 a4!

A useful precaution as the 'passive' pawns might have sprung to life with ...b7-b5 followed by ...c6-c5.

17...Nac5 18 Qa3 Ne6 19 Be3 Nb6

Black appears to have escaped the worst as the knight on c4 will be liquidated, but Korchnoi has prepared a powerful blow in the centre.

20 Nd5!

A drastic exploitation of the potential pin on the c-file. Black will be ripped apart after 20...cxd5 21 exd5 Ng5 22 Nxb6 axb6 23 Rfd1, winning back the piece with a crushing game (this is better than 23 d6 Bxd6!). After 20...cxd5 it would be an embarrassing mistake for White to play 21 Nxb6? first as this gives Black the chance to obstruct the c-file after 21...axb6 22 exd5 Nc5! etc.



NOTE: When playing a combination it is important to get the moves in the right order.

20...Nxc4 21 Rxc4 Qd8

Here 21...cxd5 22 exd5 Ng5 23 Rfc1 is also decisive.

22 Nxc7 Qxc7 23 b4 (Diagram11)

White's combination didn't lead to mate or gain of material, but Korchnoi now has three positional advantages on which to build a win:

1. The bishop pair.
2. The possibility of a Minority Attack on the Queenside.

3. The possibility of gaining more space in the centre due to his extra centre pawn.

The combination with 20 Nd5 didn't create all these advantages by itself, but it has clarified the situation and left Black facing a tough defensive task with absolutely no counterplay. The bishop in particular is entirely passive.

23...Qe7 24 Qc3

White prepares b4-b5, when he will open and control the c-file.

24...Rfd8 25 f4

As if Black didn't have enough problems already on the queenside, he now has to defend against 26 f5 and 27 f6, breaking open his king's defences.

25...f6

This meets the threat, but it leaves the knight on e6 no longer securely defended.

26 b5 cxb5 27 axb5 Rd7

Black defends his second rank against a future Rc7 invasion but he ends up dropping a pawn. However, it is clear that he is already strategically lost – not least because he is playing without any help from the bishop.

28 Rc8+ Rxc8 29 Qxc8+ Nf8 30 Qc4+ Qe6 31 Qxe6+ Nxe6 32 Bxa7

White wins a pawn whilst keeping all his positional advantages.

32...Nd4 33 Bh3 Ne2+ 34 Kf2 Rd2 35 Ke3 Rb2 36 Be6+ Kh8 37 Rd1 g5 38 Rd8+ Kg7 39 Bc5 gxf4+ 40 gxf4 Bg6 1-0

The bishop wakes up only when Black decides it is time to resign. It would be murder after 41 Bf8+ Kh7 42 Rd7+ Kh8 43 Bg7+ Kh7 44 Bxf6+.

Capablanca's System

Capablanca's System with ...Bg4 is positionally well motivated. It makes a lot of sense to introduce the idea of ...Bxf3 as White's knight controls the two centre squares that Black's c6/d5/e6 pawn centre doesn't guard – d4 and e5.

Capa 1: White acts Immediately in the Centre

1 c4 c6 2 g3 d5 3 Bg2 Nf6 4 Nf3 Bg4 5 Ne5

The most aggressive and, in my opinion, the best move. If instead 5 cxd5, intending 5...cxd5 6 Ne5, Black has the intermediate 5...Bxf3!?, cutting across White's plan.

After 5 0-0 e6 6 d3 Be7 7 Be3, the course recommended against the New York System, Black can use the fact that he has the bishop on g4 to gain a bind on the dark squares with 7...Bxf3! 8 Bxf3 d4 9 Bd2 a5!, preventing b2-b4. I think Black is then very comfortable.

5...Bh5 6 cxd5 cxd5 (Diagram 12)

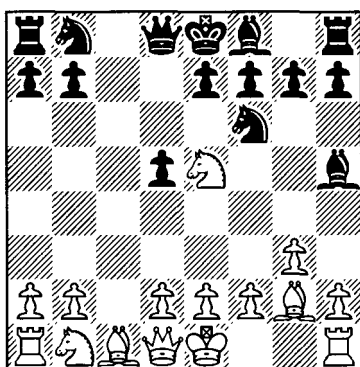


Diagram 12

White has a strong check

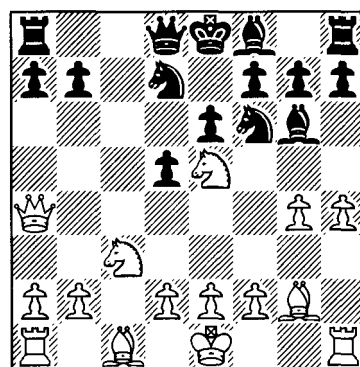


Diagram 13

The bishop on g6 is under siege

7 Qa4+! Nbd7 8 Nc3 e6 9 g4 Bg6 10 h4! (Diagram 13)

This is highly awkward for Black as 11 h5 is threatened and after 10...h6 White can damage the pawn structure with 11 Nxg6. In the event of 10...Bd6 White maintains the pressure with 11 d4, while 10...a6 allows White to go bishop hunting: 11 Nxd7 Qxd7 12 Qxd7+ Nxd7 13 h5 Bc2 14 d3 (the noose tightens around the bishop) 14...d4 (Black is compelled to open the diagonal in order to save his bishop – a sure sign that his strategy has gone wrong) 15 Kd2!? (better than letting the bishop slip out after 15 Ne4 Ba4) and no matter how Black plays White acquires the bishop pair whilst maintaining an attack on b7. In our illustrative game Black tried to escape from his troubles with a little trick.

Game 43

□ V.Loginov ■ Shaposhnikov

St Petersburg 2000

1 c4 c6 2 g3 d5 3 Bg2 Nf6 4 Nf3 Bg4 5 Ne5 Bh5 6 cxd5 cxd5 7 Qa4+ Nbd7 8 Nc3 e6 9 g4 Bg6 10 h4 Bc2

Now 11 Qxc2 Nxe5 allows Black to emerge unharmed, but White had his own surprise waiting...

11 Nxf7! (Diagram 14)

A so called desperado move. The knight will be lost anyway so White parts with it as expensively as possible by destroying the base of Black's kingside pawn structure.

TIP: In any exchanging sequence, always look out for desperado moves.

11...Kxf7



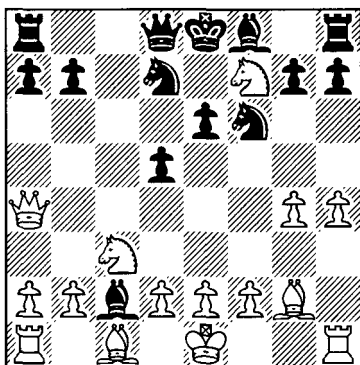


Diagram 14
Desperado!

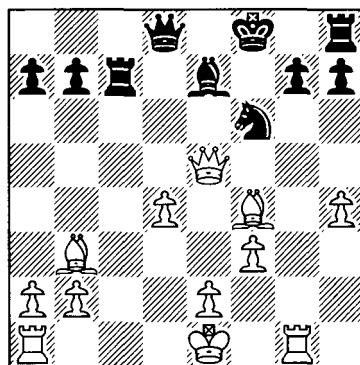


Diagram 15
White wastes no time

11...Bxa4 12 Nxd8 Kxd8 13 Nxa4 Nxd4 14 Bh3, intending f2-f3 if necessary, is ruinous for Black.

12 Qxc2 Nxd4

Now things don't seem so bad for Black. He is poised to develop an initiative with ...Bd6 and ...Qf6, hitting the f2-square. Meanwhile White's bishop on c1 is still asleep and his rooks are inactive. However, the weakness of Black's pawn structure is more significant than these considerations and allows a spectacular combination.

13 Nxd5!! exd5 14 Bxd5+ Ke8

14...Kf6 15 Qe4 Nge5 16 d4 Bb4+ 17 Kf1, when the quickest of many white wins are 17...Nf7 18 Qe6 mate and 17...Re8 18 Bg5 mate.

15 Qe4+ Nde5

Also hopeless is 15...Nge5 16 d4.

16 f3

White regains his piece with two extra pawns and a huge attack against the exposed king.

16...Nf6 17 Qxe5+ Be7 18 Bb3 Rc8 19 d4 Kf8 20 Rg1 Rc7 21 Bf4! (Diagram 15)

White prepares to return one of his extra pawns to clear the way for the final attack.

21...Rd7 22 Qe6 Bb4+ 23 Kf1



NOTE: In the English Opening the centre pawns often provide the white king with a shelter that is as good as a castled position.

23...Re7 24 Qf5 Qxd4 25 Rd1 Qb6 26 Qc8+ Re8 27 Qc4 Re7 28 a3 Bc5 29 Rg5 1-0

The black bishop has run out of squares and 29...Nd7 simply meets with 30 Ba4.

Capa 2: A Classical Approach with b2-b3

The above line is convincing for White, but it may be that you intend to play 1 Nf3, for example because you want to control e5 and so rule out the Four Knights, which occurs after 1 c4 e5. In that case if Black plays Capablanca's System you might be able to profit by holding back the advance c2-c4 until the last moment.

1 Nf3 Nf6 2 g3 d5 3 Bg2 c6 4 0-0 Bg4 5 b3 Nbd7 6 Bb2 e6 7 d3 Be7 (Diagram 16)

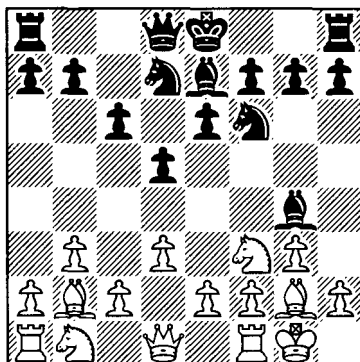


Diagram 16

White wisely delays c2-c4

A more active deployment of the bishop is 7...Bd6, where it guards the important e5-square and might support an advance ...e6-e5 in the future. However, White can respond 8 e4!, when 8...dxe4 9 dxe4 uncovers an attack on the bishop. Then 9...Nxe4 10 Bxg7 Rg8 11 Bb2 (there may be sharper moves for White) has disrupted Black's development by ruling out castling. This seems to indicate that White has adopted a shrewd move order in keeping open both options, c2-c4 and e2-e4, as it has persuaded Black to choose an inferior square for his bishop.

8 Nbd2 0-0 9 h3

A useful little move. White is planning Nh4 and a future Nf5 so he forces the bishop to give up its defence of f5. If White had delayed this move until after Black had organised ...e6-e5 the bishop would have the extra option of retreating to the vacated e6-square.

9...Bh5 10 c4

A typical scenario has arisen. White has fianchettoed both bishops, while Black has claimed an equal share of the centre.

Game 44

□ Kosten ■ I. Farago

Hyerres 1992

1 Nf3 Nf6 2 g3 d5 3 Bg2 c6 4 0-0 Bg4 5 b3 Nbd7 6 Bb2 e6 7 d3

Be7 8 Nbd2 0-0 9 h3 Bh5 10 c4 a5

Besides restraining the white queenside in a general way this also contains the positional threat of 11...a4!, when 12 bxa4 Nc5 easily regains the pawn while wrecking White's queenside, or, otherwise, the pawn can advance further with ...a4-a3!? when it would become strong in an endgame.

11 a3!

White therefore puts a stop to the idea, for now 11...a4 12 b4 keeps his queenside pawns intact.

11...Bd6

Farago 'corrects' his seventh move.

12 Qc2 e5!

Black's whole deployment has been geared up for this space gaining advance in the centre.

13 e4

This is necessary or else White's centre is likely to be encroached upon at some point with ...e5-e4.

13...d4 14 Nh4 Ne8! (Diagram 17)

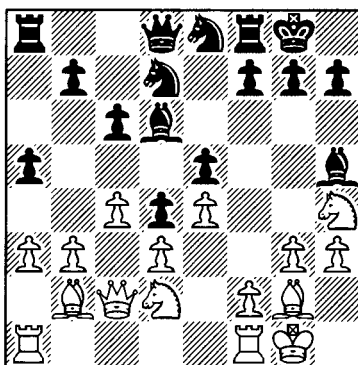


Diagram 17
Heading for e6

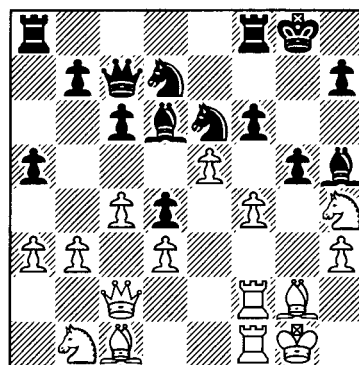


Diagram 18
A thematic advance

An admirable manoeuvre. White is obviously planning f2-f4 so Farago transfers his knight to e6 and clears the way for ...f7-f6 to solidify the e5-square.

15 Nf5 Bc5 16 f4 f6 17 Rf2 Nc7 18 Raf1 Ne6 19 Bc1 Qc7 20 Nh4

A strange retreat that is at odds with White's play on the f-file. Perhaps White was hoping to gain space with f4-f5 and g3-g4 but missed the strength of Black's reply. More natural was 20 Bf3 followed by Bg4 if Black retreats.

20...exf4 21 gxf4 Bd6!

The attack on f4 intensifies. The fact that White has to decentralise his other knight to keep the pawn guarded shows that his strategy has gone awry.

22 Nb1 g5!

Finally Black believes all his preparations are complete and makes his bid to seize the dark squares.

23 e5! (Diagram 18)

An excellent counter. Instead 23 fxe5? Bg3 loses material, while 23 f5? would amount to positional suicide: after 23...Nf4 Black has an iron grip on e5 and f4. With the text Kosten denies an enemy knight the e5-square and obstructs Black's dark-squared bishop. He hopes the e5-square will become a 'dead point' in the centre – a white knight placed in front of it on e4 would be on a wonderful square.

23...fxe5 24 fxg5 Nf4!

Black gives his opponent no time to play Nd2 and Ne4 in peace. Instead White is obliged to exchange on f4 when the e5-square once again becomes available for the black pieces.

25 Bxf4 exf4 26 Nd2!

White decides that he has to seek dynamic play even at the cost of a pawn or else Black's presence in the centre with ...Ne5 and so on will prove decisive.

26...Bxa3 27 Ne4 Kh8 28 Bf3 Be8 29 Bg4 Ne5 30 Rxf4 Rxf4 31 Rxf4 Nxg4

Not 31...Nxd3? 32 Qxd3 Qxf4 33 Qxd4+ Kg8 34 Nf6+ and wins.

32 Rxg4 Bh5 33 Rg2 Qf4 34 Qf2 Qxf2+ 35 Rxf2 Bc1

Black has the two bishops and a queenside pawn structure that can easily manufacture a passed pawn with ...b7-b5 and ...a5-a4 but, even in the endgame, the open position of the black king affords White plenty of counterplay.

36 Kf1 b5 37 cxb5 cxb5 38 Rc2! Be3 39 Rc7 Rf8+

Not 39...a4 40 Nf6 Bg6 41 Nxg6+ hxg6 42 Rh7 mate.

TIP: A rook on the seventh rank can cause havoc.

40 Nf6 Bf7 41 Nf3 Bf4 42 Rb7 Bg6 43 Ke2 Bxg5 44 Nxg5 Rxf6 45 Rxb5 Rc6 46 Rxa5 Rc2+ 47 Kf3 Rc3 48 Kf4

Here a draw was agreed as all the pawns are vanishing.

An Interesting Anti-Slav Method

1 c4 c6 2 Nf3 d5 3 e3!?

This idea has been used with great success by former USSR Champion Mikhail Gurevich. Black is prevented from playing in the style of the New York or Capablanca Systems as both 3...Bg4?! 4 cxd5 cxd5 (4...Bxf3! bails out but surrenders the bishop pair) 5 Qa4+ Bd7 (forced) 6 Qb3 and 3...Bf5? 4 cxd5 cxd5 5 Qb3 would be unpleasant for



him. Of course White is deprived of g2-g3, but Gurevich wants to push the pawn not one square, but two!

3...Nf6 4 Qc2 (Diagram 19)

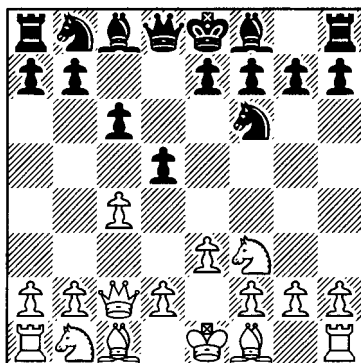


Diagram 19

White's queen has big plans

White has once again ruled out ...Bf5 and ...Bg4 (4...Bg4 5 Ne5 is awkward for Black). The queen move also contains considerable venomous intent: White prepares to castle queenside and attack h7 with Bd3 once Black has castled kingside.

4...e6 5 b3 Be7?

If Black had guessed his opponent's intentions he would have played 5...Bd6 6 Bb2 0-0, when he would have counterplay in the centre with ...Nbd7 and ...e6-e5 if White had continued with a wing attack as in the game. Alternatively 5...Nbd7 6 Bb2 Bd6 allows 7 g4, though even that amounts to a better version of things for Black after 7...0-0.

6 Bb2 0-0 7 Rg1!

A remarkable move. White wants to attack with g2-g4 but after 7 g4 Black might have been able to take the pawn. Once again the solidity of the English set-up is no barrier against dynamic play – on the contrary it promotes it by allowing tactical operations to begin from a solid base. If White had rushed his centre pawns forward he wouldn't have been able to allow himself this liberty.

7...Nbd7 8 g4

This plan of attack is worth a comparison with Krasenkow's method against Macieja in Chapter Two.

Game 45

□ M.Gurevich ■ Wegerle

Pardubice 2000

1 c4 c6 2 Nf3 d5 3 e3 Nf6 4 Qc2 e6 5 b3 Be7 6 Bb2 0-0 7 Rg1!
(Diagram 20)

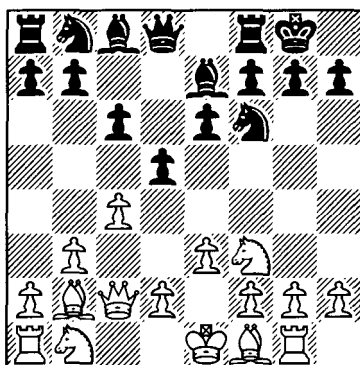


Diagram 20

Preparing a bayonet attack

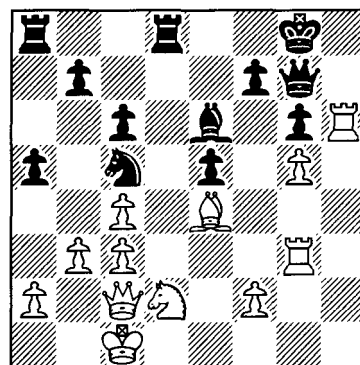


Diagram 21

The focus is on g6

7...Nbd7 8 g4 Ne4

Black tries to organise counterplay in the centre but it proves terribly slow. By the time he gets in ...e6-e5 White already has an open h-file.

9 Nc3 Nxc3 10 Bxc3 Re8 11 Bd3 g6 12 h4!

Easy chess: White's attack rolls inexorably forwards.

12...Bf6 13 h5 Bxc3 14 dxc3 Qf6 15 Rg3 Nc5 16 hxc6 hxc6 17 g5!

White gains a grip on the dark squares on Black's kingside. Now he has a potential base for a knight on f6 and a rook on h6.

17...Qg7 18 0-0-0 e5 19 e4!

White's centre holds firm against the attempt to break it down, which means Black has no answer to the coming offensive on the h-file.

19...dxe4 20 Bxe4 a5 21 Nd2 Be6 22 Rh1 Red8 23 Rh6 (Diagram 21)

Now there is no good answer to the threat of 24 Bxg6, for if 23...Nxe4 24 Nxe4 and the knight will come to f6 with a deadly check.



TIP: When you are dominant on squares of one colour, look for a winning breakthrough on a square of the other colour. Here, for example, White controls the dark squares f6 and h6, but it is a light square – g6 – which crumbles in the final phase of the game.

23...f5 24 gxf6 Qxh6 25 Rxc6+ Qxc6 26 Bxc6 Bf7 27 Nf3 e4 28 Bxe4 Rd6 29 Ng5 Rxf6 30 Qd2 Nxe4 31 Nxe4 Re6 32 Qg5+ Bg6 33 Nc5 Rd6 34 Nxb7 Re6 35 Nd8 Rd6 36 Nxc6!

A nice little joke to end with (36...Rxc6 37 Qd5+).

36...Re8 37 Ne5 Kg7 38 c5 Rde6 39 f4 1-0

The Queen's Gambit Treatment: 1...e6

This is an unpretentious approach. Black plans to create a solid cen-

tre and avoid the problems created on b7 in the examples above by leaving the bishop on c8.

Theoretical?

Not much, but that doesn't stop it containing dangers for Black if he is content to put his pieces on 'natural' squares rather than make the effort to find a decent plan.

1 c4 e6 2 Nf3 d5 3 b3

The good thing about defending c4 straightaway is that it cuts out lines with 3...dxc4.

3...Nf6 4 g3 Be7 5 Bg2 0-0 6 0-0 c5 7 e3 b6

Black hopes that by developing the queen's bishop on b7 he will have solved his eternal dilemma in the Queen's Gambit of how to get the bishop to a decent square without weakening his pawn structure in doing so. If this were the Queen's Gambit White would have looked to punish Black for playing ...b7-b6 as quickly as possible by putting pressure on the c-file or against the d5-pawn, but players of the English Opening like to prepare such things in a slower and more restrained way.

8 Bb2 Bb7 9 Nc3 (Diagram 22)

TIP: Note that this line also works as a way to avoid the Hedgehog. Consider, for example, the move order 1 c4 Nf6 2 Nf3 e6 3 g3 b6 4 Bg2 Bb7 5 0-0 c5 6 Nc3 Be7 7 b3 0-0 8 e3 d5 9 Bb2. White has resolutely avoided playing d2-d4 and therefore has avoided the Hedgehog.

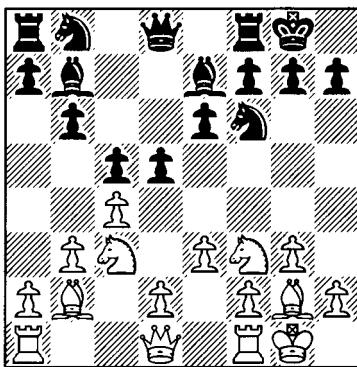


Diagram 22

A stand-off in the centre

Now **9...Nbd7** looks the most accurate. This leaves the bishop on b7 unobstructed, which not only means that the d5-point is more secure but also that Black can prepare the manoeuvre ...Bc6, ...Qc7 and

..Ob7, when he exerts considerable counter-pressure down the long diagonal. This should work well if White plays quietly with 10 d3, for example 10...Qc7 11 Qe2 Bc6 12 Rfd1 Qb7 and Black is well placed to defend his territory in the centre. Instead White can cause Black more problems by going for immediate action in the centre with **10 Qe2** followed by Rfd1, Rac1 and d2-d4. However, Black remains solid and besides the 10...Qc7 plan he could also try 10...Ne4!? to ease the tension.

Game 46

□ McDonald ■ Nicholson

London 1986

1 c4 e6 2 Nf3 d5 3 b3 Nf6 4 g3 Be7 5 Bg2 0-0 6 0-0 c5 7 e3 b6 8 Bb2 Bb7 9 Nc3 Nc6

A natural move, but as indicated above 9...Nbd7! was more precise.

10 Qe2 Qc7 11 d3 dxc4 12 bxc4 a6 13 Ne1

White's set-up looks harmless, but I achieved good success with it in my days of playing the Réti. If Black is careless he can suddenly find himself in big trouble.

The plan is to attack e6 with f2-f4-f5. The positional rationale is that Black has weakened the e6-square by moving his bishop away from its defence with ...Bb7.

13...Na7 14 a4! (Diagram 23)

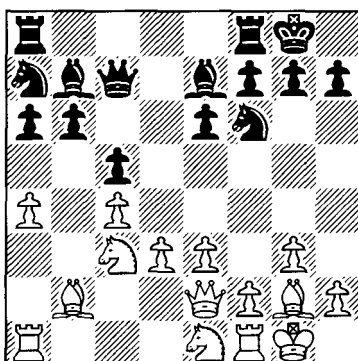


Diagram 23
Circumspect play

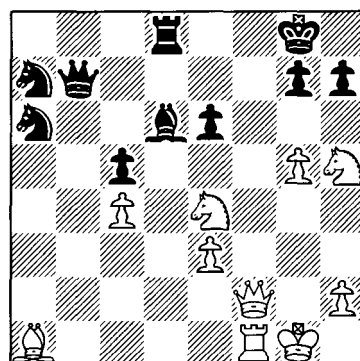


Diagram 24
White closes in

White takes time out to restrain Black's counterplay on the queenside before embarking on a kingside attack. Not only does this move make Black spend more time on preparing ...b6-b5 but it also leads to the a-file falling into White's hands.

14...Bxg2?

An obvious move but it falls in with White's plan as after the recap-

ture the knight will be well placed on g2 to join the kingside attack. Here 14...Bc6 was a better idea when, if White plays 15 Bxc6 (to clear the g2-square for his knight), then 15...Qxc6 16 Ng2 b5 is possible. In that case Black has achieved his counterplay with gain of time and without having to surrender the a-file.

15 Nxb5 Rab8 16 f4 b5 17 axb5 axb5 18 f5 bxc4 19 dxc4

Black is in a difficult position as he has a weak pawn on e6 which can be further attacked with Nf4. The pawn is performing a vital task on e6 which it cannot abandon as both 19...exf5 or 19...e5 leave a nasty hole on the important d5-square. In the event of 19...Nc6 White has 20 Nb5 or 20 Nf4, leaving Black facing mounting pressure. Therefore Black tries to counterattack down the b-file, but meets with little success.

19...Rb6 20 Ra2

White anticipates the attack on his bishop, preparing a safe retreat.

20...Qb8 21 Nf4 Rd8 22 Ba1

This continues the 'safety first' approach and also clears the second rank for the rook to swing over to the kingside if required.

22...Qb7 23 g4!

Now at last White feels all his preparations are complete and it is time for a direct pawn storm.

23...Bf8?

This loses without a fight. Black had to play either 23...Nc8 or 23...Rd7 so that 24 g5 can be answered by 24...Ne4. In that case Black would still face a strong attack, e.g. 23...Nc8 24 g5 Ne4 25 g6!, breaking down the defence of the e6-pawn.

24 g5 Ne8

24...Ne4 25 Nxe4 Qxe4 26 Rxa7 drops a piece.

25 fxe6 fxe6 26 Qf2!

With the terrible threat of 27 Nxe6.

26...Nc7

There wasn't much choice, for 26...Be7 27 Nxe6, intending 28 Qf7+, is decisive, or equally 26...Qf7 27 Rxa7! Qxa7 28 Nxe6 Be7 29 Qf8+! mates.

27 Nh5!

Now Black is obliged to move the knight from d7 to a wretched square (a6 or a8) in order to prevent the deadly check on f7.

27...Na6 28 Rd2! Rbd6

I was flattered that GM Ribli wrote some comments to this game in *British Chess Magazine*, but his suggestion of 28...Rxd2 here to ease the pressure wasn't one of his finer moments as it allows mate in one!

29 Rxd6 Bxd6 30 Ne4! (Diagram 24)

Finally the bishop on a1 is unleashed. If Black takes the knight it is

mate in two.

30...Bf8 31 Nhf6+! gxf6

31...Kh8 32 Ne8 and White wins at least a piece.

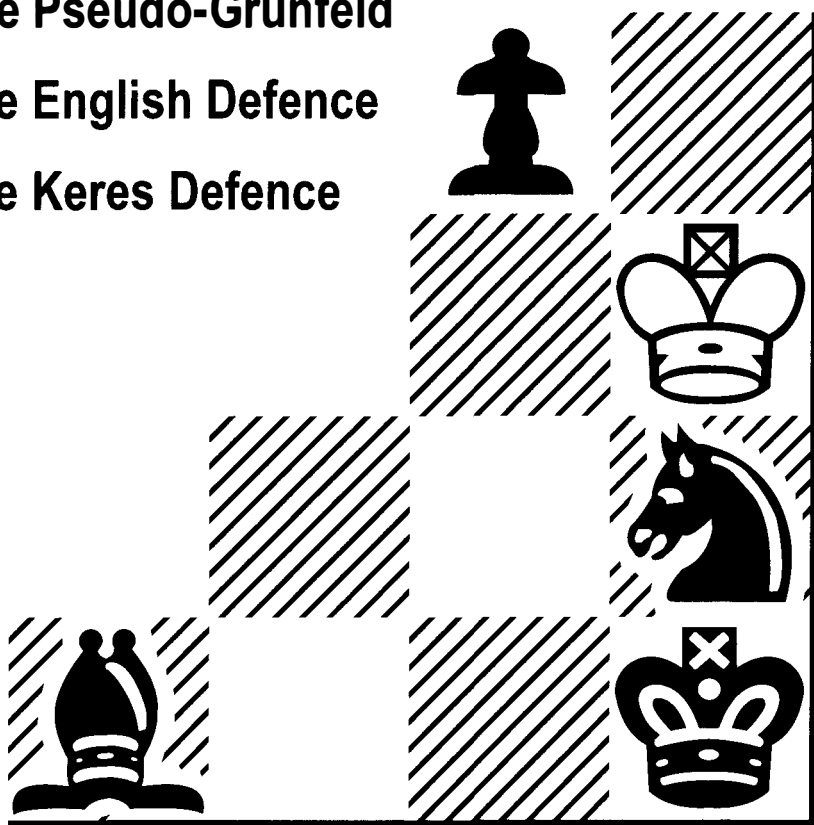
32 Qxf6 1-0

The double threat to the rook and h8 is decisive.

Chapter Nine

Other Variations

- Introduction
- Black Plays the Dutch
- 1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 d6
- The Pseudo-Grünfeld
- The English Defence
- The Keres Defence



Introduction

This chapter considers a wide variety of defences for Black – English Defence, anti-Stonewall, Pseudo Grünfeld, Keres and 1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 d6 (or 2...Bb4).

Theoretical?

All of these defences can lead to sharp play because they provoke White into seizing space in the centre. There aren't many long tactical lines to learn, but there are pitfalls to be avoided.



WARNING: Don't regard these defences as junk just because they don't have their own chapter: Grünfeld and Dutch players often adopt them, while the English Defence is becoming very popular.

Black Plays the Dutch

1 c4 f5 (Diagram 1)

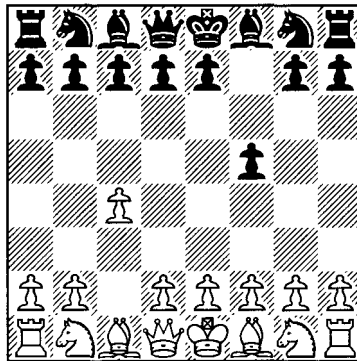


Diagram 1
Mixed fortunes for the Dutch

Strategies

If Black plays in the style of the Leningrad Dutch with a kingside fianchetto then play could easily transpose to the Botvinnik System: 1 c4 f5 2 g3 Nf6 3 Bg2 g6 4 Nc3 Bg7 5 d3 0-0 6 e4 and here, in Chapter Seven, rather than setting up a pawn centre with ...d7-d6 and ...e7-e5, I recommend 6...fxe4 7 dxe4 d6 8 Nge2 c5 9 0-0 Nc6 as a more promising approach for Black. Alternatively White could try 2 b3 to make the fianchetto on g7 less appetising for Black: 2 b3 g6 3 Bb2 Nf6 4 Bxf6 exf6 5 g3. In return for the loosening of his kingside Black has the bishop pair but there isn't much for his dark-squared bishop to at-

tack. Therefore Black should prefer something like 2...e5, when 3 Bb2 Nc6 4 Nc3 Nf6 5 e3 g6 6 Nge2 Bg7 7 d4 exd4 8 Nxd4 Nxd4 9 Qxd4 0-0 is fairly equal.

So far the Dutch is looking good, but the Stonewall Variation fares badly against the English, as we can see in the following game.

Game 47

□ Avrukh ■ Shachar

Tel Aviv 2002

1 c4 f5 2 Nf3 e6 3 g3 Nf6 4 Bg2 d5

It was better to develop more modestly with 4...Be7 and 5...d6, when if White ventures d2-d4 we have the fluid centre version of the Dutch. Of course this wouldn't make a Stonewall devotee very happy.

5 0-0 c6 6 d3!

Exactly. White has avoided d2-d4 so that he has the flexibility to attack the Stonewall with d2-d3 and e2-e4.

6...Bc5

After 6...Bd6 7 Nc3 0-0 8 e4! the bishop is a target for a fork on e5, and 8...fxe4 9 dxe4 dxe4 10 Ng5 sees White regain the pawn with advantage. However, as will be seen the bishop on c5 is also vulnerable, so 6...Be7 looks best.

7 Qc2!

White's move order has been effective. Here the fact that he has delayed Nc3 allows him to terrorise the bishop with the threat of 7 cxd5.

7...Nbd7

The knight defends the bishop but cuts off the defence of f5 by the bishop on c8. You might be wondering why on earth I am mentioning this, but after...

8 cxd5! (Diagram 2)

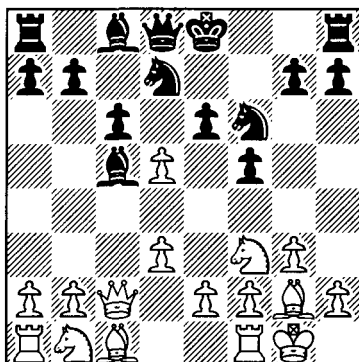


Diagram 2

A well-timed capture

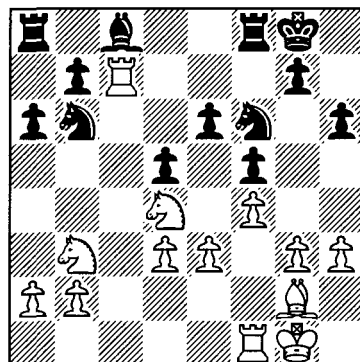


Diagram 3

White secures d4 and e5

Black would like to keep a barrier on c6 by recapturing 8...exd5. However, 9 d4 is then a double attack on c5 and f5.

8...cxd5 9 Bf4!

White immediately begins to exploit the open c-file.

9...0-0 10 Nbd2!

The knight heads for b3 to force the bishop out of the way.

10...Qb6 11 Rac1 Ng4

Black tries for counterplay but it can only work if White is careless as the bishop on c8 is doing nothing.

12 e3 h6

Black's centre disintegrates after 12...e5 13 Nxe5! Ngxe5 14 Bxe5 Nxe5 15 Qxc5 Qxc5 16 Rxc5 Nxd3 17 Bxd5+ Kh8 18 Rc7.

13 Nb3 Bd6 14 Bxd6 Qxd6 15 Nfd4!

The knight finds an excellent centre post from where it cannot be driven because 15...e5 loses the d5-pawn after 16 Nb5 (16...Qe6? 17 Nc7).

15...a6 16 Qc7!

Now the c-file will be firmly in White's hands.

16...Qxc7 17 Rxc7 Nb6 18 h3

Not played necessarily to drive back the knight: White is looking ahead to a kingside advance with g3-g4.

18...Nf6 19 f4! (Diagram 3)

White affirms his grip on d4 and creates another outpost for a knight on e5.

19...Rf7 20 Rc2 Re7 21 Nf3!

A notable changing of the guard on d4.

21...Rb8 22 Nbd4 Bd7 23 Ne5 Be8 24 Rfc1

White has achieved a beautiful position: his rooks control the c-file and the knights dominate the centre. The only piece not pulling its weight is the bishop. White corrects this state of affairs by using his pawns to break up Black's kingside and thus facilitate the advance e3-e4.

24...Bf7 25 g4! g6 26 Rc7 Rbe8 27 g5 hxg5 28 fxg5 Nh7 29 h4 Nf8 30 e4! dxe4 31 dxe4 fxe4 32 Bxe4

Now everything is perfect for White. Black can defend b7 only by allowing a rook to reach c8.

32...Nd5 33 Rxe7 Rxe7 34 Rc8 Kg7 35 h5! 1-0

A nice finishing touch to a lovely game. White wins a rook after 35...gxh5 36 Bxd5 exd5 37 Nf5+, while otherwise there is 36 h6+ Kg8 37 h7+ and Black will have to give up the knight on f8.

1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 d6

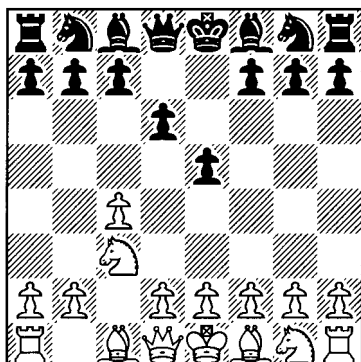


Diagram 4

A variation with no name

Strategies

Black is willing to concede the centre to White as he hopes his pieces will benefit from the open lines.

1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 d6

A similar alternative is 2...Bb4 3 Nd5, when White has a fairly useful pair of bishops after either 3...Be7 4 d4 d6 5 e4 Nf6 6 Nxe7 Qxe7 7 f3 or 3...Ba5 4 b4 c6 (the only move) 5 bxa5 cxd5 6 cxd5 Qxa5 7 e4 etc.

3 d4

Instead 3 Nf3 leads to a completely different type of game. Black can't tolerate White playing 4 d4 and recapturing after 4...exd4 with 5 Nxd4, when the knight is excellently centralised and no time is won by attacking White's queen (as happens after the text). Therefore there usually follows 3...f5 4 d4 e4. Black's centre looks over-stretched but White has to waste time with this knight, and after 5 Ng5 c6! (monitoring d5 and freeing c7 for his knight) 6 g3 Be7 7 Nh3 Nf6 8 Bg2 0-0 9 0-0 Black can play 9...Na6! and ...Nc7 to further support his centre. Meanwhile White can dissolve the e4-pawn with f2-f3. An unclear battle results.

3...exd4 4 Qxd4 Nc6

Black gains time by attacking the queen. Furthermore, he achieves a King's Indian style set-up with all his pieces finding active squares. However, a space advantage always means something and Black might have difficulty in finding a plan – there is no pawn on e5 to suggest that he should generate a kingside attack.

5 Qd2!

This is usually the best square for the queen in this type of centre. The players will scramble to fianchetto bishops on b2 and g7 to contest control of the diagonal opened by the exchange of pawns in the centre. On d2 the queen will support both the knight on c3 and the bishop when it arrives on b2.

5...g6 6 b3 Bg7 7 Bb2 Nf6 8 g3 0-0

Black has a lead in development but as long as the pawn situation remains quiet in the centre he will be unable to exploit it.

9 Bg2 Re8

This is a critical moment in the battle between White's slower but superior piece deployment and Black's temporarily more active pieces. Now White should make do with 10 Nf3! Bf5 11 0-0, completing his development when he can count on a slight edge after, for example, 11...Ne4 12 Nxe4 Bxe4 13 Rfd1.

However, the time consuming 10 Nh3 followed by Nf4 is a strategically desirable manoeuvre as the knight then controls the key d5-square and doesn't obstruct the bishop on g2. Let's see what happened when White tried to play like this against a Grandmaster:

Game 48

□ **Sadler** ■ **McNab**

London 1989

1 d4 d6 2 c4 e5

A common non-English move order.

3 Nc3 exd4 4 Qxd4 Nf6 5 b3 g6 6 Bb2 Bg7 7 g3 0-0 8 Bg2 Nc6 9 Qd2 Re8 10 Nh3?

Evidently Matthew Sadler thought the position was quiet enough to justify this slow plan, but he was in for a surprise!

10...d5!! (Diagram 5)

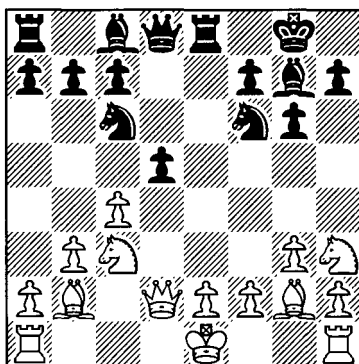


Diagram 5
An energetic thrust

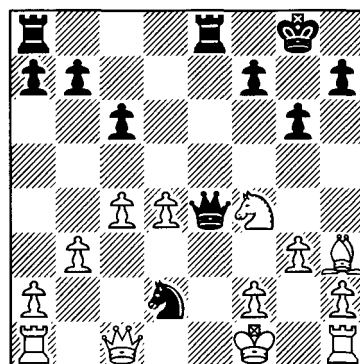


Diagram 6
A fitting finish

An explosive freeing move which occurs just in time before 11 Nf4.

11 Nxd5

After 11 cxd5 Bxh3 12 Bxh3 Nxd5 13 Nxd5 Bxb2 14 Rd1 (14 Qxb2 Qxd5 15 0-0 Qh5 16 Bg2 Rxe2 gives Black a strong initiative) Black can maintain his attack with either 14....Bg7!?, intending ...Nd4, or the immediate 14...Nd4, threatening 15...Qxd5 (15 Ne3 Qf6).

11...Bxh3!

As Black's overall plan requires this move, all objections of a general nature – such as not surrendering a bishop for a knight on the edge of the board – are irrelevant.

12 Bxh3 Ne4 13 Qc1 Nd4!

Black's knights take over the central squares with tremendous threats. After 14 Bxd4 Bxd4 Black's bishop hits both a1 and f2.

14 e3!

Cold-blooded. White realises that he has to challenge the knight and cannot allow e2 to drop, so he willingly gives away the f3-square.

14...c6! 15 Nf4 Nd2!? 16 Bc3! Ne4 17 Bb2 Qa5+ 18 Kf1 Nd2+ 19 Kg2 Qe5 20 Bxd4 Qe4+ 21 Kg1 Nf3+ 22 Kf1 Bxd4 23 exd4 Nd2+ 24 Kg1

Of course if 24 Qxd2 it is mate on h1, so a draw is forced.

24...Nf3+ 25 Kf1 Nd2+ (Diagram 6) $\frac{1}{2}$ - $\frac{1}{2}$

This was a hair raising experience for White, but also a reminder of the durability of his restrained centre in the English: the e3 barrier held firm and allowed him to escape with a draw.

The Pseudo-Grünfeld

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nc3 d5 (Diagram 7)

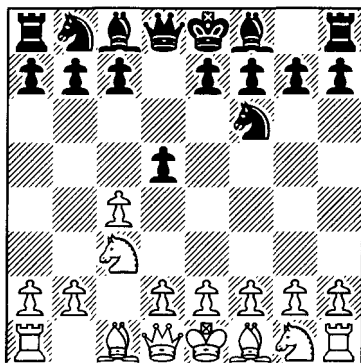


Diagram 7

Black wants a Grünfeld

Strategies

This is an important option for Black as it can lead to positions similar or even identical to those in the Symmetrical English where Black fianchettoes on g7 and then plays ...d7-d5. It is also akin to lines in the Reversed Dragon, but with the black bishop on g7 rather than e7.

Note that 2...g6, intending 3 Nf3 d5, is discussed below after the illustrative game.

3 cxd5

After 3 Qa4+? Bd7 4 Qb3 d4! White is left looking silly as 5 Qxb7?? Bc6 is decisive.

3...Nxd5 4 g3

If White wants to force the knight on d5 to retreat then it is a good idea to delay Nf3 so that he can threaten it directly with Bg2. There are various tries for advantage after 4 Nf3 g6, for example 5 Qa4+ Bd7 6 Qh4 which immediately puts the queen on an active square. Alternatively there is 5 e4 Nxc3 when White should play 6 bxc3 followed by 7 d4, transposing to the Grünfeld Main line, as 6 dxc3 Qxd1+ 7 Kxd1 Nd7 leads only to an equal looking endgame. If you compare this with the Krasenkow-Protaziuk game in Chapter Two you will see that it helps Black that he hasn't played the weakening ...c7-c5: for one thing he can put his bishop on the active c5 after ...e7-e5.

Another approach is 5 h4, an odd looking move that tries to take advantage of the fact that Black has weakened his kingside with ...g7-g6. The best response is perhaps 5...h6! when 6 h5?! g5 leaves Black's kingside secure and the h5-pawn is a liability for White. Instead after 6 e4 Nxc3 7 bxc3 Bg7 8 d4 c5 we have a Grünfeld with the extra moves h2-h4 and ...h7-h6. I guess this isn't very appealing for an English player, who likes to hold his centre pawns back to keep his king covered if he begins a wing attack.

4...g6 5 Bg2 Nb6

5...Nxc3 6 bxc3 Bg7 7 Rb1 gives White useful pressure on b7. Then 7...0-0? 8 Bxb7?? Bxb7 9 Rxb7 Qd5 loses for White but 8 Rxb7! does very nicely and wins a pawn. Instead 7...Nd7 deals with the immediate threat because 8 Bxb7? Bxb7 9 Rxb7 Nb6 traps the rook, but White can maintain the pressure with 8 Nf3 etc.

6 Nf3 Bg7 7 0-0 0-0

Black's knight on b6 is on a worse square than it reaches in the Symmetrical Variation where 1...c5 has cleared the way for the superior ...Nc7. However, having a pawn on c5 is double edged since it contests the d4-square but can become a target, so it isn't clear that Black is dissatisfied with the difference.

8 d3 Nc6 9 Be3 e5

The set-up here is similar to that in the Reversed Dragon after 1 c4 e5 2 Nc3 Nf6 3 Nf3 Nc6 4 g3 d5 5 cxd5 Nxd5 6 Bg2 Nb6 7 0-0 Be7 8 d3 0-0.

In the Grünfeld version the e5-pawn is securely defended by the bishop on g7, so that Black isn't compelled to respond to any attempt to dislodge the knight on c6 with b2-b4-b5 by loosening his kingside structure with ...f7-f6. In fact he can even play ...Nd4, placing his knight in the centre without dropping the e5-pawn. On the other hand the bishop sitting on e7 can fight for the c5-square and help to support a counter involving ...a7-a5 (directed against White's space gaining b2-b4). Let's see how play developed in a Grandmaster game.

Game 49

□ Gelfand ■ Avrukh

Israel 1999

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nc3 d5 3 cxd5 Nxd5 4 g3 g6 5 Bg2 Nb6 6 Nf3 Bg7 7 0-0 0-0 8 d3 Nc6 9 Be3 e5 10 b4! (Diagram 8)

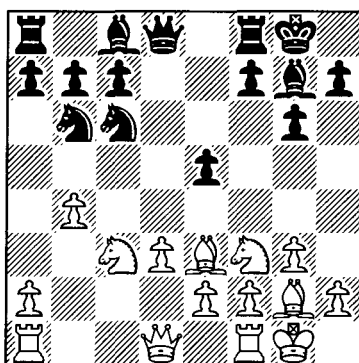


Diagram 8

White wastes no time

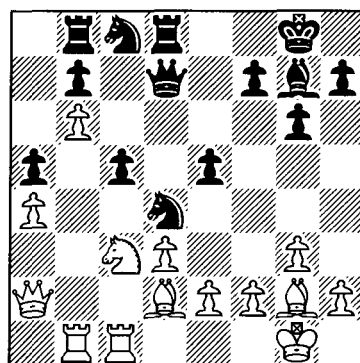


Diagram 9

A disruptive advance

White doesn't feel the need to even prepare this move! If the black bishop were on e7 the pawn would be removed but here neither 10...Nxb4? (losing the exchange after 11 Bc5) or 10...e4? 11 Nxe4 Bxa1 12 Qxa1 (winning the exchange but leaving his dark squares horribly weak) is playable for Black.

10...Nd4 11 a4 Be6

The bishop's foray on b3 fails to disrupt White's queenside play. Simpler was 11...Nxf3+! which eliminates the knight that will cause so many problems in the game. Then after 12 Bxf3 c6 Black is ready to play the recentralising 13...Nd5.

12 Ng5! Bb3

White has a useful bishop pair after 12...Bd5 13 Nxd5 Nxd5 14 Bd2.

13 Qb1

White has to manoeuvre carefully for the next few moves to avoid falling for a fork on e2, c2 or b3 or a tactical blow based on ...e5-e4,

unleashing the dark-squared bishop.

13...a5 14 b5 c6 15 Nge4 Bd5 16 Rc1!

White presses on with his plan as 16...Nb3? can be refuted in several degrees of ferocity, from the simple 17 Bxb6?! Qxb6 18 Nxd5 cxd5 19 Qxb3 dxe4 20 Bxe4, winning a pawn, to the crushing 17 bxc6! bxc6 (or 17...Nxa1 18 Bxb6) 18 Nxd5 and Black loses a piece no matter how he continues.



TIP: If you see a good move, don't play it immediately – look for something better.

16...Rb8 17 Qb2 Qe7 18 Rab1 Bxe4?

Gelfand gives a long tactical variation in Informator 75 to show that Black should have played 18...f5! here: 19 bxc6 bxc6 20 Bxd4 exd4 21 Nxd5 Nxd5! (giving up two rooks for the queen) 22 Qxb8 Rxb8 23 Rxb8+ Bf8 24 Rxc6 fxe4 25 Rcc8 Nc3! 26 Bxe4 Nxe2+ 27 Kg2 Nc3 28 Bc6 Qd6 'with equality'. The point is that after 29 Rxf8+ Qxf8 30 Rxf8+ Kxf8 31 Kf3 White has an extra pawn but Black can force a draw by attacking the bishop that has to defend the a4-pawn (31...Ke7 32 Kf4 Kd6 33 Be8 Ke7 etc.). Seeing such a long and complex variation, with the drawing method of attack on the bishop hidden in an endgame where White appears to be a sound pawn up, is way beyond all but the best Grandmasters, let alone average club players. No doubt Gelfand discovered this variation in post mortem analysis – he was looking for the ultimate truth in the position, not suggesting what he thinks Black should have seen during the game.

19 Bxe4 c5

Black avoids a weakness on c6 but he is soon wishing he had his bishop on e7, defending c5, rather than g7.

20 Bd2 Rfd8 21 Qa2 Qd7?

Black neglects his c5-pawn with fatal consequences. Here 21...Kh8! allows 22 Bg2 to be answered with 22...f5!, guarding the e4-square against the knight.

22 Bg2!

Suddenly there is the threat of 23 Ne4, winning the c5-pawn.

22...Nc8?

The only hope was 22...c4 23 dxc4 Nxe2+ 24 Nxe2 Qxd2, although White has a clear advantage after 25 Rc2 according to Gelfand.

23 b6! (Diagram 9)

It is vital to stop 23...b6, when both a5 and c5 are firmly defended and White's rook is denied the b5-square.

23...Ne7 24 Bg5!

Now White eliminates the chief defender of the d5-square. If 24...f6 were a legal move you can bet Black would have played it!

24...h6 25 Bxe7 Qxe7 26 e3

White continues to take over the centre by evicting the black knight from its centre square: a compliment Black can't return with a white knight on d5.

26...Ne6 27 Nd5 Qd6 28 Rb5 Ra8 29 Nc7!

Now either b7 or c5 will fall. Black chooses the lesser evil but still emerges in a lost endgame.

29....Rab8 30 Nxe6 Qxe6 31 Qxe6 fxe6 32 Be4

It would be ridiculous to describe the pawn on d3 as a weak backward pawn when it has such a defender. Gelfand wins because he has succeeded in marginalising the bishop on g7, which has been a mere spectator, whereas White's bishop is putting unbearable pressure on b7.

32...Bf8 33 Rxa5 Ra8

Black concedes a passed pawn, but if he waited then 34 Ra7 followed by a5-a6 would have led to the same result.

34 Rxa8 Rxa8 35 Bxb7 Rxa4 36 Be4 Rb4 37 b7 Bd6 38 Ra1 Kf7 39 Ra7 Kf6 40 Ra8 g5 41 Rh8 Kg7 42 Rh7+ Kg8 43 Rd7 1-0

The bishop has been crowded out. If it moves 44 Rd8 will win.

Note that if Black wants to play a Grünfeld type centre it is a good idea to play ...d7-d5 as soon as possible as 2...g6 runs the risk that White might play 3 e4!?, when 3...d6 4 d4 is suddenly a King's Indian Main line.

Of course, you probably have no intention of playing like this as White. Here is an example of White enjoying fabulous success by keeping play in English territory.

Game 50

□ Krasenkow ■ V.Mikhalevski

Saint Vincent 2000

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nc3 g6 3 Nf3 d5 (Diagram 10)

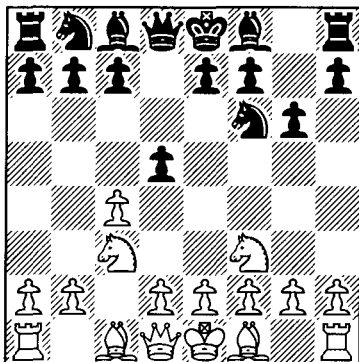


Diagram 10

White has a surprise in store

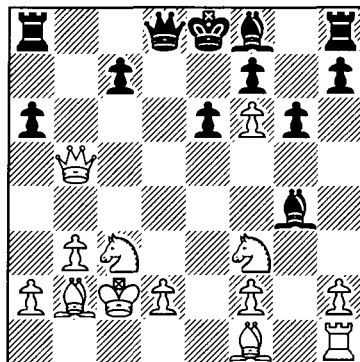


Diagram 11

A nice finish

White can transpose to the main set-up with 4 cxd5 Nxd5 5 g3 etc. However, he has an interesting alternative in mind.

4 Qa4+!? Bd7 5 Qb3

Now both b7 and d5 are hanging.

5...dxc4 6 Qxc4 a6?

Black plans to disrupt White by attacking the queen, but development with 6...Bg7 was necessary.

7 e4 b5 8 Qe2!

The queen finds an unexpected and safe post in the centre.

8...Nc6 9 e5 Nb4?

This leads to disaster but Black was already struggling.

10 exf6 Nc2+ 11 Kd1 Nxa1

Black is now the exchange up, but the knight won't escape alive.

12 b3 Bf5 13 Bb2 Nc2 14 g4! Bxg4 15 Kxc2 e6? 16 Qxb5+! (Diagram 11) 1-0

Black loses even more material after 16...axb5 17 Bxb5+ Qd7 18 Bxd7+ Kxd7 19 Ne5+.

The English Defence

1 c4 b6 (Diagram 12)

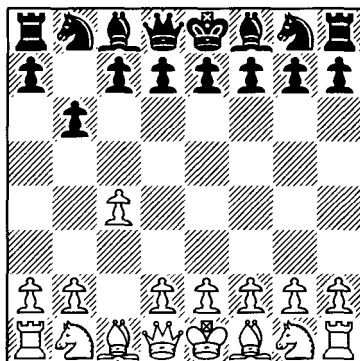


Diagram 12

English Opening versus
English Defence!

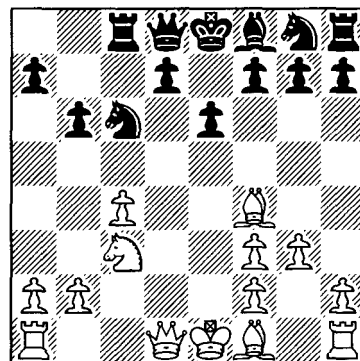


Diagram 13

Initiative versus solidity

Black's first move has become fairly popular these days and is a good choice against a player who likes to play a restrained opening as White. This is because White is compelled to play moves like d2-d4 and e2-e4 if he wants to assert the advantage of the first move – not something that appeals to everyone.

If you are willing to contemplate 2 d4, then 2...e6 3 a3!? (stopping the pin with ...Bb4) 3...Bb7 4 Nc3, preparing to smother out the bishop with 5 d5, is a good way to play it. But here we'll concentrate on English style responses by White.

2 Nf3

Another approach for White is 2 Nc3 Bb7 3 e4!?, for example 3...e6 4 Nf3 Bb4 5 Bd3. White solidifies his control of e4 and plans 0-0, Bc2 and d2-d4. Meanwhile Black intends to attack e4 with ...0-0 and ...f7-f5.

2...Bb7 3 Nc3

After 3 g3 Bxf3! 4 exf3 c5 White has the two bishops but his pawn structure is fractured. An example is 5 d4 Nc6! (gaining a hold on the d4-square) 6 d5 Nd4 7 Be3 Nf5 8 Bd2 g6!, when Black leaves his centre intact and puts his bishop on a strong diagonal. Knott-Summerscale, Millfield 2000 continued 9 Bc3 Bg7 10 Bxg7 Nxg7 11 Bh3 Nh6! (better than the automatic 11...Nf6 – the knight will be excellent on f5 and, beyond that, d4) 12 0-0 Nhf5 and Black had a good position. It is better for White to wait until Black has weakened his centre with the move ...e7-e6 before he allows his pawns to be compromised.

3...e6

After 3...Bxf3?! 4 exf3 White doesn't need to play g2-g3. Instead he can develop with 5 d4 and 6 Bd3 etc.

4 g3 Bxf3!

The critical move – will White's initiative outweigh his loosened pawn structure?

Instead we are back in the territory of the Hedgehog (Chapter Three) after 4...Nf6 5 Bg2 c5.

5 exf3 c5 6 d4!

This is necessary before Black plays 6...Nc6.

6...cxd4 7 Qxd4 Nc6 8 Qd1!

The queen retreats all the way back. On d2 it would obstruct the queen's bishop while on d3 it would get in the way of the king's bishop. If necessary the queen will go to a4 to put pressure on Black's queenside and defend the c4-pawn.

8...Rc8 9 Bf4!? (Diagram 13)

Here the bishop prevents ...Ne5 and doesn't get in the way of pressure on the d-file.

Now let's see how play developed in a recent game:

Game 51

□ D.Fridman ■ G.Mainka

Recklinghausen 2002

1 c4 b6 2 Nc3 Bb7 3 Nf3 e6 4 g3 Bxf3 5 exf3 c5 6 d4 cxd4 7 Qxd4

Nc6 8 Qd1 Rc8 9 Bf4 Bb4

An interesting reply to 9...Na5 is 10 Qa4.

10 Rc1 Nge7 11 a3 Bxc3+ 12 Rxc3 d5!

It looks like Black is completely freeing his game, but White finds a tactical means to keep up the pressure.

13 cxd5 Nxd5 14 Rxc6! (Diagram 14)

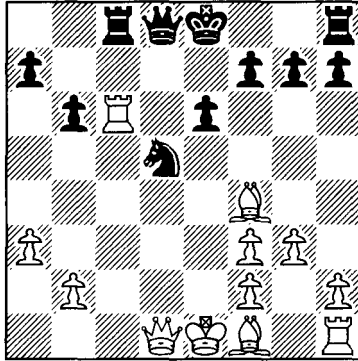


Diagram 14

Uncompromising play

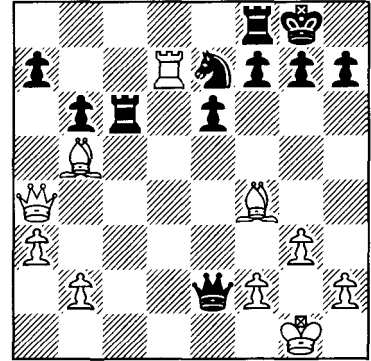


Diagram 15

The tension mounts

14...Rxc6 15 Bb5 Ne7 16 Qa4 Qd5?

After this Black suffers decisive material losses. He had to play 16...Qd7, although White keeps an edge after 17 0-0 0-0 18 Rd1 Qb7 19 Bxc6 Nxc6 20 Qe4! etc.

17 0-0 0-0 18 Rd1! Qxf3 19 Rd3 Qe2 20 Rd7 (Diagram 15)

Now Black is the exchange and a pawn up but he has his queen, rook and knight all hanging.

20...Qe1+ 21 Kg2 Rfc8?

It was necessary to jettison the knight.

22 Bxc6 1-0

Black suffers a back rank disaster after 22...Nxc6 23 Qxc6 Rxc6 24 Rd8 mate.

WARNING: Always look out for back rank tricks.



The Keres Defence

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nc3 e5 3 g3 c6 (Diagram 16)

Black can play the same idea of ...c7-c6 against other white deployments, for example 1 c4 e5 2 g3 Nf6 3 Bg2 c6.

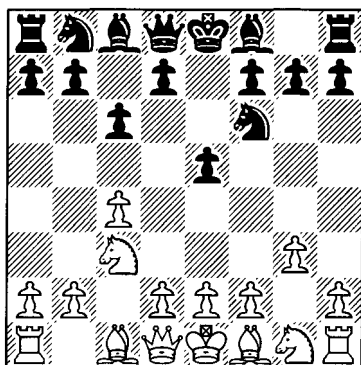


Diagram 16

Black aims for ...d7-d5

Strategies

Black takes advantage of the fact that he hasn't been compelled by 2 Nf3 or 3 Nf3 to defend the e5-pawn with ...Nc6 by preparing to build a big centre with ...c7-c6 and ...d7-d5. As a consequence he will have to accept an isolated pawn, but he gets plenty of activity.

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nc3 e5 3 g3 c6 4 d4

White prepares to answer 4...e4?! with 5 d5!, cutting off the support of the e4-pawn. Instead 4 Bg2 gives Black the chance to play 4...d5 5 cxd5 cxd5, when 6 d4 e4 gives him a solid centre. White can try 6 Qb3 but then Black has a powerful pawn sacrifice in 6...Nc6! 7 Nxd5 Nd4 8 Nxf6+ gxf6 9 Qd1 Qc7 and the threat of 10...Nc2+ is very troublesome. Black also generates activity after 4 Nf3 e4 5 Nd4 d5 6 cxd5 Qb6!? etc.

4...exd4 5 Qxd4 d5 6 Bg2

White doesn't let his opponent develop his queen's knight immediately as he can then stage a break out after 6 cxd5 cxd5 7 Nf3 Nc6 8 Qa4 d4!, which disrupts White's game after 9 Nb5 Bb4+ 10 Bd2 Bxd2+ 11 Nxd2 0-0 etc.

6...Be6 7 cxd5 cxd5 8 Nf3 Nc6 9 Qa4 Bc5!

The most active square for the bishop.

10 0-0 0-0

With a double-edged position. Let's see how Kasparov handles the black pieces.

Game 52

□ Chabanon ■ Kasparov

French Team Ch 1993

1 c4 Nf6 2 Nc3 e5 3 g3 c6 4 d4 exd4 5 Qxd4 d5 6 Bg2 Be6 7 cxd5 cxd5 8 Nf3 Nc6 9 Qa4 Bc5 10 0-0 0-0 11 Ne1?

This is just the sort of passive response the world number one was hoping for when he chose the Keres Defence. Correct is 11 Bg5 to exert more pressure on the centre. Then after 11...h6 12 Bxf6 Qxf6 White can try for an advantage with 13 Rfd1, but I am curious to know how Kasparov intended to keep the position complex against a player rated almost 400 Elo points lower after 13 e4!?, when 13...d4 14 Nd5 is bad for Black and 13...dxe4 14 Nxe4 Qe7 15 Nxc5 Qxc5 is completely equal.

11...d4 (Diagram 17)

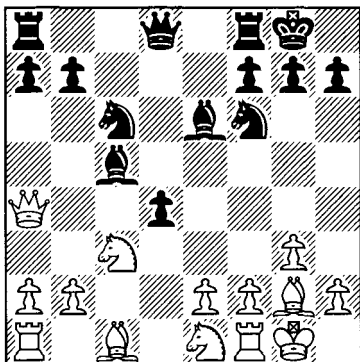


Diagram 17

Black enjoys more space

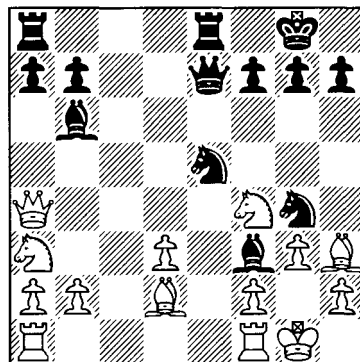


Diagram 18

Black turns the screw

It is usually a good sign for Black in an Isolated Queen's Pawn (IQP) position if he manages to advance the pawn.

12 Nd3 Bb6 13 Nb5 Bd5 14 Bh3

White wants to keep his bishop to fight for the light squares but all the time he is losing ground.

14...Re8

Now the pawn on e2 proves more of a target than the IQP.

15 Nf4 Be4 16 Rd1 Qe7 17 Na3

White's pieces are disorganised or undeveloped while almost all of Black's are ready for action in the centre. Consequently Kasparov judges the moment to be right for the commencement of a vicious attack.

17...d3!

An explosive move that clears the d4-square for the knight, the diagonal for the bishop on b6 to attack f2 and, after White's reply, the f3-square for a black bishop or knight.

18 exd3 Bf3 19 Rf1 Ng4 20 Bd2 Nce5 (Diagram 18) 21 Bg2

There are so many black pieces threatening the white king that it is no wonder a winning combination now appears.

21...Nxf2! 22 Rxf2 Bxg2 23 Kxg2 Bxf2 24 Kxf2 g5!

The decisive blow, for if the knight moves there comes the crushing 25...Nxd3+ etc.

25 Qe4 gxf4 26 gxf4 Qh4+ 0-1

White resigned as he is the exchange down with a ruined position.

An easy victory for Kasparov but note that it didn't come about because he found a combination with 21...Nxf2 – any strong player is capable of doing that. His superiority was due to his fine positional play which began with excellent opening preparation.

I hope this book has helped you to understand where the pieces are most effectively placed in the English Opening.

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starting out: the english

This book is deal for those wanting to understand the basics of the English Opening. The English is a sophisticated and popular opening system that is suitable for all types of players and can lead to both positional and tactical middlegames. Many of the world's top players, including Kasparov and Kramnik, include the English in their openings weaponry. In this groundbreaking book, Grandmaster Neil McDonald revisits the basic principles behind the English and its many variations. Throughout this easy-to-read guide the reader is aided by a wealth of notes, tips and warnings from the author, while key strategies, ideas and tactics for both sides are clearly illustrated. This book is ideal for the improving player.

- Written by an openings expert
- All the important lines are covered
- A back-to-basics look at one of the most important openings

English Grandmaster **Neil McDonald** is an experienced player on the international chess circuit, with a string of tournament successes to his name. He is a respected chess coach, who has trained many of England's strongest junior players. McDonald is also a talented chess writer and has many outstanding works to his name. Earlier Everyman books include *Concise Chess Endings* and the best-selling *Concise Chess Openings*.



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